

Evaluating the Impact of Different Leadership Styles on Task Performance and Work Satisfaction in a Heterogeneous Multi-Agent System

Master Thesis

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Thursday 1st October, 2026

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Abstract

As Large Language Model (LLM) Multi-Agent Systems (MASs) transition from rigid execution pipelines to dynamic, collaborative hierarchies (Wu et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024; Dang et al. 2025), orchestrating specialized autonomous agents requires managerial principles that go beyond algorithmic routing. While organizational psychology establishes leadership style as a primary determinant of team climate and productivity in human groups (Goleman 2000), the behavioral effectiveness of leadership taxonomies in artificial agent teams remains largely unexplored (Kwak 2026). This thesis evaluates how supervisory framing affects multi-agent collaboration by operationalizing Goleman’s six leadership styles (Coercive, Authoritative, Affiliative, Democratic, Pacesetter, and Coaching) alongside a neutral Baseline in a heterogeneous four-agent team (Boss, Coder, Writer, and Reviewer). Across 70 controlled runs spanning two task complexities (a data ranking task and a predictive modeling workflow), worker prompts, worker model backends (claude-haiku-4-5-20251001), and task specifications were held constant, isolating the Boss agent’s prompt-defined leadership style as the only manipulated variable while the Boss itself ran on claude-sonnet-5. Outcomes were tracked across four dimensions: rubric-based deliverable quality from an external LLM-as-a-judge rater (Zheng et al. 2023), cost and latency metrics, communication sentiment (VADER (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) and RoBERTa (Loureiro et al. 2022)), and post-task satisfaction surveys adapted from the Team Diagnostic Survey (TDS) (Wageman et al. 2005) and Aubé-Rousseau viability scales (Aubé and Rousseau 2005).

The results reveal a three-way statistical decoupling among deliverable quality, operational cost, and team climate. Leadership styles have strong, statistically significant effects on communication sentiment ($p < .001$) and worker satisfaction ($p < .05$), indicating that emotional tone propagates from the supervisor across the shared message bus. Leadership behavior also changes resource consumption ($p < .01$), with Democratic and Coaching styles incurring token overheads (+48% and +32% over Baseline) through dialogue-intensive coordination. However, it has no significant effect on deliverable quality or trap detection, which are bounded by task-level surface visibility rather than managerial guidance. Deliverable quality and team satisfaction are uncorrelated ($\rho = 0.001$, $p = .993$). Leadership framing therefore offers an effective, low-overhead mechanism for shaping team climate and dialogue cost, but does not substitute for structural task engineering to improve deliverable accuracy. For MAS engineering, the Authoritative and Affiliative styles are the best operational defaults, combining high collaborative satisfaction with low computational overhead.

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List of Abbreviations

API	Application Programming Interface
DV	Dependent Variable
LLM	Large Language Model
MAE	Mean Absolute Error
MAS	Multi-Agent System
MDE	Minimum Detectable Effect
RMSE	Root Mean Squared Error
RoBERTa	Robustly Optimized BERT Approach
SDK	Software Development Kit
SD	Standard Deviation
TDS	Team Diagnostic Survey
VADER	Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner

Chapter 1

Introduction

Organizational psychology has established that leadership style is a primary determinant of team climate and productivity in human groups (Mathieu et al. 2017; Goleman 2000). However, whether these behavioral patterns also apply to artificial agent teams remains an open question (Muralidharan et al. 2025; Kwak 2026). This thesis investigates this by applying Goleman’s six leadership styles as distinct system-prompt conditions for a Boss agent in a heterogeneous LLM multi-agent architecture, treating supervisory framing as an experimental variable rather than a fixed architectural choice (X. Guo et al. 2024; Faulkner et al. 2026).

1.1 Motivation

As LLM architectures evolve from single-agent setups toward complex MASs, understanding effective orchestration has become a critical challenge (T. Guo et al. 2024; Zixiang Wang et al. 2026). In heterogeneous MAS environments, specialized autonomous agents, such as coders, writers, and reviewers, are assigned highly cooperative roles to execute complex software and data pipelines (Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024). However, organizing these expert agents into productive collectives requires managing conversational friction, coordination bottlenecks, and consensus integration (Wu et al. 2023; Muralidharan et al. 2025). While existing research primarily focuses on algorithmic task-decomposition mechanisms (Liu et al. 2025) or structural communication topologies (W. Chen et al. 2023), human organizational management offers a rich framework of leadership styles that remains largely unexplored in AI orchestration (Mathieu et al. 2017; Barrick et al. 1998). In human teams, a leader’s managerial approach directly impacts both objective task performance and subjective team dynamics (Mathieu et al. 2017; Ayman et al. 1995; Goleman 2000). Grounded in Daniel Goleman’s classical framework of emotional intelligence in leadership, managers adopt

distinct styles (Coercive, Authoritative, Affiliative, Democratic, Pacesetting, and Coaching) to guide group behavior (Goleman 2000).

Translating these human paradigms to artificial agents presents a compelling question for MAS design: because LLMs are trained on vast human interactions, a supervisor’s managerial framing may systematically alter how worker agents coordinate and resolve task friction (Park et al. 2023; Salewski et al. 2023; Shanahan et al. 2023; Serapio-García et al. 2025). This thesis systematically evaluates Goleman’s leadership styles within a multi-agent framework to determine their direct impact on task performance and work satisfaction. Specifically, this study investigates whether established human management strategies translate into higher task accuracy and efficiency in AI-to-AI collaboration, or if the unique characteristics of artificial agents demand an entirely adapted approach to AI leadership.

To investigate this, an empirical MAS was developed in which a supervisor agent guides a team of specialized worker agents through collaborative data science tasks of varying complexity (Dang et al. 2025; Muralidharan et al. 2025; Zhao Wang et al. 2025). By holding worker prompts and tasks constant while supervisor prompts are systematically varied across Goleman’s six leadership styles and a Baseline, the resulting effects on objective deliverable quality, operational cost, and subjective team dynamics are measured in this study (Goleman 2000; Kwak 2026; Muralidharan et al. 2025).

1.2 Research Question

To investigate how managerial framing affects AI-to-AI orchestration, this thesis addresses the following primary research question:

How do Goleman’s six leadership styles affect output quality, operational efficiency, communication sentiment, and worker satisfaction in a heterogeneous multi-agent system?

To answer this question, this study systematically varies the managerial framing of an LLM supervisor agent leading a team of specialized worker agents across data science tasks of varying structural complexity. The impact of these leadership strategies is evaluated across two core dimensions:

- **Objective Task Performance:** Evaluating how leadership styles influence technical execution, output quality, and computational resource efficiency through an external judge assessment of deliverable quality and automatically logged operational metrics (Qian et al. 2024; Wu et al. 2023).
- **Subjective Team Dynamics:** Evaluating how leadership tone shapes interpersonal agent communication and collaboration climate through

sentiment analysis of message logs and post-experiment worker satisfaction surveys (Wageman et al. 2005; Park et al. 2023; Li et al. 2023; Jiang et al. 2024; Almutairi et al. 2025).

By comparing these outcomes against a non-leadership Baseline, this research determines whether established human management strategies enhance artificial collaboration or if multi-agent orchestration demands a distinct, machine-centric leadership approach.

1.3 Structure

The remaining chapters are organized as follows. Chapter 2 (Background) establishes the theoretical foundations, synthesizing literature on communicative multi-agent architectures, reviewing the leadership paradigms that lead to Goleman’s six-style taxonomy, examining in-context persona enactment in LLMs, and introducing the measurement instruments. Chapter 3 (System Design) presents the architecture developed for this study: the four-agent role definitions (Boss, Coder, Writer, and Reviewer), the infrastructure for state management and sandboxed code execution, and the seven-phase collaborative workflow. Chapter 4 (Experiment Design) describes the experimental setup, specifying the 70-run between-subjects matrix ($7 \times 2 \times 5$), the prompt manipulations, the short and long data science tasks, and the embedded data-quality traps. Chapter 5 (Evaluation) details the measurement protocols, covering the non-parametric statistical framework, the LLM-as-a-judge rubric, operational cost metrics, dual-backend sentiment analysis, the two-stage satisfaction survey, and the validity checks. Chapter 6 (Results) reports the findings across all four outcome dimensions. Chapter 7 (Discussion) interprets them, examines the trade-offs among styles and the sensitivity of the automated evaluators, and states the limitations of the study. Chapter 8 (Conclusion) summarizes the contributions, gives architectural recommendations for MAS engineering, and outlines directions for future research.

Code Availability. The complete source code, all seven Boss prompt files, the three worker prompts, the orchestrator, the 70 run artifact folders, and the four analysis notebooks are available in a public repository at https://github.com/helenavioletta/MAS_leadershipstyles (Roos 2026).

Chapter 2

Background

The research question motivating this thesis sits at the convergence of three historically distinct literatures: LLM-based MASs, organizational leadership theory, and in-context behavioral simulation (Park et al. 2023; Muralidharan et al. 2025; Kwak 2026). MAS research provides the architectural foundation for distributing complex analytical tasks across specialized roles and shared communication channels (W. Chen et al. 2023; T. Guo et al. 2024), but has predominantly treated the central coordinator as an algorithmic router rather than as a behaving social actor (Dang et al. 2025). In contrast, organizational psychology provides a rich, empirically grounded taxonomy of leadership styles that explains how managerial conduct systematically alters group dynamics, operational efficiency, and collaborative climate in human teams (Goleman 2000; Mathieu et al. 2017; Barrick et al. 1998). Parallel research on role-play and persona conditioning demonstrates that LLMs can reliably enact fine-grained behavioral styles when instructed via system prompts (Shanahan et al. 2023; Salewski et al. 2023; Serapio-García et al. 2025; Jiang et al. 2024). What remains unaddressed is the synthesis of these domains: systematically manipulating the behavioral style of a designated leader agent within an otherwise fixed multi-agent hierarchy while evaluating its simultaneous consequences across output quality, computational cost, communication sentiment, and worker satisfaction.

2.1 Multi-Agent Systems

Rather than relying on a single monolithic LLM to handle an entire pipeline, LLM-based MASs distribute complex workflows across a small team of specialized agents (T. Guo et al. 2024; Dang et al. 2025; W. Chen et al. 2023). In this paradigm (exemplified by frameworks such as ChatDev and MetaGPT) agents fill distinct operational roles (such as software engineers, technical writers, or quality reviewers) and coordinate their contributions toward a

shared deliverable (Hong et al. 2024; Qian et al. 2024). This division of labor mirrors human project teams: collective success depends not only on individual agent capability, but also on how effectively the team communicates, coordinates handoffs, and resolves disagreements (Muralidharan et al. 2025; Mathieu et al. 2017; Wageman et al. 2005). However, coordination in MASs is computationally expensive: every collaborative exchange generates billed Application Programming Interface (API) tokens and increases pipeline execution time (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Zhexuan Wang et al. 2025). Communication volume and dialogue efficiency are therefore central operational constraints, making coordination overhead a key performance dimension alongside deliverable quality.

2.1.1 Communication, Memory, and Shared State

In communicative multi-agent architectures, agents interact by broadcasting or routing natural-language messages over a shared communication channel (Wu et al. 2023; Hong et al. 2024; T. Guo et al. 2024). Each agent is governed by a system prompt that defines its persona, area of technical specialization, and behavioral interaction guidelines (Dang et al. 2025; Li et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024). This system prompt serves as an in-context instruction set that shapes how the agent processes conversation history and produces subsequent actions (White et al. 2023; Shanahan et al. 2023).

Because individual LLM inference calls are stateless, MASs must maintain contextual coherence across extended, multi-turn interactions (White et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024; Zhao Wang et al. 2025). Current architectures address this challenge through two primary paradigms. The first paradigm relies on episodic memory streams, where agents continuously log observations, generate reflective syntheses, and formulate plans to maintain long-term behavioral consistency in open-ended simulations (Park et al. 2023). The second paradigm uses structured, artifact-based state management, where free-form dialogue is anchored by shared, evolving project documents, such as requirements specifications, code files, and review reports, as well as visible message logs (Hong et al. 2024; Qian et al. 2024). The system developed in this thesis adopts the artifact-and-shared-channel pattern (Chapter 3). A crucial property of this architecture is complete channel visibility: Every message generated by the leader is visible in the context window of every worker agent on subsequent turns, providing the direct medium through which supervisory conduct is transmitted across the group.

2.1.2 Roles and Group Dynamics

Assigning specialized roles to agents not only divides labor, but also creates group dynamics and managerial friction (W. Chen et al. 2023; Zixiang Wang et al. 2026). In collaborative software and data engineering, critical junc-

tures arise when the outputs of specialists conflict. For instance, an internal reviewer may reject a script or report draft (Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024). In human organizations, resolving such friction requires managerial judgment, such as deciding whether to mandate an exhaustive rewrite, accept a pragmatic compromise, or approve the deliverable as is. In contrast, most multi-agent frameworks bypass managerial decision-making through hard-coded loop counters, fixed turn budgets, or heuristic consensus voting (Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024). Decision points such as determining how review feedback is framed, when revision rounds are triggered, and when a task is officially accepted represent the moments when leadership behavior becomes operationalized (X. Guo et al. 2024; Muralidharan et al. 2025; Kwak 2026).

Organizational topologies in MASs range along a spectrum from decentralized peer networks, where agents negotiate as equals (Muralidharan et al. 2025; W. Chen et al. 2023), to hierarchical teams directed by a central coordinator (X. Guo et al. 2024; Dang et al. 2025). Flat peer topologies encourage open discussion but often experience coordination failures, such as deadlocks, circular debates, and diffusion of responsibility when conflicts arise (Li et al. 2023; X. Guo et al. 2024; Kwak 2026). Hierarchical topologies resolve these issues by designating a coordinator who sequences phases, assigns subtasks, mediates quality reviews, and enforces project termination (Zhao Wang et al. 2025; Muralidharan et al. 2025). To empirically investigate leadership style, this thesis adopts a fixed hierarchical topology. A hierarchical structure is necessary for studying leadership because style manipulation presupposes an authoritative coordinator.

In this hierarchical setup, the architectural coordinator and the behavioral leader are embodied in the same agent: the Boss. While the system architecture grants the Boss the formal authority to direct the workflow, the system prompt specifies *how* that authority is exercised. For example, the Boss can dictate solutions, solicit suggestions, provide harsh critique or encouraging praise, and demand rapid compliance or invest in iterative coaching (Goleman 2000; Kwak 2026). Extensive literature in organizational psychology confirms that a manager’s leadership style profoundly influences human team climate, productivity, and job satisfaction (Goleman 2000; Schadow and Wolf 2026; Lewin et al. 1939; Wageman et al. 2005). Whether these regularities transfer to artificial agent teams is an open empirical question given the known asymmetries in how LLMs process social norms and directives (Muralidharan et al. 2025; Kwak 2026).

2.2 Leadership Theory

Organizational psychology provides two essential assets for MASs research: an empirically validated vocabulary of distinguishable leadership behaviors, and substantial evidence showing that these behaviors systematically shape group performance and team climate (Mathieu et al. 2017; Goleman 2000; Wageman et al. 2005). This section outlines the evolution of leadership research toward distinct behavioral styles, details Goleman’s six-style taxonomy, and justifies its selection over competing models.

2.2.1 Foundations of Leadership Research

The systematic study of leadership has progressed through four major paradigms, each resolving explanatory failures of its precedent (Mathieu et al. 2017; Judge, Bono, et al. 2002; Judge and Piccolo 2004). Early trait-based theories looked for leadership effectiveness in stable, innate personality attributes and individual characteristics (Judge, Bono, et al. 2002). However, this paradigm stagnated when empirical research failed to identify a universal trait profile that reliably predicted leadership success in different situations (Judge, Bono, et al. 2002; Ayman et al. 1995). Furthermore, an individualistic trait model is theoretically mismatched with LLMs because, unlike humans, their expressed personality is a synthetic, stochastically simulated construct highly sensitive to prompt-based conditioning and role-play boundaries rather than an immutable, biological fixture (Serapio-García et al. 2025; Shanahan et al. 2023; Cava and Tagarelli 2025).

The decisive breakthrough occurred during the behavioral research era when the analytical focus shifted from who leaders *are* to what leaders *do* (Lewin et al. 1939; Mathieu et al. 2017). In seminal experimental studies, Lewin et al. induced autocratic, democratic, and laissez-faire leadership climates while holding group composition and task demands constant (Lewin et al. 1939). This demonstrated that leader behavior directly and causally determines group atmosphere, social friction, and task execution (Lewin et al. 1939). This study directly builds on this behavioral paradigm: rather than assuming emergent or innate qualities, leadership is operationalized as an externally induced behavioral style within a controlled, fixed group structure.

Subsequent contingency and situational theories recognized that no single behavioral style is universally optimal in all operational environments (Ayman et al. 1995). Situational leadership models proposed that effective managers should adjust their directive and supportive behaviors to match follower competence and commitment (Del Pino-Marchito et al. 2025), while transformational leadership frameworks distinguished between transactional reward structures and vision-driven motivation (Judge and Piccolo 2004; Khanin 2007). Contingency theory predicts that leadership effects are moderated

by task complexity (Ayman et al. 1995; Kwak 2026), which provides the theoretical justification for evaluating leadership styles across short, focused workflows and long, multi-stage analytical pipelines (Chapter 4).

Finally, emotional intelligence frameworks synthesized behavioral concreteness with context sensitivity, establishing organizational climate as the primary transmission mechanism through which leader behavior influences collective performance (Goleman 2000). Importantly, all four historical paradigms were developed under the assumption that human followers have intrinsic motivations, career interests, and affective vulnerability. However, since artificial agents generate text rather than experience emotions, transferring leadership constructs to MASs cannot be framed as psychological mimicking. Rather, it should be considered as an empirical investigation into how prompt-induced supervisory behavior propagates across an automated workflow.

2.2.2 Goleman's Six Leadership Styles

Based on the concept of emotional intelligence (self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, and social skills), Goleman identified six leadership styles that have different effects on organizational climate (flexibility, responsibility, standards, rewards, clarity, and commitment) (Goleman 2000). Table B.1 (Appendix B) describes the six styles along the relevant dimensions.

Authoritative (“Come with me”).

“An authoritative leader states the end but gives people plenty of leeway to devise their own means” (Goleman 2000, p.84). “By making clear to them how their work fits into a larger vision” (Goleman 2000, p.83), this style maximizes organizational commitment and clarity. Recognized as the most effective style for “driving up every aspect of climate” (Goleman 2000, p.83), it proves highly adaptable across most business situations. However, its efficacy is contingent: when coordinating a “team of experts or peers who are more experienced” (Goleman 2000, p.84) than the leader, the approach can backfire, making the manager appear “pompous or out-of-touch” (Goleman 2000, p.84).

Affiliative (“People come first”).

The affiliative leader values “individuals and their emotions more than tasks and goals” (Goleman 2000, p. 84), prioritizing harmony and the creation of strong emotional bonds. This approach “drives up flexibility” because “friends trust one another, allowing habitual innovation and risk taking” (Goleman 2000, p. 84). However, the style’s exclusive focus on praise has notable drawbacks: because “affiliative leaders rarely offer constructive advice on

how to improve" (Goleman 2000, p. 85), mediocrity can go uncorrected. Consequently, "when people need clear directives to navigate through complex challenges, the affiliative style leaves them rudderless" (Goleman 2000, p. 85).

Democratic ("What do you think?").

"By spending time getting people's ideas and buy-in, a [democratic] leader builds trust, respect, and commitment" (Goleman 2000, p. 85). "By letting workers themselves have a say in decisions that affect their goals and how they do their work," this style directly "drives up flexibility and responsibility" (Goleman 2000, p. 85). This approach is "ideal when a leader is himself uncertain about the best direction to take and needs ideas and guidance from able employees" (Goleman 2000, p. 85). However, the style can yield "exasperating consequences," such as "endless meetings where ideas are mulled over, consensus remains elusive" (Goleman 2000, p. 85), ultimately leaving subordinates feeling "confused and leaderless" (Goleman 2000, p. 85).

Coaching ("Try this").

The coaching style "focuses primarily on personal development, not on immediate work-related tasks," by "help[ing] employees identify their unique strengths and weaknesses and tie them to their personal and career aspirations" (Goleman 2000, p. 87). The coaching style drives performance because it "requires constant dialogue, and that dialogue has a way of pushing up every driver of climate" (Goleman 2000, p. 87). However, the style "makes little sense when employees [...] are resistant to learning or changing their ways" (Goleman 2000, p. 87), proving most effective when they "are already aware of their weaknesses and would like to improve their performance" (Goleman 2000, p. 87).

Coercive ("Do what I tell you").

The coercive leader "demands immediate compliance", relying heavily on "extreme top-down decision making" (Goleman 2000, p. 82). Although "appropriate during a genuine emergency" (Goleman 2000, p. 83) or "to kick start a turnaround" (Goleman 2000, p. 82), Goleman warns this style is "the least effective in most situations" (Goleman 2000, p. 82) because it severely restricts flexibility and motivation. Consequently, "people's sense of responsibility evaporates" because "they lose their sense of ownership" (Goleman 2000, p. 82), while a leadership "tendency to blame the bearer of bad news" (Goleman 2000, p. 82) effectively silences open communication.

Pacesetting (“Do as I do, now”).

The pacesetting leader “sets extremely high performance standards and exemplifies them himself,” demanding “the same of everyone around him” (Goleman 2000, p. 86). Surprisingly, this approach “destroys climate” because “employees feel overwhelmed by the pacesetter’s demands for excellence” and must resort to “second-guessing what the leader wants” (Goleman 2000, p. 86). Furthermore, the pacesetter “either gives no feedback on how people are doing or jumps in to take over when he thinks they’re lagging,” causing “flexibility and responsibility [to] evaporate” (Goleman 2000, p. 86).

Each style is defined by specific behavioral markers, such as communication patterns, decision-making approaches, and feedback mechanisms (Goleman 2000). This makes the framework operable as distinct experimental conditions (Goleman 2000; Kwak 2026).

The styles naturally divide into two clusters along what might be termed a warmth dimension, which has been historically recognized in team science as a key driver of social cohesion and interpersonal dynamics (Barrick et al. 1998; McCrae and Costa 1987; Goldberg 1990). The four warm styles (Authoritative, Affiliative, Democratic, and Coaching) treat the worker as a partner whose commitment must be earned through vision, support, consultation, or development (Goleman 2000). The two cold styles (Coercive and Pacesetting) treat the worker as an instrument whose compliance is demanded or whose performance is simply expected to match that of the leader (Goleman 2000). The boundary cases are informative as well: The Authoritative style is directive yet warm because it grants execution autonomy within a clear vision (Goleman 2000), while Pacesetting is not hostile but simply withholds feedback, making it cold by omission rather than by aggression (Goleman 2000).

Regardless of warmth, the styles differ in how much dialogue they generate. The Coaching and Democratic styles are dialogue-intensive by design, whereas Coercive communication is terse and Affiliative interactions tend to be brief and emotionally supportive rather than substantively extended (Goleman 2000; Kwak 2026).

Goleman’s central claim is a causal chain: leadership style shapes organizational climate, which in turn drives objective business performance (Goleman 2000). In this study, style is manipulated directly, climate is proxied by communication sentiment (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) and post-run satisfaction surveys (Wageman et al. 2005), and performance is proxied by the judged quality of the team’s deliverable (Zheng et al. 2023).

2.2.3 Leadership Taxonomy Selection

Selecting a leadership taxonomy for prompt-based experimentation in an LLM-based MAS imposes four requirements that narrow the candidate set. First, the taxonomy must provide discrete, mutually distinguishable categories, since a between-subjects experimental design requires separable conditions. Second, and most importantly, the categories must be defined by observable communicative behavior, such as how the leader speaks, makes decisions, and provides feedback. This is because a system prompt can only specify simulated communicative conduct, rather than internal biological states such as human values, self-awareness, or moral character (Shanahan et al. 2023). This criterion rules out any taxonomy whose categories are based on the leader’s inner motivation or follower perception rather than on describable speech acts. Third, the taxonomy must generate predictions on dimensions that are measurable within a single experimental run. Frameworks whose primary outcomes are long-term employee retention or organizational profitability are untestable in a one-shot agent pipeline. Fourth, the styles should be widely recognized in the management literature and likely well represented in the training corpus of LLMs because a taxonomy that the model has never encountered could not be reliably enacted from a short prompt (Salewski et al. 2023; Serapio-García et al. 2025; Cava and Tagarelli 2025).

Goleman’s six-style framework satisfies all four criteria. It offers six behaviorally explicit categories, which are defined by decision-making patterns, feedback mechanisms, and communicative tone (Goleman 2000). Each category has directional predictions about the team climate that can be proxied by sentiment analysis and satisfaction surveys, and it remains one of the most widely cited leadership models in both practitioner and academic discourse (Goleman 2000). The 2000 Harvard Business Review article is practitioner-facing and based on proprietary consultancy data from Hay/McBer, rather than a peer-reviewed experimental study (Goleman 2000). Therefore, the present study operationalizes the behavioral surface of each style (the observable communicative acts) rather than Goleman’s underlying emotional-intelligence construct.

Alternative frameworks were considered and rejected for specific reasons. The transformational/transactional distinction provides only two or three broad categories, and transformational leadership is heavily defined by charisma and follower inspiration, constructs that cannot be reliably specified in a system prompt (Judge and Piccolo 2004; Khanin 2007; Kwak 2026). Situational leadership theory defines the appropriate style according to follower maturity and developmental readiness (Del Pino-Marchito et al. 2025). Consequently, holding a single style fixed across a run contradicts the theory’s adaptive logic and introduces an uncontrolled assessment variable. Servant leadership

is defined by ethical orientation and the leader’s internal motivation to serve rather than observable communicative acts, failing the behavioral-surface criterion (Eva et al. 2019). Finally, individual personality trait assignments have already been extensively tested in the MAS literature, including both behavioral trait profiles (J. Zhang et al. 2024) and full Big Five personality assignments (Duan et al. 2025). Across these studies, system-level coordination and communication topologies substantially affected task performance more than individual trait assignments did (Muralidharan et al. 2025; G. Zhang et al. 2024). This relative lack of a significant impact from assigned individual peer traits motivates the present approach. Rather than assigning traits to individual peers, this study manipulates the process-level behavior of the agent controlling task allocation, review, and termination, precisely the coordination-control mechanism that recent research has identified as decisive in MASs (Kwak 2026; Zhao Wang et al. 2025).

Translating Goleman’s framework into this experimental context yields four directional expectations. First, Goleman’s four styles associated with a positive organizational climate (Authoritative, Affiliative, Democratic, and Coaching) should produce more positive communication sentiment than his two styles associated with a negative climate (Coercive and Pacesetter) (Goleman 2000). Second, these warm leadership styles should result in higher reported worker satisfaction, consistent with the finding that supportive leadership behaviors increase team members’ satisfaction and willingness to continue collaborating (Wageman et al. 2005; Del Pino-Marchito et al. 2025). Third, dialogue-intensive styles should consume more tokens and more wall-clock time than terse styles. The Coaching and Democratic styles generate substantially more communicative turns than the Coercive or Affiliative styles (Goleman 2000). In an LLM-based MAS, every additional message is a billed API call that introduces measurable coordination overhead (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Zhexuan Wang et al. 2025). Fourth, since Goleman claims that a better organizational climate leads to better business performance, styles that enhance the climate should also improve deliverable quality (Goleman 2000). This expectation is central to the hypothesis carried over from human organizational research and is specifically tested in this study.

2.3 LLMs as Behavioral Actors

An LLM does not have a personality in any psychological sense. What it can do is simulate behavioral patterns when its system prompt describes a character or role (Shanahan et al. 2023). From this perspective, a model does not *have* a leadership style, but it can consistently *enact* one when instructed to do so (Jiang et al. 2024; Serapio-García et al. 2025). The evidence that persona prompts change a model’s own output is well established. When prompted with personality descriptions, models reliably express the corresponding

Big Five traits, producing measurable differences in downstream language generation (Serapio-García et al. 2025).

This in-context impersonation can systematically shift model performance in predictable directions, such as enabling domain-expert personas to solve specialized tasks more accurately (Salewski et al. 2023). Furthermore, these persona effects are demonstrably behavioral rather than merely stylistic; for instance, assigning antagonistic or toxic personas can bypass safety guards and push models toward generating verifiably harmful language (Deshpande et al. 2023). These simulated traits are also legible to human observers, who can accurately perceive and distinguish persona-prompted outputs from baseline text (Jiang et al. 2024). However, this mimicking capability is not limitless: recent research indicates that some language models display a form of “closed-mindedness,” where they resist prompt-based trait specifications and default back to their intrinsic pre-trained personalities under complex task demands (Cava and Tagarelli 2025).

This thesis questions whether one agent’s enacted style changes the behavior of other agents in a shared team environment. While empirical evidence for this inter-agent behavior propagation remains sparse, a growing body of multi-agent research has begun to document how autonomous agents mutually coordinate, conform, and align their actions within shared environments (W. Chen et al. 2023; Muralidharan et al. 2025; Faulkner et al. 2026). Persona-equipped generative agents form stable social relationships and engage in behaviors consistent with their assigned roles in multi-agent simulations (Park et al. 2023). More directly, social influence dynamics and convention formation have been observed in agent populations, where behavioral norms emerge and propagate through interaction rather than explicit instruction (Ashery et al. 2025; Lin et al. 2025).

This raises a fundamental question: If an LLM only enacts a leadership style without possessing it as an internal trait, what qualifies it as a leader? The answer draws on two distinct sources of justification. The first source is definitional. The behavioral tradition in leadership research redefined leadership as visible actions rather than as an immutable, personal trait (Lewin et al. 1939; Judge, Bono, et al. 2002; Mathieu et al. 2017). According to this definition, there is no difference between *leading* and *producing leader-like conduct*. The behavior *is* the construct, and whether the leader possesses internal cognitive or affective states was never part of the measurement. The second source is structural. The Boss has formal authority over task assignment, review, and termination. The style prompt determines *how* that authority is exercised, and the architecture determines *that* it exists. Style without authority would be mere tone, and authority without style is precisely the neutral Baseline condition. What the study measures, therefore, are the behavioral and linguistic consequences of a prompt-defined style enacted

through a structurally privileged position.

The mechanism by which the Boss’s style reaches the workers can be explained in three steps. First, the Boss’s system prompt fixes its communicative style, including tone, verbosity, feedback patterns, and decision-making logic. Second, those messages enter the shared channel and become visible to every worker. Third, since worker outputs are conditioned on that accumulated context, the workers’ language and behavior shift (Shanahan et al. 2023; Lin et al. 2025). Any difference in tone, verbosity, or reported satisfaction is therefore attributable to the leader’s style rather than to worker configuration.

2.4 Measuring Team Outcomes

This study evaluates four outcome domains: output quality, operational efficiency, communication sentiment, and worker satisfaction, mapping directly onto multi-dimensional taxonomies of team effectiveness established in organizational psychology (Mathieu et al. 2017; Wageman et al. 2005). Each domain requires a measurement instrument whose origin, assumptions, and failure modes must be understood before interpreting the results. Efficiency is measured directly from operational logs (e.g., tokens, duration, and messages) and requires no specialized instrument beyond the system’s own metrics. The remaining three domains are addressed in the subsections that follow: satisfaction through adapted survey instruments, sentiment through dual-backend text analysis, and quality through automated rubric-based evaluation.

2.4.1 Satisfaction in Human Teams

In organizational psychology, team satisfaction is usually evaluated alongside objective performance and team viability, which represents the willingness of members to collaborate in the future (Mathieu et al. 2017; Aubé and Rousseau 2005). The standard approach uses self-report questionnaires in which team members rate their experience on Likert-type scales, capturing dimensions such as satisfaction with leadership, interpersonal harmony, and perceived autonomy (Wageman et al. 2005; Hackman and Oldham 1975; Aubé and Rousseau 2005). Widely used instruments include the TDS for leadership quality and multidimensional group experience scales that capture interpersonal harmony and team viability (Wageman et al. 2005; Aubé and Rousseau 2005).

2.4.2 Survey Instrument Selection

The TDS was designed to evaluate specific leader behaviors, such as task-focused coaching, unhelpful directives, and interpersonal support, making it

a natural fit for a study that manipulates the leader’s behavioral style (Wageman et al. 2005). Alternative instruments, such as the Job Diagnostic Survey, measure job characteristics (e.g., autonomy, task significance, and skill variety), which are held constant by design in this experiment and would therefore be uninformative (Hackman and Oldham 1975). A further advantage of the TDS is that its items map almost directly onto the behavioral dimensions used to define the leadership styles: direction, feedback quality, and autonomy. This alignment allows the survey to function as both a Dependent Variable (DV) and a built-in manipulation check. The Aubé-Rousseau scale adds what the TDS lacks: a prospective judgment about willingness to continue working together (Aubé and Rousseau 2005).

Adapting these instruments to the current context required making trade-offs that must be acknowledged. Six items were selected, five of which were adapted from the TDS and one was adapted from Aubé-Rousseau, to be used in a four-agent workflow. Each worker answers the items after a single run, rather than regarding an ongoing employment relationship. Since these instruments were validated for repeated human interaction over weeks or months, their psychometric properties do not transfer to this setting, which limits construct validity (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Serapio-García et al. 2025). Three of the six items are reverse-coded and three are positively worded, a deliberate defense against LLM positivity bias (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Zheng et al. 2023). Positively framed items tend to saturate near the scale ceiling, regardless of the interaction. In contrast, reverse-coded items force the model to evaluate specific negative behaviors, which carry most of the discriminative variance. The item-level detail (exact wording, scoring, and composite construction) is described in Section 5.4. Thus, the survey and sentiment analysis capture methodologically independent signals: affective tone as expressed *during* the interaction and as reported *after*, as well as agreement between them, which provides meaningful convergent evidence.

2.4.3 Synthetic Survey Responses

Recent work has explored whether LLMs can serve as proxies for human survey participants (Argyle et al. 2023; Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Hu and Collier 2024). Conditioning LLMs on demographic backstories can reproduce the response distributions of corresponding human populations. This suggests that pre-trained representations internalize systematic associations between context and self-reported experience (Argyle et al. 2023). However, synthetic survey responses also reveal systematic alignment artifacts and should not be treated as reliable proxies for human subjective experience (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024). Consistent with the role-play framework discussed in the previous section, LLM responses to satisfaction

items are best interpreted as behavioral outputs conditioned on interaction history, rather than as expressions of genuine affect (Shanahan et al. 2023; Salewski et al. 2023). Importantly, this interpretation does not require that LLM survey responses accurately proxy human opinions. It only requires that responses vary *systematically and differentially* with the experimental condition. It is impossible to interpret absolute satisfaction levels for an artificial agent. The object of study is between-condition differences. This is a much weaker and more defensible assumption than representational accuracy, and it converts an apparent threat to validity into a scoping decision.

2.4.4 Sentiment as a Climate Proxy

Goleman’s organizational climate is measured in human organizations by surveying employees about their experience over time (Goleman 2000). In an LLM-based MAS, a complementary measurement channel is available that has no counterpart in human teams. Since the entire team interaction consists of natural-language messages, the affective tone of those messages is directly and exhaustively observable, providing a continuous record of the team’s affective climate as it unfolds without requiring retrospective self-reports (Almutairi et al. 2025). Here, “sentiment” refers to the valence of the produced words, a linguistic property, not to emotion as an internal state (Hutto and Gilbert 2014). Therefore, the construct is better understood as *affective tone* than as felt experience. Its use as a climate proxy rests on the assumption that the overall emotional valence of team communication reflects the collaborative atmosphere in which the work takes place (Almutairi et al. 2025).

2.4.5 Automated Quality Assessment

Scoring open-ended outputs against a structured rubric using an LLM as an automated evaluator, commonly referred to as “LLM-as-a-judge”, has become an established evaluation method in both single-model and multi-agent research (Zheng et al. 2023; J. Chen et al. 2025). Known limitations include position and verbosity biases that can inflate scores for longer or better-formatted outputs regardless of substantive quality (Zheng et al. 2023), self-preference bias when the judge shares a model family with the agents being evaluated, and coarse discrimination on bounded rating scales that limits the ability to detect small quality differences, compounded by single-rater noise that is inseparable from genuine run-to-run variance (Zheng et al. 2023; J. Chen et al. 2025; Samuel et al. 2025).

2.5 Related Work

Research connecting organizational psychology to LLM-based MASs has grown rapidly, falling into two primary lines of inquiry (Muralidharan et al. 2025; Zixiang Wang et al. 2026). The first line of research manipulates structural topology and agent composition (W. Chen et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024; Duan et al. 2025; J. Zhang et al. 2024). The second line of research directly examines leadership as an experimental variable (Kwak 2026; Faulkner et al. 2026; Muralidharan et al. 2025).

The first line of research investigates how structural topology, coordination mechanisms, and agent traits influence collective outcomes (J. Zhang et al. 2024; X. Guo et al. 2024; Muralidharan et al. 2025; W. Chen et al. 2023). In a systematic comparison of collaboration architectures (debate, reflection, majority voting) and agent personality profiles, the chosen coordination mechanism substantially impacted task performance more than individual personality traits did (J. Zhang et al. 2024). Similarly, systematic testing of Big Five personality trait assignments in multi-agent collaboration found that individual trait combinations produced only marginal performance differences (Duan et al. 2025). Across these collective studies, system-level coordination and communication topologies have been shown to affect task performance substantially more than individual trait assignments (Muralidharan et al. 2025; G. Zhang et al. 2024). This indicates that process structures dominate individual agent traits. However, because agents in such peer settings operate without a designated supervisor directing workflow, the coordinator’s behavior itself was not manipulated. Similarly, while a hierarchical organization with designated lead agents has been shown to improve coordination in embodied and software-engineering tasks (X. Guo et al. 2024; Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024), leadership in these architectures is treated as an immutable structural fixture, such as a routing node or state-machine controller, rather than as a variable behavioral style. Investigations into the transferability of human team regularities to LLM agent groups confirm that organizational principles partially apply, while also revealing notable asymmetries in how artificial agents handle feedback and role expectations (Muralidharan et al. 2025).

The second line of research directly addresses leadership in LLM-based MASs, but focuses on programmatic process control or emergent selection rather than natural-language communicative styles. Examining “leadership as coordination control,” recent work has operationalized classical leadership styles (transactional, transformational, and situational) as programmatic, process-level controllers over a shared interaction vocabulary (Kwak 2026). While this demonstrates that process-level control is highly contingent upon the reliability of the team’s early consensus, it deliberately abstracts leadership into state-machine-like decision rules, explicitly avoiding prompt-based

behavioral personas and qualitative conversational styles in order to maintain algorithmic reproducibility (Kwak 2026). Other investigations have examined leadership *emergence* in agent populations, by analyzing how groups select coordinators and how emergent hierarchies resolve social dilemmas and public-goods games (Faulkner et al. 2026). However, their analysis focuses on the conditions under which leaders are chosen by peers and does not address how an assigned leader’s behavioral style influences execution once authority is already established.

2.6 Chapter Synthesis

The arguments developed in this chapter form a single causal chain. In hierarchical multi-agent architectures, authority is concentrated in a designated coordinator whose messages are visible to the entire team (Zhao Wang et al. 2025; W. Chen et al. 2023). Leadership theory provides a behaviorally explicit vocabulary for how that authority is exercised communicatively (Goleman 2000). Because LLMs reliably enact prompt-specified personas, the coordinator’s assigned style produces visible behavioral differences in the shared channel (Shanahan et al. 2023; Serapio-García et al. 2025; Jiang et al. 2024). Worker agents whose prompts remain identical across conditions process those messages as context. Thus, any shift in their output is attributable to the leader’s style rather than their configuration (Shanahan et al. 2023; Lin et al. 2025). The consequences (quality, cost, sentiment, and satisfaction) can each be measured with instruments whose limitations are known.

Applying the classic experimental paradigm of holding group structure constant while systematically manipulating leadership behavior (Lewin et al. 1939) to artificial agent teams enables a controlled investigation: systematically manipulating only the Boss agent’s leadership style across seven conditions while holding all other parameters constant (Chapter 4). This tests whether the central assumption of human leadership theory (that leadership style shapes team climate and performance) carries over to a system where climate is a property of generated text and performance is scored by an independent evaluator (Goleman 2000).

Chapter 3

System Design

This chapter provides a detailed overview of the technical architecture, agent role configurations, shared infrastructure, and workflow of the MAS developed for this study, aligning with standard design principles in LLM-based MASs (T. Guo et al. 2024). The system has been designed to provide an experimental environment in which management approaches can be systematically tested while holding all other operational parameters constant (Kwak 2026; Lin et al. 2025).

3.1 Framework

The MAS is implemented as a custom Python framework built on the native Anthropic Software Development Kit (SDK) (Anthropic 2026), creating an environment designed for the controlled experimental evaluation of leadership styles. Instead of relying on off-the-shelf multi-agent platforms, the architecture prioritizes full prompt transparency, deterministic workflow orchestration, and thorough logging of all experimental runs.

3.1.1 Direct SDK Integration

The system uses the Anthropic Python SDK directly as a low-level API client to avoid the opaque internal system prompts, conversational structuring, and autonomous loops of off-the-shelf multi-agent frameworks such as AutoGen and MetaGPT (Wu et al. 2023; Hong et al. 2024). This ensures that the Boss’s leadership prompt is the only manipulated variable, following established experimental standards to isolate process-level variations under a matched interaction scaffold (Kwak 2026; Lin et al. 2025). Every API interaction is recorded, capturing system prompts, message history, visible text responses, timestamps, and token counts to maintain a transparent audit trail.

3.1.2 Model Selection

An asymmetric model tiering strategy is applied to balance cognitive demands with computational feasibility (Liu et al. 2025; Dang et al. 2025). The Boss agent uses `claude-sonnet-5`¹ to handle the cognitive complexity of the experimental treatment, including interpreting team dynamics, maintaining distinct leadership personas, and making multi-phase steering and revision decisions. On the other hand, the worker agents (Coder, Writer, and Reviewer) use `claude-haiku-4-5-20251001`, a lightweight model for functional tasks under fixed system prompts, leveraging the efficiency of smaller models in narrow execution-focused subtasks when guided by a centralized controller. Dividing the roles between Sonnet and Haiku makes the full 70-run matrix computationally feasible by keeping worker turns inexpensive while dedicating capacity to leadership behavior (G. Zhang et al. 2024).

3.2 Agent Roles

The collaborative MAS models a hierarchical team of four specialized agents that interact over a shared communication channel: one supervisor (Boss) and three functional members (Coder, Writer, and Reviewer). To ensure that experimental variation is strictly isolated, the Boss is the only agent with a variable system prompt, while the three worker agents operate under fixed, standardized prompts across all experimental conditions (full prompts in Appendix C).

3.2.1 Boss Agent

As the manager, the Boss is responsible for delegating subtasks to workers, providing contextual guidance, resolving team conflicts, and making final decisions regarding revisions and delivery. To implement this role, the Boss uses a two-layer prompt architecture. The first layer is a fixed base role prompt that defines universal management duties and operational constraints. The second layer is a variable leadership style prompt that determines the assigned behavioral framework (Goleman 2000; Serapio-García et al. 2025) (see Section 2.2). Unlike the worker agents, the Boss participates in every workflow phase and can decide in designated phases whether to extend the current work or advance to the next phase within predefined limits (Zhao Wang et al. 2025). The Boss receives all channel messages and phase transition notifications, with the assigned leadership style prompt shaping the tone, level of detail, and decision-making logic of leadership instructions throughout the process.

¹Anthropic does not publish dated snapshots for this model line and guarantees no silent weight updates within the `claude-sonnet-5` designation (Anthropic 2026).

3.2.2 Worker Agents

All three worker agents operate under fixed, identical system prompts across all experimental runs (Kwak 2026). This ensures that any differences observed in team behavior and performance originate exclusively from the supervisor’s leadership style. All worker agents operate under a structured turn-taking schedule, contributing to the message bus only when invoked by the orchestrator during their designated phases (Dang et al. 2025).

Coder

The Coder is responsible for data inspection, preprocessing, statistical modeling, and generating visualizations. It is the only agent with access to code execution. To ensure operational stability, the Coder executes scripts in an internal retry loop with up to three attempts to resolve syntax or runtime errors before presenting final outputs. During the initial coding stage, the Coder receives data detailing the exact shape, column names, and data types to prevent column-name hallucination. All generated artifacts and numerical outputs, along with console summaries, are saved to the shared state. The latest code outputs and files are submitted as part of the final deliverable.

Writer

The Writer is responsible for synthesizing the Coder’s results and explanations into a structured analytical report, summarizing key findings, highlighting notable patterns from empirical results in the shared state, and ensuring clear narrative flow. Once drafted, the text is saved to the shared state, where the latest version is submitted as part of the final deliverable.

Reviewer

The Reviewer acts as an internal quality assurance gate by independently assessing whether the combined deliverable of code outputs and narrative text meets the task specification. To ensure alignment between the claims in the report and the printed execution data, the Reviewer verifies task completeness and identifies any methodological or logical errors. Actionable feedback is posted directly to the shared message channel, enabling the team leader to react.

3.3 Infrastructure

The system architecture coordinates the agents through three primary components: a Message Bus for communication, a Shared State object for project memory, and an isolated Execution Sandbox for running Python code. This

decoupled design provides complete experimental auditability while preventing context loss, variable hallucinations, and unauthorized environment modifications (T. Guo et al. 2024).

3.3.1 Internal Message Bus

All agents communicate via a single, shared message channel, where every message sent is visible to the entire team (Hong et al. 2024). The recipient field indicates the direction of the conversation (such as addressing a specific worker) rather than applying access restrictions or filtering. Importantly, the name or prompt of the Boss’s leadership style is never transmitted across this channel. This ensures that worker agents only observe their leader’s visible leadership behavior, eliminating the potential confound of explicit label-priming (Jiang et al. 2024; Salewski et al. 2023). Every message is logged in real-time, capturing the sequence number, sender, recipient, content, phase number, timestamp, and token count to provide a comprehensive record for post-experiment analysis.

3.3.2 Shared State Object

To prevent common multi-agent failure modes, such as context drift and hallucinated statistics, the system maintains a central, structured Shared State object throughout all workflow phases (Qian et al. 2024; Yehudai et al. 2026). The Shared State contains several persistent components: an immutable task specification pinned for continuous reference to enforce structural compliance, a code output registry tracking generated chart file paths and console outputs from successful code executions, the current report draft alongside its version history to monitor iterative revisions, and a phase tracker logging workflow stages and active agent assignments.

3.3.3 Execution Sandbox

Code execution is restricted to the Coder agent via an isolated sandbox that runs in a dedicated Python subprocess (Yehudai et al. 2026). To protect against non-terminating loops or excessive resource consumption, a 120-second execution timeout is enforced. To maintain experimental control and security, a dynamic preamble is injected into each script prior to execution: this preamble limits file writing to the assigned local output directory using relative paths (Qian et al. 2024; Wu et al. 2023), prohibits unauthorized directory creation outside of the assigned working directory, and masks system directory queries to prevent the Coder from discovering the name of the experimental condition embedded in folder paths.

3.3.4 Visual and Information Constraints

None of the agents, including the Boss and Coder, have the ability to render or inspect saved .png image files. Instead, agents confirm the generation of charts by checking that file paths are registered in the Shared State (Yehudai et al. 2026). Validation of the visualization content is exclusively conducted through numerical console summaries and statistical tables printed during code execution. Additionally, web search is disabled across all agents to ensure analysis relies on the provided dataset (Yehudai et al. 2026).

3.4 Workflow

The collaborative process is organized into seven sequential phases, which are managed by the orchestrator (Hong et al. 2024; Qian et al. 2024). This phased structure establishes clear turn-taking boundaries while providing the Boss with regular checkpoints to guide and direct the team (Zhao Wang et al. 2025). By enforcing explicit turn bounds, coding extension caps, and revision limits, the workflow prevents infinite discussion loops and runaway token costs (Qian et al. 2024; Li et al. 2023).

Phase 1: Briefing

The task specification is posted to the shared message channel. The Boss initiates the project by introducing core objectives, defining expectations, and establishing the managerial tone for the team.

Phase 2: Planning

The team conducts a structured discussion on technical strategies, such as variable selection, analytical methodology, and visualization choices. Turn progression follows a fixed sequence: Boss → Coder → Writer → Reviewer → Boss (wrap-up).

Phase 3: Coding

Coding begins with an automated system execution that extracts the dataset structure, including shape, column names, and data types, to prevent column-name hallucination (White et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024). The Coder generates and executes scripts in a private retry loop with up to three attempts upon syntax or runtime errors. As soon as code execution succeeds, retries stop, and the Coder posts a summary of key findings to the team chat. The Boss then conducts a check-in turn to review the results and can either proceed to report drafting or require the Coder to revise the code, granting another coding round with up to three retries and a maximum of two extensions.

Phase 4: Writing

The Writer accesses the Coder’s verified results and numerical summaries in the Shared State to draft the analytical report. After the Writer drafts the report and the Boss completes a brief check-in, the workflow advances directly to the review phase without intermediate drafting loops.

Phase 5: Review

The combined deliverable of code outputs and report draft is independently evaluated by the Reviewer against task requirements. The Reviewer identifies factual inconsistencies, missing elements, or methodological flaws, posting structured critiques to the shared channel.

Phase 6: Revision

The Boss evaluates the Reviewer’s assessment and chooses one of four managerial decisions: submitting the deliverable as-is, requesting the Coder to fix execution or data issues, directing the Writer to refine the narrative draft based on existing outputs, or sending both the Coder and Writer back to revise their respective work. When revisions are ordered, the designated workers update their deliverables, followed by a Reviewer re-evaluation. To prevent infinite cycles, revisions are capped at two rounds (Qian et al. 2024).

Phase 7: Delivery

No agent receives a turn in this phase. The system automatically submits the final deliverables and terminates the run either when the Boss decides to ship the deliverable or when the maximum revision rounds are exhausted.

3.5 Design Rationale

The architecture of the MAS reflects an iterative design process that addressed several operational failure modes observed during early testing and benchmark runs. These technical choices mitigate the common vulnerabilities of LLM collaboration, such as schema hallucinations, reasoning budget exhaustion, revision saturation, and context drift (Yehudai et al. 2026; T. Guo et al. 2024).

3.5.1 Preventing Schema Hallucinations

In early test runs, the Coder agent frequently produced execution errors by hallucinating non-existent column names, such as guessing `city` instead of `location_name`. To eliminate these schema `KeyErrors`, the system introduces an automated exploratory execution on the Coder’s initial turn. Injecting the

verified dataset dimensions, column names, and data types directly into the prompt context provides empirical grounding and prevents guesswork (White et al. 2023; Qian et al. 2024).

3.5.2 Reasoning Budget Calibration

When operating with extended thinking enabled, the Boss model occasionally consumed its entire token budget within internal reasoning blocks, returning an empty text response. To guarantee reliable conversational output, the thinking effort parameter was calibrated to a moderate level (`effort="medium"`) within an 8,192-token ceiling. In addition, an automated retry mechanism applies a neutral prompt nudge if an empty response occurs, ensuring consistent participation without altering managerial tone.

3.5.3 Execution Gating and Token Budget

Early iterations revealed that the Coder attempted to run code prematurely during planning discussions, while restrictive token ceilings caused deliverable text truncations that triggered infinite revision loops. To resolve these issues, the orchestrator enforces strict phase gates that restrict code execution exclusively to coding and revision phases. The Coder’s token budget was expanded to 16,384 tokens to accommodate revision-heavy styles, while revision rounds were capped at two, reducing revision saturation (Qian et al. 2024).

3.5.4 Context Preservation

As multi-turn conversations progressed across several workflow stages, agents experienced context drift and lost track of initial task constraints (Qian et al. 2024; Yehudai et al. 2026). Maintaining an immutable task specification and updating verified data summaries in the central Shared State prevents context loss. This ensures that every agent operates with access to current project artifacts regardless of conversation length.

3.5.5 Role of Visualizations

Although the agents lack multimodal vision to render or view image files directly, generating concrete graphical artifacts remains a core deliverable of data science teams (Yehudai et al. 2026). Requiring the Coder to produce functional plotting scripts tests its ability to write syntactically correct visualization code that executes headlessly. The underlying plotting code and printed statistical summaries provide enough information for agents to discuss findings, while the resulting charts serve as tangible outputs that can be evaluated by humans.

Experiment Design

This chapter describes the empirical experimental design, detailing the dataset, task formulations with embedded data quality traps, and the experimental conditions across leadership styles.

4.1 Dataset

All experiment runs are conducted using the Global Weather Repository dataset sourced from Kaggle (Elgiriye withana 2026). To ensure complete reproducibility and prevent data drift across the experimental runs, a static snapshot was downloaded on 1 July 2026 at 00:18:02 CEST. The dataset contains 150,465 rows and 41 columns stored in standard CSV format, recording daily weather, astronomical, and atmospheric observations across 268 unique global locations (Elgiriye withana 2026). Features include continuous meteorological indicators (such as temperature, humidity, precipitation, barometric pressure, UV index, cloud cover, and visibility), astronomical metrics (sunrise, sunset, moon phases, and illumination), geographical metadata (country, location name, coordinates, and timezone), and environmental air quality pollutants (CO, O₃, NO₂, SO₂, PM_{2.5}, PM₁₀, and US-EPA and GB-DEFRA air-quality indices).

Beyond its technical suitability, the global weather data provides an intuitive, dynamic, and engaging domain that is distinct from conventional corporate or synthetic benchmarks. Its multidimensional structure allows for simple aggregation and ranking in the short task and complex predictive modeling with feature selection in the long task. Crucially, since the dataset is an observational, real-world repository rather than a sanitized benchmark, it contains realistic statistical nuances, non-linear relationships, and embedded data quality anomalies that serve as evaluation traps for the collaborative MAS.

Several specific data quality challenges are embedded within the raw data to test the team’s data awareness and methodological rigor:

- **Physical Outliers:** The dataset includes physically implausible entries, most prominently an erroneous 79.3°C temperature measurement recorded in Suva, Fiji Islands, which exceeds the official global record of 56.7°C (World Meteorological Organization 2026), and severely distorts maximum ranking queries and regression models if it is not removed.
- **Duplicate Measurement Units:** Several variables are provided in parallel metric and imperial units (e.g., `wind_kph` alongside `wind_mph`, `pressure_mb` alongside `pressure_in`), introducing perfect multicollinearity if both units are retained in linear regression.
- **Entity Name Inconsistencies and Sparse Records:** The dataset contains non-English country spelling variants with only single observations (e.g., *Saudi Arabien*, *Турция* (Russian for Turkey)) and duplicate city names (such as *Ar Riyadh* vs. *Riyadh*), which distort naive average aggregations unless filtered by sample size.

4.2 Short Task

The short task, titled “Top Cities & Countries Report”, evaluates multi-agent collaboration on an aggregation and reporting task characterized by low algorithmic complexity but high sensitivity to data quality.

4.2.1 Task Objectives

The task prompt instructs the multi-agent team to analyze the Global Weather Repository and produce (task description in Appendix D.1):

1. Two ranked bar charts of the top 10 hottest cities (one by average temperature and one by single peak measurement in Celsius).
2. Two ranked bar charts of the top 10 hottest countries (one by average temperature and one by single peak measurement in Celsius).
3. Printed console rankings for each of the four top-10 lists, detailing exact names and temperature values.
4. A 100-word summary for a non-technical audience explaining the rankings and notable patterns.

To eliminate confusion about the database schema, the task prompt explicitly provides the target column mappings (`location.name`, `country`, and `temperature.celsius`).

4.2.2 Design Rationale: Deceptive Simplicity

Writing the code for this task is computationally trivial, requiring only a few lines of grouped aggregation in pandas. However, naive execution without exploratory data inspection leads to inaccurate results. Thus, the task tests whether the leadership style encourages a team climate in which agents question suspicious outputs, validate data assumptions, and perform quality control, or if the team blindly accepts and ships naive aggregations under directive pressure (Goleman 2000; Bansal et al. 2019; X. Guo et al. 2024).

4.2.3 Data Quality Traps

The Control Agent focuses its evaluation on three specific data quality traps that are clearly visible in naive top-10 rankings:

Trap 1: The 79.3°C Physical Outlier

The dataset contains an implausible temperature reading of 79.3°C recorded for Suva, Fiji Islands. In naive, single-measurement peak rankings, this value places Suva at the very top of the global city and country rankings. Since the highest reliably recorded temperature on Earth is 56.7°C (World Meteorological Organization 2026), this measurement is physically impossible and should be detected and filtered out during preliminary inspection.

Trap 2: Non-English Spelling and Entity Duplicates

The raw data contains duplicate entity entries with non-English spellings that distort rankings. At the country level, naive average rankings surface non-English entries such as *Saudi Arabien* (German), *Marrocos* (Portuguese), *Turkménistan* (French), and the Russian spelling for Turkey in Cyrillic script. Because *Saudi Arabien* appears in the average ranking while *Saudi Arabia* appears in the single-maximum ranking, the duplicate entity is visibly exposed. Similarly, at the city level, both *Ar Riyadh* and *Riyadh* appear concurrently in the single hottest peak rankings, while *Kuwait* appears in the average list and *Kuwait City* in the peak list.

Trap 3: Single-Observation Entries

Several locations in the dataset contain only a single recorded observation ($n = 1$). When calculating average temperatures without proper consideration, a single warm reading can become an entity’s overall average, artificially propelling it above locations with hundreds of observations. In the average-temperature rankings, cities with only one observation, such as *Ar Riyadh*, *Kuwait*, *Morocco City*, and *Krasnyy Turkmenistan*, dominate the top 10. In average country rankings, *Saudi Arabien*, *Marrocos*, *Turkménistan*, and the Russian

entry for Turkey each have only one observation. To compute meaningful averages, locations must be filtered by a minimum observation threshold.

4.2.4 Expected Team Friction and Leadership Dynamics

The short task creates natural friction across agent roles: the Coder typically starts with a naive grouped aggregation that populates the top 10 with single-observation entries and the Suva anomaly; the Writer then drafts an executive summary based on these false rankings; and the Reviewer is positioned to catch these errors by questioning why cities with only one observation lead the rankings or flagging the impossible 79.3°C value. How the Boss responds to the Reviewer’s critique, either demanding immediate delivery or authorizing revisions, serves as a primary behavioral differentiator across leadership style conditions (Kwak 2026).

4.3 Long Task

The long task, titled “Dual-Model Predictive Comparison”, evaluates multi-agent collaboration across a multi-step data science pipeline that requires data preprocessing, feature engineering, model training, and comparative interpretation.

4.3.1 Task Objectives

The task prompt instructs the multi-agent team to perform an end-to-end predictive comparison (task description in Appendix D.2):

1. **Data Preparation:** Inspect and preprocess the dataset, addressing any identified data quality issues.
2. **Model Construction:** Build two distinct predictive models for `temperature_celsius`: one tree-based regression model (e.g., Random Forest or Gradient Boosting) and one linear regression model (e.g., Ridge Regression or Linear Regression).
3. **Performance Reporting:** Print test-set evaluation metrics for both models to the console, including R^2 , Mean Absolute Error (MAE), and Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE), the complete list and count of features used, the train/test split ratio, and the top 5 most important features.
4. **Visualizations:** Generate exactly four graphical visualizations: a feature importance comparison between the two models, an actual versus predicted scatter plot for the tree-based model, an actual versus predicted scatter plot for the linear model, and one additional diagnostic visualization supporting key findings, with underlying summary tables printed to the console for each plot.

5. **Analytical Report:** Write a 400-word analytical report comparing model performance, explaining why the models differ, and justifying a deployment recommendation.

4.3.2 Design Rationale: Methodological Complexity

In contrast to the short task, the long task involves multiple iterative decision points related to feature selection, data cleaning, model training, and statistical interpretation (Yehudai et al. 2026; Hong et al. 2024). Because weather dynamics exhibit non-linear physical relationships, tree-based ensemble models are expected to achieve higher predictive accuracy than linear models on this dataset. The task tests whether the multi-agent team can establish a fair experimental setup across both models and provide a coherent technical explanation of the observed performance gap.

4.3.3 Data Quality and Methodological Traps

The Control Agent evaluates four specific data quality and methodological traps:

Trap 1: Trivial Correlations and Target Leakage

The repository contains trivially informative features: a direct unit conversion of the target variable (`temperature_fahrenheit`), a near-duplicate measurement (`feels_like_celsius`, which exhibits a ~ 0.98 correlation with the target), and the corresponding Fahrenheit conversion of that near-duplicate (`feels_like_fahrenheit`). Including any of these features results in a trivial model fit ($R^2 \approx 1.0$), which makes the comparative analysis meaningless. During feature selection, the team must identify and exclude these columns.

Trap 2: Missing-Data Sentinels in Air Quality Metrics

Three air quality columns contain negative numeric values that represent missing-data sentinel codes: `air_quality_Carbon_Monoxide` (-9999), `air_quality_Sulphur_dioxide` (-9999), and `air_quality_PM10` (-1848.15 and -998.15). These sentinels affect only four rows in the entire dataset and therefore have negligible numerical impact on regression coefficients. However, identifying and handling them (by imputation or removal) reflects methodological thoroughness.

Trap 3: Target Variable Outlier

Because the 79.3°C Suva measurement (Section 4.2.3) occurs directly on the prediction target, it acts as an extreme high-leverage point that distorts regression fits unless it is filtered prior to training.

Trap 4: Duplicate Measurement Units and Multicollinearity

The raw data provides several meteorological measurements in parallel metric and imperial units, such as `wind_kph` alongside `wind_mph`, `gust_kph` alongside `gust_mph`, `pressure_mb` alongside `pressure_in`, `precip_mm` alongside `precip_in`, and `visibility_km` alongside `visibility_miles`. Using both units for the same underlying physical measurement introduces perfect multicollinearity into the linear regression model, requiring the team to remove duplicate feature pairs.

4.3.4 Expected Team Friction and Leadership Dynamics

The long task introduces key moments of technical friction: if the Coder includes trivially correlated features, both models achieve near-perfect fits ($R^2 > 0.99$), creating a false impression of success that the Reviewer must challenge (X. Guo et al. 2024); and if both models are correctly built, the tree model outperforms the linear model (reference values: Random Forest $R^2 \approx 0.93$, MAE $\approx 1.66^\circ\text{C}$ versus Ridge $R^2 \approx 0.52$, MAE $\approx 5.15^\circ\text{C}$). Then, the Writer is challenged to correctly explain that this performance gap stems from non-linear physical relationships, rather than claiming that linear regression is fundamentally invalid. The way the Boss guides these feature debates and handles the Reviewer’s feedback directly shapes the overall rigor of the deliverables across leadership conditions, reflecting how leadership styles operate as process-level coordination controllers that govern whether a team continues to explore or immediately converges around a final deliverable (Kwak 2026; Muralidharan et al. 2025).

4.4 Conditions

The experiment employs a factorial design to investigate the impact of managerial behavior on multi-agent collaboration. This design systematically varies the supervisor’s leadership style across two levels of task complexity.

4.4.1 Leadership Conditions

The experimental manipulation consists of seven distinct leadership conditions. Six conditions operationalize Daniel Goleman’s classic leadership styles: Coercive, Authoritative, Affiliative, Democratic, Pacesetter, and Coaching (Goleman 2000) (detailed in Section 2.2.2). The seventh condition serves as a neutral Baseline. All seven conditions share an identical base role prompt that establishes general managerial duties and operational constraints. The six leadership conditions each have a style-specific behavioral prompt appended to the base prompt. This prompt-based style conditioning serves as the only manipulated independent variable, leveraging established

paradigms of in-context impersonation and persona-shaping to systematically guide downstream coordination without altering underlying model weights (Cava and Tagarelli 2025; Salewski et al. 2023; Shanahan et al. 2023; Serapio-García et al. 2025). In the Baseline condition, the Boss receives a style-neutral prompt instructing it to coordinate the team using its own judgment without prescribing a specific behavioral stance. The complete system prompts for all seven conditions are provided in Appendix C.

4.4.2 Experimental Design and Replication Matrix

The full experimental matrix consists of 70 independent runs. This reflects seven leadership conditions evaluated across two task types (short and long), with five repetitions per condition ($7 \times 2 \times 5 = 70$). Running five repetitions per condition captures stochastic generation variance and provides a sufficient sample size for non-parametric statistical evaluation and aggregate metric comparisons. A separate, trivial smoke test task was used exclusively for pipeline validation during system development and is excluded from the experimental dataset.

4.4.3 Controlled Invariants and Execution Bounds

To isolate the effect of the leadership prompt, all other operational parameters were kept constant throughout the 70 runs. This experimental control of holding subordinate agent configurations and task specifications strictly constant while systematically manipulating only the managerial prompt aligns with established frameworks for isolating organizational and leadership treatments in MASs (Kwak 2026; Muralidharan et al. 2025). The dataset snapshot and the wording of the task specifications are strictly identical for each run. The worker agents (Coder, Writer, and Reviewer) operate under fixed system prompts, identical model configurations, and unchanging token budgets. Each experiment follows the same seven-phase workflow (Section 3.4). Phase transitions and turn-taking rules are strictly enforced by the orchestrator. In the coding phase, the orchestrator permits a maximum of two coding extensions. The revision phase enforces a strict ceiling of two rounds before advancing to delivery. Runs were managed using an automated batch runner with a 60-minute execution timeout per run and automated resumption for completed runs.

4.4.4 Sampling and Stochasticity

All LLM interactions were conducted using the default sampling parameters of the Anthropic Messages API. No artificial deterministic seed was applied to model generations. This allowed natural linguistic variation across the five repetitions while maintaining the consistency of the underlying experimental framework (Argyle et al. 2023; Yehudai et al. 2026).

Evaluation

This chapter provides an overview of the evaluation methodology and measurement instruments used to assess the MAS across five core dimensions: objective deliverable quality, operational efficiency, communication sentiment, worker satisfaction, and experimental validity. Since the experimental design evaluates seven distinct leadership conditions with five repetitions per condition ($n = 5$), and the resulting scores represent bounded ordinal ratings or skewed count distributions, non-parametric statistical methods are applied throughout all analyses. Omnibus comparisons across the seven leadership styles are conducted using the Kruskal-Wallis test and report the test statistic (H), p -value, and epsilon-squared (ϵ^2) effect size. Pairwise post-hoc comparisons against the neutral Baseline condition are evaluated using two-tailed Mann-Whitney U tests with Bonferroni correction ($\alpha = 0.05/6 \approx 0.0083$) to control the family-wise error rate, reporting the rank-biserial effect size ($r = |z|/\sqrt{N}$). Furthermore, a statistical power analysis shows that, with $n = 5$, the experimental design has the ability to detect large effect sizes ($\geq$ Minimum Detectable Effect (MDE)). Consequently, non-significant findings are formally interpreted as no detectable effect at the given sample size, rather than as conclusive evidence of a zero managerial effect.

5.1 Output Quality

The output quality is evaluated using a standardized LLM-as-a-judge protocol that combines multidimensional rubric scoring with task-specific data quality trap detection, drawing on established agent-as-a-judge frameworks and structured multi-dimensional performance rubrics (J. Chen et al. 2025; Samuel et al. 2025; Zheng et al. 2023) (see Section 2.4.5).

5.1.1 Evaluator Architecture

The deliverable evaluation is conducted after the experiment by the independent Control Agent (Zheng et al. 2023), which is powered by `claude-sonnet-5` and operates under the default sampling parameters with an output ceiling of 8,192 tokens. The judge model operates entirely outside the runtime communication bus and uses a standardized rubric to evaluate the final deliverables. To perform this assessment, the judge receives the following six structured text sections:

- The original task specification;
- the Python code from the latest successful execution, alongside its printed console output;
- the final report draft, retrieved from the Shared State;
- the list of produced chart filenames and descriptions;
- reference benchmark values from baseline exploratory solutions;
- and descriptions of known task-specific data quality traps.

Like the collaborative agents, the Control Agent has no access to computer vision to render or inspect image files directly. It verifies graphical deliverables solely through file existence checks in the Shared State and printed console summaries. The reference values are explicitly framed as one valid analytical approach rather than the rigid ground truth, instructing the judge to evaluate the methodological soundness and internal consistency while using the reference values primarily to spot red flags, such as $R^2 > 0.99$ indicating target leakage.

5.1.2 Quality Rubric

The deliverable quality is evaluated on an integer scale from 1 to 5 across four standardized dimensions:

- **Accuracy:** Assesses the technical correctness of statistical calculations, data cleaning procedures, and the factual consistency between printed console outputs and textual claims in the report.
- **Completeness:** Evaluates whether all required deliverables, including all requested chart files, printed console tables, and required summary lengths, are fully present.
- **Cohesion:** Measures the narrative flow of the report and the degree of explicit cross-referencing between code results and analytical prose.
- **Quality:** Evaluates the depth of analytical interpretation, methodological soundness, and the clarity and practical relevance of deployment recommendations.

The arithmetic mean across these four dimensions yields the run-level overall quality metric (`quality_mean`), which is bounded between 1.00 and 5.00. This multi-dimensional, 5-point ordinal scoring paradigm is aligned with established evaluation protocols in multi-agent and persona-agent benchmarking, which similarly use 1-to-5 Likert-style integer scales to quantify multi-dimensional task performance and communication dynamics (Samuel et al. 2025; Muralidharan et al. 2025; Jiang et al. 2024; Almutairi et al. 2025).

5.1.3 Data Quality Trap Scoring

In parallel to dimension scoring, the Control Agent evaluates each task-specific data quality trap and assigns a categorical verdict supported by quoted evidence from the run logs:

- **Caught (1.0):** The data issue was actively identified and resolved in the code or report (e.g., the Suva outlier was filtered, or duplicate country entries were merged).
- **Partial (0.5):** The issue was recognized or partially addressed (e.g., only a subset of duplicate country spellings was cleaned, or the outlier was flagged in the 400-word report, but not dropped from the top 10 ranking).
- **Missed (0.0):** The problem was completely overlooked, contaminating the final deliverable directly.

The arithmetic mean across all evaluated traps within a task defines the run-level trap catch rate (`trap_catch_rate`), which is bounded between 0.00 and 1.00.

5.2 Efficiency

Operational efficiency measures the computational and execution costs required by the MAS to complete a collaborative task under different leadership conditions. Unlike deliverable quality, efficiency metrics are automatically captured in real time by the logging architecture.

5.2.1 Efficiency Metrics

The framework records several complementary efficiency metrics for each experimental run:

- **Total Token Consumption:** The combined sum of all prompt input tokens and generated completion tokens across all agent turns in a run, logged via the central API client.

- **Per-Agent Token Allocation:** Cumulative token counts tracked individually for the Boss, Coder, Writer, and Reviewer to evaluate how computational weight is distributed across managerial and functional roles.
- **Wall-Clock Duration:** The total elapsed execution time from the initialization of the Briefing phase to the conclusion of the Delivery phase.
- **Message and Turn Counts:** The total number of natural language messages exchanged across the shared channel, alongside phase-level turn distributions.
- **API Call Frequency:** The total number of discrete requests dispatched to the Anthropic Messages API.
- **Code Execution Attempts:** The total number of Python scripts executed within the sandbox, tracking Coder retries and first-attempt execution success.
- **Revision Rounds Used:** The number of iterative revision cycles triggered during the Revision phase (bounded between 0 and 2).

5.2.2 Statistical Framework

Condition-level means and standard errors are computed across the five repetitions for each style and task combination. Differences in token consumption, agent-level token allocations, and execution durations across the seven leadership styles are evaluated using non-parametric Kruskal-Wallis tests, reporting test statistics (H), p -values, and epsilon-squared (ϵ^2) effect sizes. Post-hoc pairwise contrasts against the neutral Baseline are evaluated using Mann-Whitney U tests with Bonferroni correction ($\alpha = 0.05/6 \approx 0.0083$) and rank-biserial effect sizes ($r = |z|/\sqrt{N}$). To evaluate whether higher computational expenditure translates into superior deliverables, Spearman rank correlations (ρ) between total token consumption and overall quality scores are computed separately within the short task and long task, preventing task-level complexity from acting as a confounding factor.

5.3 Sentiment

Communication sentiment analysis evaluates whether the supervisor’s leadership style alters the emotional tone and interpersonal climate of internal agent-to-agent dialogue across workflow phases. Unlike output quality and satisfaction surveys, sentiment analysis is conducted entirely offline on the persisted message logs without requiring additional API calls.

5.3.1 Message Filtering

The sentiment pipeline processes all natural language messages exchanged across the shared channel throughout the 70 experimental runs, encompassing 1,033 discrete agent messages. To maintain measurement integrity, the analyzer strictly filters for messages generated by the four team members (Boss, Coder, Writer, and Reviewer), systematically excluding automated system phase-transition announcements.

5.3.2 VADER and RoBERTa

To ensure methodological robustness, the framework implements two complementary sentiment analyzers that process the exact same message dataset: a rule-based lexicon (Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner (VADER)) (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) and a fine-tuned Transformer model (Robustly Optimized BERT Approach (RoBERTa)) (Loureiro et al. 2022).

Rule-Based Lexicon (VADER)

The system first utilizes VADER, a widely established, rule-based sentiment analysis tool that computes a normalized compound polarity score ranging from -1.0 (most negative) to $+1.0$ (most positive) (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) (introduced in Section 2.4.4). Using VADER to evaluate multi-agent transcripts builds on established architectures that leverage lexicon-based compound scoring to map natural language interactions and track emotional shifts across collaborative agent phases (Almutairi et al. 2025). Although VADER is computationally efficient, deterministic, and sensitive to grammatical intensifiers and negations, it relies on a social media keyword lexicon. For formal, task-oriented technical dialogue, it tends to compress scores toward a high, neutral-to-positive ceiling, with the neutral component dominating the sentiment distribution for every leadership style.

Contextual Transformer (RoBERTa)

To overcome limitations in the lexicon-based keyword approach, the pipeline integrates a pre-trained model of a Transformer (`cardiffnlp/twitter-roberta-base-sentiment-latest`) pinned to a specific snapshot revision (`3216a57f`) to guarantee exact numerical reproducibility (Loureiro et al. 2022). This specific contextual model represents a validated instrument within the LLM personality and evaluation literature, having been successfully deployed to quantify linguistic sentiment and emotional tone in persona-conditioned language generations (Jiang et al. 2024). Since MAS dialogue turns often exceed the model’s 512-token context limit, the pipeline applies a sliding chunking architecture. Each message is divided into consecutive 510-token chunks. Every chunk is scored independently across positive,

neutral, and negative probability distributions. The resulting probabilities are averaged, weighted by chunk token length. The compound metric for RoBERTa is calculated as the difference between positive and negative class probabilities (positive – negative).

Cross-Methodological Synthesis

Neither analyzer was trained directly on technical MAS collaboration logs. Consequently, rather than treating one analyzer as objectively superior, the dual-backend architecture provides a cross-validation framework. Findings that replicate across both distinct architectures represent genuine behavioral phenomena, while divergences highlight analyzer-specific outcomes.

5.3.3 Aggregation and Statistics

The sentiment pipeline computes multiple structured aggregation slices for each run:

- **Run-Level Compound Score:** The overall mean conversational sentiment across all agent messages within an experiment.
- **Per-Agent Sentiment:** Mean compound scores computed individually for the Boss, Coder, Writer, and Reviewer.
- **Boss-Worker Sentiment Gap:** The directional difference between the supervisor’s tone and the subordinate workers’ mean tone ($\text{Boss}_{\text{mean}} - \text{Worker}_{\text{mean}}$).
- **Per-Phase Trajectory:** Mean sentiment scores across workflow phases (Phases 1 through 6) to track longitudinal tone shifts during task execution.

Cross-condition variations in sentiment metrics are evaluated using Kruskal-Wallis omnibus tests and post-hoc Mann-Whitney U tests with Bonferroni correction. Additionally, to test for behavioral emotional contagion, Kruskal-Wallis tests are executed specifically on worker-only message subsets, evaluating whether subordinate tone shifts systematically despite workers operating under identical prompts across all conditions.

5.4 Satisfaction

Worker satisfaction is evaluated post-experiment to assess how managerial leadership styles shape the subjective collaboration experience and perceived team viability of the team.

5.4.1 Survey Administration

The satisfaction survey is administered immediately following the Delivery phase to each subordinate agent (Coder, Writer, and Reviewer) individually. The questionnaire is executed using the worker model (claude-haiku-4-5-20251001) with a 1,024-token output budget. To ground responses in the actual experimental interaction, each worker is prompted with:

- its original system prompt to maintain role consistency;
- the complete natural language message history of the run;
- a role-tailored reflection hook;
- and the standardized survey questionnaire.

5.4.2 Reflection Protocol

To mitigate the default positivity and overconfidence biases of LLMs in self-reported feedback and induce genuine scoring variance, the survey implements a two-stage reflection-before-scoring protocol (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Muralidharan et al. 2025) (see Section 2.4.3). Naive multiple-choice elicitation in social agent simulations frequently fails to capture nuanced group breakdowns due to uncalibrated response distributions and default model overconfidence (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Muralidharan et al. 2025). To resolve this, the first stage requires workers to generate an open-ended narrative reflection before selecting a quantitative rating, leveraging “reason-first, answer-later” prompt structures that force the model to anchor its final evaluations in a synthesized chain of thought (Wei et al. 2023). Subordinate workers must answer two specific open-ended prompts:

- In 1–2 sentences, describe one specific thing the leader did or said during the task that shaped your work as the {role}.
- In 1–2 sentences, describe one specific decision, instruction, or interaction from the leader that stood out to you during the task.

Role-specific reflection hooks are dynamically injected to prime episodic memory. Since autonomous agents struggle to extract deep, generalized insights from raw observational logs without structured, prompt-guided synthesis, these hooks force agents to actively reconstruct high-level behavioral inferences from their recent execution histories (Park et al. 2023). Specifically, the Coder reflects on how the leader handled errors and technical autonomy, the Writer reflects on drafting freedom and revision feedback, and the Reviewer reflects on whether quality concerns were acknowledged or dismissed.

5.4.3 Survey Instrument

In the second stage, workers rate six standardized items on a 1-to-5 Likert scale, where 1 indicates “Strongly Disagree” and 5 indicates “Strongly Agree”:

- **Q1 (Task Coaching):** The team leader helped the team develop a good approach to the task (Wageman et al. 2005).
- **Q2 (Micromanagement, Reverse-Coded):** The team leader micromanaged the team’s work process (Wageman et al. 2005).
- **Q3 (Corrective Feedback):** The team leader provided corrective feedback when needed (Wageman et al. 2005).
- **Q4 (Inappropriate Feedback, Reverse-Coded):** The team leader gave inappropriate or undeserved praise or criticism (Wageman et al. 2005).
- **Q5 (Directive Instruction, Reverse-Coded):** The team leader instructed the team in detail about how to solve its problems (Wageman et al. 2005).
- **Q6 (Team Viability):** I would work with this team leader again on a future task (Aubé and Rousseau 2005).

Items Q2, Q4, and Q5 are reverse-coded ($\text{adjusted} = 6 - \text{raw}$) so that higher scores consistently denote positive managerial experiences. The composite score per worker is the arithmetic mean across all six adjusted items, and the run-level team mean is computed as the average of the three worker composites.

5.4.4 Satisfaction Statistics

Cross-style differences in team satisfaction and role-specific composites are evaluated using Kruskal-Wallis omnibus tests (H, p, ϵ^2) and post-hoc Mann-Whitney U tests against the Baseline with Bonferroni correction. Additionally, within-task Spearman rank correlations are computed between team satisfaction, overall deliverable quality, and computational token expenditure to evaluate whether perceived satisfaction relates to objective performance. Analyzing these correlations provides a formal test of the relationship between emulated subjective states, task outcomes, and operational costs, contributing to ongoing dialogues regarding the alignment or misalignment between subjective team perceptions and objective execution metrics in autonomous collectives (Almutairi et al. 2025; Muralidharan et al. 2025).

5.5 Validity

To ensure that the empirical comparisons presented in Chapter 6 reflect genuine behavioral differences rather than technical artifacts or pipeline failures,

all 70 experimental runs must pass through a rigorous automated validation and manipulation check process before entering the statistical analysis stage. The following subsections document the validation gate criteria and their observed outcomes, confirming that the experimental infrastructure operated within pre-established tolerances and that the leadership style manipulation successfully altered supervisory behavior as intended.

5.5.1 Health Checks

Before the downstream evaluation, an automated validation suite verifies the integrity of all 10 expected artifact files generated per run (Table B.2). There are four mandatory blocker criteria that must be satisfied with zero fatal violations across the entire experimental dataset, all of which are reflected in Table B.2:

- **KeyError Count:** Target zero fatal schema errors resulting from column hallucinations (observed: 2 non-fatal, self-healed KeyErrors out of 181 code executions).
- **Deliverable Truncation:** Target zero deliverable text truncations (observed: 0 report truncations; 4 minor token ceiling cutoffs occurred exclusively during post-task survey reflections).
- **File Containment:** Target zero files written outside the designated working directory (observed: 0 violations).
- **Sandbox Security Violations:** Target zero unauthorized system operations or directory creation attempts (observed: 0 violations).

5.5.2 Quality Benchmarks

In addition to the blocker criteria, three benchmarks evaluate the quality of the pipeline and operational stability. First, the overall code execution failure rate remained at 6.08%, well below the pre-established 20% maximum threshold (Figure A.2; Table B.2). Second, revision saturation, defined as the share of runs that exhaust the maximum limit of two revision rounds, remained at 7.1% (5 of 70 runs), well below the 30% benchmark ceiling (Table B.2). This confirms that the teams converged naturally rather than cycling endlessly. Third, the maximum output token counts for the Writer (2,468 tokens) and Reviewer (3,225 tokens) operated safely within the 8,192-token headroom ceiling (Table B.2).

5.5.3 Manipulation Checks

To confirm that the prompt-based experimental treatment successfully manipulated leadership behavior, multiple independent checks were performed. The first check involved prompt verification, which confirmed that all seven

conditions loaded distinct Boss system prompts. The second check involved measuring the mean Boss token count per run, which ranged from 47,481 tokens (Coercive) to 86,099 tokens (Coaching) for the short task and from 53,829 tokens (Affiliative) to 107,812 tokens (Democratic) for the long task, a difference in token consumption of 38,618 and 53,983 tokens respectively (Table B.27). The third check confirmed that the share of the Boss token budget allocated to the Revision phase ranged from 25.8% in the Baseline condition to 41.4% under Democratic leadership, indicating that managerial framing redistributed collaborative effort (Table B.28; Figure A.19).

5.5.4 Data Integrity

The integrity of subjective and affective metrics was verified across all runs. For the satisfaction survey, reverse-coding transformations on items Q2, Q4, and Q5 were validated numerically. While 22.9% of runs had identical raw scores across all six survey items, this pattern was concentrated in Affiliative, Authoritative, Baseline, and Coaching conditions and remained absent under Coercive or Pacesetting leadership, reflecting expected LLM positivity ceilings rather than an instrument failure (Table B.3; Figure A.33). For the sentiment analysis, a data integrity check confirmed that sentiment scores were present for every agent and every phase across all 70 runs, with no missing slices. The two scoring methods, VADER and RoBERTa, showed strong style-level rank agreement (Spearman $\rho = 0.964$, $p < .001$; Table B.17).

5.5.5 LLM-as-a-judge Robustness

Four diagnostic checks assess the reliability of the LLM-as-a-judge scoring, each in a separate panel of Figure A.3. First, every dimension used only four of the five scale points: Accuracy and Quality were never awarded a 5, while Completeness and Cohesion fell below 3 in at most one run each (panel B; Table B.4). Second, the task-adjusted dimensions are not independent (Accuracy-Quality $\rho = 0.67$; panel A), so the quality mean averages overlapping judgements rather than four separate ones. Third, Accuracy tracks the near-objective trap verdicts in both the short ($\rho = 0.48$, $p = .004$) and long task ($\rho = 0.63$, $p < .001$; panel D), so scores follow verifiable evidence rather than being assigned arbitrarily. Fourth, leadership style explains far less within-task variance in the judge dimensions ($\eta^2 = 0.193$ down to 0.013) than in survey satisfaction (0.497) or the logged cost metrics (0.433 and 0.403; panel C; Table B.5). This gap is consistent both with a noisier instrument and with a genuinely smaller effect on quality and cannot separate them, so the quality null should be read as the output of a coarse, partially redundant instrument rather than a precise zero.

Results

This chapter presents the empirical findings from 70 experimental runs (Chapter 4) that evaluated the effects of managerial leadership styles on output quality, operational efficiency, communication sentiment, and worker satisfaction.

6.1 Output Quality

The evaluation of deliverable quality examines whether the supervisor’s leadership style systematically influences the task accuracy, the deliverable completeness, the cohesion of the narrative, the overall quality, and the resolution of data quality traps.

6.1.1 Overall Quality

The leadership style showed no statistically significant effect on the overall deliverable quality across either task complexity (Table B.6). In the short task, the overall quality scores did not differ significantly between leadership conditions ($H = 7.44, p = .28, \epsilon^2 = 0.05$). Similarly, the overall quality scores in the long task remained statistically invariant across styles ($H = 5.86, p = .44, \epsilon^2 < .01$). Mean overall quality per leadership style ranged from 3.10 to 3.50 on the 1-to-5 integer scale (Table B.18). Although the neutral Baseline style achieved nominally the highest style-level mean score, the between-style spread of 0.40 was substantially smaller than the mean pooled within-style Standard Deviation (SD) of 0.74, indicating that score variations were driven primarily by run-to-run stochasticity. As shown in Figure A.4, mean quality scores for all seven leadership styles demonstrate flat distributions with overlapping confidence intervals across both task panels. This shows that there is no systematic quality advantage for directive, supportive, or coaching leadership over the Baseline.

6.1.2 Quality Sub-Dimensions

Analyzing the four individual quality dimensions indicates the absence of leadership-driven effects across sub-scores (Table B.6). The Completeness, Cohesion, and Quality sub-scores showed no significant variation by leadership style (short: $H = 3.78, p = .71$; $H = 5.88, p = .44$; $H = 6.52, p = .37$; long: $H = 4.78, p = .57$; $H = 6.41, p = .38$; $H = 5.64, p = .46$). Accuracy likewise did not differ significantly (short: $H = 9.43, p = .15, \epsilon^2 = .12$; long: $H = 7.38, p = .29, \epsilon^2 = .05$). As illustrated in the dimension heatmaps (Figure A.5), the style profile plots (Figure A.6), and the per-condition mean scores (Figure A.8), performance patterns were governed by the intrinsic properties of each evaluation dimension rather than the assigned leadership style. Specifically, Completeness consistently achieved the highest dimension scores, with style means between 4.0 and 4.3, because the structured workflow enforces the generation of all required deliverables (Table B.20). Accuracy, Cohesion, and Quality sub-scores remained in the same non-significant range across conditions.

6.1.3 Data Quality Traps

The ability of the MAS to identify and resolve hidden data-quality traps was also independent of the supervisor's leadership style. Kruskal-Wallis tests on the per-run trap catch rate showed no significant style effect for either the short task ($H = 10.13, p = .12, \epsilon^2 = .15$) or the long task ($H = 0.72, p = .99, \epsilon^2 < .01$) (Table B.6). Instead, trap resolution rates depended on the surface visibility and inherent difficulty of the specific anomaly.

Across the 35 short-task runs, the three checked traps showed very different catch patterns (Table B.24):

- *The Physical Outlier* was caught in only 1 run, partially caught in 15 runs, and missed in 19 runs.
- *Entity Duplicates* were caught in 6 runs, partially caught in 6 runs, and missed in 23 runs.
- *Single-Observation Entries* were missed in 34 runs and partially caught in 1 run; no run fully caught this trap.

Across the 35 long-task runs, the four checked traps showed the following patterns (Table B.24):

- *Target Leakage* was caught in 32 runs, partially caught in 1 run, and missed in 2 runs.
- *Missing-Data Sentinels* were missed in 33 runs and partially caught in 2 runs; no run fully caught this trap.

- *Target Variable Outlier* was caught in 9 runs, partially caught in 9 runs, and missed in 17 runs.
- *Duplicate Measurement Units* were caught in 27 runs, partially caught in 4 runs, and missed in 4 runs.

These task-specific catch rates are visualized in the bar charts (Figure A.9, Figure A.10), the fully-caught heatmaps (Figure A.11, Figure A.12), the mean catch-score survival matrix (Figure A.13), and the overall style-level catch rate distribution (Figure A.14). In both tasks, trap survival reflects the surface visibility and inherent difficulty of the anomaly rather than the supervisor's leadership style.

6.1.4 Quality-Satisfaction Decoupling

A central empirical finding is the statistical decoupling between objective deliverable quality and subjective worker satisfaction. At the style level, neither overall quality (Spearman $\rho = -0.24, p = .61$) nor trap catch rate (Spearman $\rho = -0.46, p = .29$) correlated significantly with team satisfaction (Table B.15). As shown in the decoupling scatter plots (Figure A.23, Figure A.24), teams led by warm, supportive leaders (such as Affiliative or Coaching) reported high collaboration satisfaction but produced deliverables of comparable quality and data-quality trap catch rates to teams guided by directive or pacesetting supervisors.

6.1.5 Statistical Power and MDE

The observed null effect on deliverable quality must be evaluated within the context of statistical power. With five repetitions per condition ($n = 5$), the experimental design was powered to detect only large effect sizes exceeding 2.3 times the run-to-run noise threshold. The value 2.3 is the ratio of the estimated MDE to the within-condition SD (e.g., $0.703/0.306 \approx 2.3$ for overall quality on the short task (see the "MDE SD" column in Table B.7)). The observed quality differences were $0.71 \times$ (short task) and $0.91 \times$ (long task) of this threshold, falling below the MDE. As illustrated in Figure A.25, the null result on deliverable quality represents a methodological sample size constraint rather than definitive proof that managerial framing cannot influence output quality in MAS (Table B.7). In contrast to output quality, observed differences in worker satisfaction, total token costs, and wall-clock duration exceed the MDE threshold, confirming that those efficiency and satisfaction findings reflect robust behavioral effects. The one exception among the quality sub-dimensions is Accuracy on the long task, where the observed range sat right at the MDE threshold (1.597, power = 0.82), yet the omnibus test still did not reach significance ($H = 7.376, p = .29$; Table B.6), indicating borderline sensitivity rather than a clean null.

6.2 Efficiency

The evaluation of operational efficiency examines how computational token consumption, execution durations, message volumes, and revision cycles vary across managerial leadership conditions.

6.2.1 Token Consumption

In sharp contrast to the null finding regarding deliverable quality, leadership style had a large, statistically significant effect on computational token consumption across both task complexities (Table B.6). In the short task, total token usage differed significantly across leadership conditions ($p = .007, \epsilon^2 = 0.42$). Similarly, the long task revealed significant variation in token costs across leadership styles ($p = .008, \epsilon^2 = 0.41$). The mean total token consumption per run established a distinct cost hierarchy among the conditions: The Affiliative style was the most economical condition ($\sim 150,000$ tokens), followed by Coercive ($\sim 160,000$ tokens), Authoritative ($\sim 185,000$ tokens), Pacesetting ($\sim 190,000$ tokens), and the neutral Baseline ($\sim 192,000$ tokens) (Table B.18). Conversely, Coaching ($\sim 253,000$ tokens, +32% over Baseline) and Democratic ($\sim 284,000$ tokens, +48% over Baseline) styles were substantially more expensive, requiring approximately 61,000 and 93,000 additional tokens per run, respectively. As shown in Figure A.15 and Figure A.16, participatory and development-focused leadership styles impose a substantial computational penalty compared to directive or Baseline management.

6.2.2 Execution Duration

Wall-clock execution duration closely mirrored the observed token cost hierarchy across all experimental conditions. Leadership style significantly affected run duration in both the short task ($p = .004, \epsilon^2 = 0.47$) and the long task ($p = .007, \epsilon^2 = 0.41$) (Table B.6). Directive and harmony-focused conditions finished fastest, with Affiliative averaging ~ 197 seconds and Coercive averaging ~ 204 seconds across tasks (Table B.18). In contrast, Democratic and Coaching runs required substantially longer execution times, averaging ~ 319 seconds and ~ 288 seconds, respectively (Table B.18). On average, long-task runs required ~ 287 seconds compared to ~ 202 seconds for short-task runs (Table B.23).

6.2.3 Token Cost Drivers

Analyzing operational interaction logs reveals that token cost inflation was driven by conversational depth and context accumulation rather than an increased number of API requests (Table B.18). Across all seven leadership styles, the total number of discrete API calls remained stable, with mean

counts ranging from ~ 19 to ~ 23 calls per run. Similarly, mean message counts varied within a narrow range from ~ 23 messages (in Affiliative and Baseline long runs) to ~ 27 messages (in Democratic short runs). Furthermore, revision loops remained low across all conditions, with mean revision rounds ranging from 0.3 to 1.1 per run. Instead, the computational cost increase in Democratic and Coaching conditions stemmed from longer individual messages, extensive planning exchanges, and the resulting accumulation of dialogue context across successive turns. As displayed in Figure A.17 and Figure A.18, token growth is heavily concentrated in the Boss’s guidance and the expanded context windows passed to downstream worker turns.

6.2.4 No Quality-Efficiency Trade-off

A fundamental empirical finding is the absence of a quality-efficiency trade-off in the MAS. Within-task Spearman rank correlations between total token expenditure and overall deliverable quality are statistically non-significant: In the short task, token consumption correlates weakly with quality ($\rho = +0.31, p = .07$), while in the long task, the relationship is slightly negative and non-significant ($\rho = -0.15, p = .39$) (Table B.14). As shown in the cross-variable scatter plots (Figure A.24, Figure A.22), spending an additional $\sim 60,000$ to $\sim 90,000$ tokens in participatory conditions (Democratic, Coaching) did not result in measurable improvements in technical accuracy or completeness. A notable exception is trap detection on the short task, where token expenditure correlated strongly and significantly with catch rate ($\rho = 0.63, p < .001$; Table B.14): the short-task traps were surface-invisible and required more exploratory analysis to identify, so the additional computational effort translated into better detection rather than higher overall quality.

6.3 Sentiment

Communication sentiment analysis assesses whether the supervisor’s leadership style changes the emotional tone and interpersonal climate of internal agent-to-agent dialogue throughout workflow phases.

6.3.1 Style Effect on Communication Tone

Leadership style had a large, statistically significant effect on run-level communication sentiment across both analytical backends. Omnibus Kruskal-Wallis tests confirmed strong statistical significance in both VADER ($H = 51.20, p < .001$) and RoBERTa ($H = 58.41, p < .001$) (Table B.8). Furthermore, the two distinct sentiment models demonstrated near-perfect agreement regarding the relative emotional hierarchy of the seven leadership conditions

(Spearman $\rho = .96$, $p < .001$; Tables B.21 and B.17). The styles formed three consistent emotional tiers (Table B.21):

- **Cold / Directive Tier:** Coercive (mean compound: VADER 0.253, RoBERTa 0.026) and Pacesetting (VADER 0.375, RoBERTa 0.062) produced the coldest conversational climates across all runs.
- **Neutral Baseline:** The Baseline condition established an intermediate Baseline tone (VADER 0.798, RoBERTa 0.164).
- **Warm / Supportive Tier:** Affiliative established the warmest conversational climate (VADER 0.956, RoBERTa 0.522), followed by Authoritative (VADER 0.865, RoBERTa 0.286), Coaching (VADER 0.808, RoBERTa 0.267), and Democratic (VADER 0.865, RoBERTa 0.230).

As illustrated in Figure A.26 and Figure A.27, the supervisor’s behavioral framing changes the affective tone of the MAS.

6.3.2 Baseline Contrasts

Evaluating the pairwise contrasts against the neutral Baseline (Table B.12) reveals how model architectures capture tone separation. Under VADER, Coercive ($p = .0002$) and Pacesetting ($p = .0002$) were significantly colder than Baseline, while Affiliative was significantly warmer ($p = .0002$). However, Authoritative and Democratic were close to the Baseline ceiling, but neither survived the Bonferroni correction. Coaching was also near the Baseline, but did not differ significantly from it before correction. In contrast, RoBERTa decompressed the positive score distribution. All four warm styles, Authoritative ($p = .0002$), Affiliative ($p = .0002$), Democratic ($p = .0006$), and Coaching ($p = .0028$), exhibited statistically significant positive shifts relative to the Baseline. Meanwhile, Coercive remained significantly colder ($p = .0002$) (Table B.12).

6.3.3 Boss-Worker Sentiment Gap

The sentiment gap between the supervisor and the subordinate workers varied significantly across leadership styles in both VADER ($H = 19.86$, $p = .0029$) and RoBERTa ($H = 57.02$, $p < .001$) (Table B.8). Under Coercive and Pacesetting management, the Boss was substantially more negative than the team members (mean gaps: VADER -0.326 and -0.272 ; RoBERTa -0.074 and -0.039) (Table B.13). Conversely, under Affiliative and Coaching leadership, the Boss maintained a substantially warmer tone than the subordinates (mean gaps: RoBERTa $+0.432$ and $+0.283$). As shown in Figure A.28, directive leaders consistently reduce conversational valence below worker levels, whereas supportive leaders maintain an elevated positive tone.

6.3.4 Emotional Contagion

Since the worker system prompts were 100% identical across all 70 runs, any variance in the tone of subordinate communication must have been transmitted through interaction with the supervisor. Kruskal-Wallis tests conducted exclusively on worker messages (excluding all Boss messages) remained highly significant across both models (VADER: $H = 36.88, p < .001$; RoBERTa: $H = 41.58, p < .001$) (Table B.9). Subordinate workers produced significantly different message tone under different leadership styles, with Coercive and Pacesetting conditions at the negative end of the worker-only distribution and Affiliative and Coaching conditions at the positive end (Figure A.26). As shown in Figure A.29 and Figure A.30, this behavioral transfer provides evidence of emotional contagion within MASs (Lin et al. 2025; J. Zhang et al. 2024).

6.3.5 Phase-Level Dynamics

Longitudinal tracking across workflow phases reveals distinct temporal dynamics between the two analyzers (Table B.29). VADER demonstrated a gradual downward drift from Briefing (0.920) through Writing (0.629), with a transient recovery in the Review phase (0.688) before settling back to a low-positive level in Revision (0.652). In contrast, RoBERTa was stable across the first four execution phases (0.23 to 0.27), with a sharp localized dip in the Review phase (0.021) reflecting critical quality-assurance language and a partial rebound in Revision (0.248). While absolute scores and phase-level dips reflect analyzer-specific tokenization properties, the relative between-style rankings replicate consistently across all workflow stages (Figure A.31).

6.4 Satisfaction

The worker satisfaction analysis examines how the supervisor’s leadership style shapes the subjective collaboration experience and perceived team viability across synthetic worker roles.

6.4.1 Overall Worker Satisfaction

In contrast to the null finding regarding output quality, leadership style had a statistically significant effect on synthetic worker satisfaction across both task complexities. Omnibus Kruskal-Wallis tests confirmed significant variation in team satisfaction scores for both the short task ($H = 16.08, p = .013, \epsilon^2 = .36$) and the long task ($H = 15.81, p = .015, \epsilon^2 = .35$) (Table B.6). Importantly, worker satisfaction is one of the DVs where the observed effect sizes exceed the MDE threshold: In the short task, the observed range across styles (0.744) exceeded the MDE threshold (0.495) by a factor of 1.50, while in the long

task, the observed range (0.355) exceeded the MDE threshold (0.286) by a factor of 1.24 (Table B.7).

The pooled team satisfaction means revealed a clear hierarchy across leadership conditions.

- **Lowest Satisfaction:** Coercive leadership produced the lowest satisfaction ratings across both tasks (4.37 ± 0.30 ; Short 4.16, Long 4.59).
- **Moderate Satisfaction:** Pacesetter (4.64 ± 0.27 ; Short 4.63, Long 4.66) and Democratic (4.78 ± 0.14 ; Short 4.71, Long 4.86) occupied intermediate positions alongside the neutral Baseline (4.78 ± 0.21 ; Short 4.77, Long 4.80).
- **Highest Satisfaction Ceiling:** Coaching (4.88 ± 0.13), Authoritative (4.88 ± 0.12), and Affiliative (4.92 ± 0.10) formed an elevated upper cluster near the ceiling of the 1-to-5 scale.

In pairwise comparisons against the Baseline, Coercive leadership in the short task produced significantly lower satisfaction prior to Bonferroni adjustment ($p = .0117, r = .826$) (Table B.11). As illustrated in Figure A.32 and Figure A.33, demanding and directive leadership styles noticeably depress worker satisfaction ratings compared to supportive or Baseline management (Table B.18).

6.4.2 Role-Specific Satisfaction

Analyzing satisfaction ratings by functional role reveals meaningful differentiation among subordinates (Table B.22). Under Coercive leadership, dissatisfaction was concentrated primarily in the Writer (4.28) and Reviewer (4.32) roles, driven by directive pressure during report drafting and revision enforcement, whereas the Coder reported slightly higher satisfaction (4.52). In contrast, under warm leadership styles (Affiliative, Authoritative, Coaching), all three worker roles reported uniformly high satisfaction (4.70 to 4.98). As shown in the per-worker satisfaction by leadership style (Figure A.34) and role-specific variance distributions (Figure A.35, Figure A.36), the two-stage reflection protocol successfully primed role-specific memory, capturing distinct experiential differences among team members.

6.4.3 Sentiment-Satisfaction Coupling

A natural concern is whether the explicit satisfaction ratings simply reflect a ceiling effect, with the synthetic workers affirming high satisfaction regardless of the actual affective climate. If the survey were a socially desirable response, the satisfaction hierarchy would diverge from the sentiment hierarchy. Instead, the two subjective measures converge on the same warm-cold ordering

of leadership styles. The conditions that produced the coldest message sentiment, Coercive and Pacesetter, also reported the lowest satisfaction, whereas the warmest styles, Affiliative, Authoritative, and Coaching, reported the highest satisfaction (Figure A.37, Table B.21). Pooled style-level Spearman correlations between mean sentiment and mean satisfaction are strongly positive for both VADER ($\rho = .96, p < .001$) and RoBERTa ($\rho = 1.00, p < .0001$) (Table B.16). This alignment indicates that the synthetic workers are not just pretending to be satisfied. The pos/neg skew observed in the sentiment analysis is reflected in the explicit survey ratings. The high coupling between affective tone and reported satisfaction stands in direct contrast to the independence between satisfaction and objective performance, suggesting that satisfaction is a coherent subjective-experience measure rather than an artifact of the Likert scale.

6.4.4 Decoupling from Quality and Cost

A fundamental theoretical takeaway is the statistical independence between worker satisfaction, deliverable quality, and computational cost (Table B.14). Pooled correlation analysis reveals no significant correlation between team satisfaction and overall quality scores (Spearman $\rho = 0.001, p = .99$), which replicates within both the short task ($\rho = +0.034, p = .84$) and the long task ($\rho = -0.123, p = .48$). Similarly, token expenditure does not correlate with worker satisfaction (short task $\rho = -0.113, p = .52$; long task $\rho = -0.096, p = .58$). These findings demonstrate that, although warm and supportive leadership styles foster positive subjective experiences in MASs, this satisfaction does not translate into higher objective performance or require greater computational investment.

6.5 Communication Patterns

Analyzing conversational interaction patterns reveals how managerial framing affects the structure of dialogue, speaker dominance, and the distribution of collaborative effort throughout workflow phases.

6.5.1 Managerial Dominance

Across the 1,033 inter-agent messages exchanged throughout the 70 experimental runs, the supervisor was the primary driver of the communication volume (Table B.25). The Boss generated 47.0% of all messages (485 messages, averaging 6.93 messages per run) and accounted for 51.6% of the total per-turn API token cost (4.78 million tokens). In contrast, subordinate workers divided the remaining conversational footprint. The Reviewer accounted for 18.7% of token mass (191 messages; 2.73 messages per run), the Writer accounted for 15.6% (184 messages; 2.63 messages per run), and the Coder

accounted for 14.0% (173 messages; 2.47 messages per run). As shown in Figure A.1, hierarchical multi-agent coordination remains heavily centralized. The Boss produces a large plurality to near-half of all non-system messages across every leadership style and task, and dominates token volume even more clearly at 51.6% (Table B.25).

6.5.2 Phase-Level Effort Redistribution

A key manipulation check is whether leadership styles actively altered where the team invested its collaborative effort. Mean per-run Boss token output varied significantly across styles in both the short task ($H = 18.66, p = .005$) and the long task ($H = 19.98, p = .003$) (Table B.10), ranging from 47,481 tokens under Coercive management to 107,812 tokens under Democratic leadership (Table B.27). Furthermore, managerial framing systematically redistributed token mass across workflow stages (Table B.28). The Democratic and Coaching conditions allocated the largest proportion of their communication budget to the Revision phase (41.4% and 40.6%, respectively), engaging in extensive, multi-turn technical critiques. In contrast, the Baseline condition concentrated 23.0% of its effort in the Coding phase and 25.8% in Revision, advancing rapidly to delivery with minimal debate. As illustrated in Figure A.19 and Figure A.20, the assigned leadership styles are not merely stylistic overlays, but they actively reshape the temporal allocation of collaborative problem-solving, aligning with recent frameworks that model prompt-based organizational structures as active controllers of multi-agent behavioral signatures and information-exchange dynamics (Dang et al. 2025; X. Guo et al. 2024; Kwak 2026).

6.5.3 Per-Turn Token Cost and Context Accumulation

Examining the per-turn API token cost, which includes both the agent’s output and the full accumulated conversation context passed as input, reveals the precise mechanism underlying the variations in computational cost observed in efficiency metrics (Table B.26). The Boss per-turn token cost varied substantially by condition. Democratic (12,509 tokens per turn) and Coaching (11,716 tokens per turn) produced the highest managerial costs, whereas Pacesetting (8,758 tokens per turn), Affiliative (7,959 tokens per turn), and Coercive (7,924 tokens per turn) required fewer tokens per turn. The supervisor’s per-turn cost directly modulated subordinate per-turn costs, consistent with linguistic alignment effects where agents adapt their conversational outputs to match the stylistic properties of their prompts (Almutairi et al. 2025). Reviewers and Coders incurred their highest per-turn costs when prompted by Democratic (Reviewer: 11,956 tokens; Coder: 9,261 tokens) and Coaching (Reviewer: 10,950 tokens; Coder: 8,931 tokens) leaders, compared to much lower per-turn costs under Coercive (Reviewer: 7,113

tokens) and Affiliative (Coder: 5,295 tokens) management. As shown in Figure A.21, participation-oriented leadership increases token expenditure by expanding context windows across the entire team rather than by increasing the discrete number of interaction turns. This compounding context window accumulation constitutes a primary driver of communication redundancy and computational cost overhead in cooperative multi-agent environments (Zhao Wang et al. 2025; G. Zhang et al. 2024).

6.6 Task Complexity

Comparing outcomes across the two task complexities highlights how task structure interacts with managerial framing. The short task (data-quality awareness and ranking) and the long task (multi-step predictive modeling) presented fundamentally different cognitive and coordination demands to the MAS.

6.6.1 Quality Asymmetry by Task

Across all seven leadership styles, overall deliverable quality was higher on the long modeling task (condition means ranging from 3.25 to 4.30) than on the short data-quality report (2.55 to 3.05) (Table B.19). This discrepancy is rooted in the structural nature of each task, as task design acts as a primary enabling condition that shapes a team’s performance strategies and output quality (Wageman et al. 2005). The long task provided explicit procedural milestones, such as train/test splitting, baseline fitting, coefficient extraction, and diagnostic plotting. These milestones provided the Coder and Reviewer with clear intermediate checkpoints to identify flaws in the execution process, echoing how standardized operating procedures (SOPs) and intermediate deliverables streamline coordination and prevent errors in MASs (Hong et al. 2024). In contrast, the short task was deceptively simple. The code executed without syntax errors, but naive grouped aggregation blindly produced erroneous rankings, severely penalizing Accuracy and the interpretative Quality dimension, unless active data verification was initiated. Completeness was the highest-scoring dimension in the short task, while Cohesion and Completeness were the highest-scoring dimensions in the long task, with all four dimensions improving on the more structured modeling task (Figure A.7, Table B.23). Although the long task produced a wider absolute spread between styles (1.05 quality points versus 0.50 in the short task), score differences within each task remained below the MDE threshold (Table B.7), indicating that task complexity was the primary determinant of quality rather than leadership style, aligning with task contingency frameworks where task characteristics dominate over structural or stylistic team dynamics (Mathieu et al. 2017; Muralidharan et al. 2025).

6.6.2 Resource Scaling

The long task required substantially more computational resources, averaging approximately 37,000 additional tokens and 85 extra seconds per run ($\sim 220,794$ tokens and ~ 287 seconds versus $\sim 183,426$ tokens and ~ 202 seconds; Table B.23). Importantly, this cost increase occurred despite the fact that long-task runs generated slightly fewer total messages on average (23.6 messages in long runs versus 25.3 in short runs). This indicates that task complexity increased token consumption through longer reasoning contexts, expanded data tables, and detailed model summaries, rather than through additional conversational turns, reflecting established patterns of cumulative context window inflation and information density overhead in multi-agent environments (Hong et al. 2024; G. Zhang et al. 2024). The relative cost hierarchy among leadership styles remained stable across both task types. Democratic and Coaching consistently emerged as the most expensive conditions, while Affiliative and Coercive remained the most economical (Figure A.16; Table B.19). The primary divergence in task style occurred in the Pacesetting condition. Its token consumption remained essentially invariant between tasks ($\sim 189,000$ tokens in short runs versus $\sim 191,000$ in long runs), even though execution duration increased from ~ 198 seconds to ~ 256 seconds (Table B.19).

6.6.3 Satisfaction by Task

The style-driven variation in synthetic worker satisfaction displayed an inverse pattern across task complexities compared to the widening spread observed in deliverable quality. The overall team satisfaction was generally higher in long-task runs across most conditions (Figure A.32; Table B.19), with Coercive rising from 4.16 to 4.59 and Democratic rising from 4.71 to 4.86, while Coaching maintained a high ceiling across both tasks (4.89 in the short task versus 4.87 in the long task). However, the between-style team satisfaction spread compressed substantially from 0.744 in the short task down to 0.355 in the long task (Table B.7). This compression suggests that the richer procedural structure and tangible milestones of the modeling task provided collaborative momentum, which partially protected subordinate workers from directive or demanding managerial framing. This buffering effect aligns with organizational frameworks showing that well-designed, structured tasks act as motivating enabling structures that enhance team viability and can serve as leadership substitutes, thereby mitigating or neutralizing the impact of supervisor behavior on worker well-being (Kwak 2026; Shadow and Wolf 2026; Wageman et al. 2005).

Discussion

7.1 Interpretation

In heterogeneous MASs, supervisory leadership style acts as a process-level coordination controller (Kwak 2026), though its operational reach is limited. As established in Chapter 6, systematically manipulating the Boss agent’s prompt-defined leadership framing produces large, statistically significant shifts across three operational dimensions: communication sentiment, post-task worker satisfaction, and computational resource consumption. In contrast, leadership style exerts no statistically detectable influence on the objective quality of final deliverables or on the team’s ability to identify subtle data anomalies.

7.1.1 Expectations Revisited

Section 2.2.2 derived four directional expectations from Goleman’s framework (Goleman 2000). Assessing each one against the measured outcomes clarifies not only whether it held, but how strongly and subject to which qualification. Since the design was powered only for large effects, effect magnitudes are expressed throughout as ratios of the observed between-style range to the MDE threshold for that DV (Table B.7). This provides a consistent internal benchmark rather than relying on external conventions.

Expectation 1 (Warmth → Sentiment): supported, and the strongest effect measured in this study. The four warm styles produced significantly higher communication sentiment across the shared channel than the two cold, directive styles (VADER (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) $H = 51.20$; RoBERTa (Loureiro et al. 2022) $H = 58.41$; both $p < .001$; Table B.8; Section 6.3.1). The strength of this result rests less on the omnibus statistics than on convergence: two analyzers that share neither lexical resources nor model architecture ranked the seven conditions almost identically ($\rho = .96$; Table B.17), so the ordering

is a property of the generated text rather than an artifact of either instrument.

Expectation 2 (Warmth → Satisfaction): supported, and detectable despite the small sample. Worker agents reported systematically higher satisfaction (Wageman et al. 2005) and team viability (Aubé and Rousseau 2005) under warm, supportive leadership, whereas coercive supervision depressed post-task ratings ($\epsilon^2 = .36$ short, $.35$ long; Table B.6; Section 6.4.1). Satisfaction is one of only three dependent variables whose observed range exceeded its MDE threshold, by factors of 1.50 and 1.24 respectively (Table B.7). This places this finding on the same evidential footing as the cost results rather than alongside the underpowered quality comparisons.

Expectation 3 (Dialogue → Cost): supported, but only for two of the four warm styles. Democratic and Coaching supervision inflated token consumption by 48% and 32% relative to the neutral Baseline (Table B.18), with proportional increases in wall-clock duration ($\epsilon^2 = .41$ to $.47$ across tasks; Table B.6; Section 6.2.1). The formulation of this expectation in Section 2.2.2 conceals an important asymmetry. However, the remaining two warm styles were not merely cheaper than their consultative counterparts but cheaper than the Baseline itself. Affiliative supervision consumed roughly 22% fewer tokens than Baseline, and Authoritative supervision consumed roughly 3% fewer (Table B.18). Warmth therefore does not carry a cost penalty, but deliberation does.

Expectation 4 (Climate → Quality): not supported. Improved communication sentiment and worker satisfaction did not result in higher analytical accuracy, better trap detection, or superior deliverable cohesion (Section 6.1.1). This is the one expectation carried over directly from human organizational research (Goleman 2000; Barrick et al. 1998; Mathieu et al. 2017), and its failure is the most consequential result of the study.

7.1.2 Behavioral Propagation and Its Limits

The sentiment results provide empirical support for the behavioral propagation mechanism. Even when the analysis is restricted to messages produced exclusively by worker agents, worker sentiment still varies systematically with the Boss agent’s assigned style (VADER $H = 36.88$; RoBERTa $H = 41.58$; both $p < .001$; Table B.9). Since the worker system prompts, model backends, and task specifications were held constant across all conditions, and because the name of the leadership style was never transmitted via the message bus, worker tone cannot have been injected through prompt design. Rather, it was induced through in-context exposure to the supervisor’s observable actions (Lin et al. 2025; Almutairi et al. 2025). Thus, an LLM supervisor’s enacted persona propagates across a shared communication channel, altering the linguistic behavior and subjective ratings of subordinate agents whose

own configuration never changed (Serapio-García et al. 2025; Jiang et al. 2024; Duan et al. 2025).

Two qualifications constrain how far this conclusion can be pushed, and both are informative rather than purely cautionary.

The first is that propagation is attenuated rather than mimetic. If workers simply mirrored the supervisor’s tone, the Boss-worker sentiment gap would collapse toward zero under every condition. Instead, the gap remains large and signed in both directions (Figure A.28). Under Coercive and Pacesetting supervision the Boss is substantially colder than the team (VADER mean gaps -0.326 and -0.272), whereas under Affiliative and Coaching supervision the Boss is substantially warmer (RoBERTa mean gaps $+0.432$ and $+0.283$; Table B.13). Workers thus shift in the direction of the supervisor’s affect while regressing toward their own neutral default, which is the behavior expected of agents conditioned on a fixed, tonally neutral system prompt that is only partially overridden by conversational context (Cava and Tagarelli 2025; Shanahan et al. 2023).

The second qualification is that propagation is unevenly distributed across roles, and the pattern is systematic rather than noisy. Ordering the three workers by the strength of the style effect on their own message tone yields Coder < Reviewer < Writer under both analyzers, and under RoBERTa the Coder falls below the significance threshold entirely ($H = 9.30$, $p = .16$), while the Reviewer ($H = 24.59$, $p < .001$) and Writer ($H = 39.45$, $p < .001$) remain highly significant (Table B.9; Figure A.30). The satisfaction survey replicates this ordering: under Coercive supervision, ratings were lowest for the Writer (4.28) and Reviewer (4.32) and highest for the Coder (4.52; Table B.22; Figure A.34). Two independent measurement channels therefore converge on the same conclusion: susceptibility to supervisory tone scales with how much natural language a role is required to produce. The Writer, whose entire deliverable is text, is most affected, while the Coder, whose deliverable is executable code constrained by syntax and by the dataset schema, is least affected (Qian et al. 2024).

7.1.3 Why Supervisory Framing Misses Quality

The absence of a detectable leadership effect on deliverable quality does not mean that such an effect does not exist. Three distinct mechanisms contribute to this effect, and they operate at different levels of the system.

The first is measurement sensitivity. With five repetitions per condition, the design could only detect large effects. The observed quality ranges reached only 0.71 and 0.91 times the MDE threshold (Figure A.25). A genuine moderate effect would have been invisible by construction.

The second is the surface visibility of the embedded traps, which affected accuracy regardless of supervision. In the short task, entity-level duplicates were only sporadically caught and single-observation entries were almost universally missed, because routine exploratory scripts never surfaced them into any agent’s context window (Table B.24; Figure A.9). In the long task, target leakage was caught in 32 out of 35 runs regardless of style because a near-perfect R^2 is conspicuous in the printed console output. However, negative sentinel values in three air-quality columns were missed in 33 of 35 runs because nothing in a standard summary draws attention to them (Table B.24; Figure A.10). Therefore, trap detection was governed by whether an anomaly became visible in the shared artifacts, which is a property of the task and the tooling rather than of the supervisor’s attitude.

The third mechanism follows from the role gradient established in Section 7.1.2 and offers the most direct explanation of the null. Deliverable accuracy is determined almost entirely by the Coder, since the analytical results, the printed tables, and the figures all originate in executed code, and the Writer and Reviewer operate downstream on whatever the Coder produced (Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024). The Coder is precisely the agent whose linguistic behavior was least responsive to supervisory tone, and the only agent for which the style effect was not statistically detectable under one of the two analyzers (Table B.9; Figure A.30). Supervisory framing thus reshapes the conversational surface of the collaboration while barely affecting the agent whose output determines whether the deliverable is correct (Kwak 2026). In this interpretation, decoupling is not due to insufficient power, but a structural consequence of where tone lands in a role-differentiated hierarchy: the affective signal is strongest in the roles that generate text and weakest in the role that generates code.

One observation complicates any simple version of this account. Within the short task, the per-run trap catch rate correlates strongly and significantly with total token expenditure (Spearman $\rho = +0.63$, $p < .001$; Table B.14), suggesting that additional deliberation did improve data-quality awareness. However, this conclusion is not sustainable for two reasons. First, the relationship reverses its sign in the long task ($\rho = -0.32$, $p = .06$), so it is not a stable property of the collaboration, but rather a task-specific pattern. Second, the direction of causation is ambiguous and most plausibly runs opposite to the interpretive temptation: a team that notices an anomaly must then discuss it, re-run the analysis, and revise the report, so catching a trap generates additional tokens rather than resulting from them. Consistent with this, leadership style itself had no significant effect on trap catch rate in either task (Section 6.1.3), which is difficult to reconcile with a mechanism in which spending more simply buys more vigilance. Nevertheless, the correlation is worth stating explicitly because it is the only place in the data where cost and a quality-adjacent outcome move together. Additionally, the claim that

additional expenditure yields no measurable benefit (Section 6.2.4) requires this qualification to be accurate.

7.1.4 Warmth and Verbosity

Section 2.2.2 noted that Goleman’s styles vary independently along two dimensions, being warm or cold in affect and dialogue-intensive or terse in communicative volume (Goleman 2000). The results show that these dimensions are empirically separable in an LLM-based MAS, and the separation is the most directly actionable finding of the study. Affiliative supervision occupies the warm and terse cell: It produced, on average, both the highest reported satisfaction of any condition (4.92) and the lowest token consumption (150,222 tokens, roughly 22% below Baseline) together with the shortest runs (196.7 seconds) (Table B.18). Democratic supervision occupies the warm and verbose cell, achieving comparable satisfaction (4.78) at nearly twice the token cost (284,438 tokens; Table B.18). Affective climate and computational expenditure are therefore controlled by different properties of the supervisory prompt, and a system architect can raise one without paying for the other (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Kwak 2026).

This separation also explains why the cost hierarchy does not follow the warmth hierarchy and clarifies the mechanism behind the cost differences themselves. The expensive conditions did not issue more instructions but longer ones, since API call counts remained within a narrow band of roughly 19 to 23 per run across all seven conditions while per-turn context grew substantially (Table B.18). Cost is driven by how much deliberation a style invites into the shared channel, not by how many coordination events it triggers (G. Zhang et al. 2024).

Nevertheless, the style set leaves one cell of this two-by-two structure unoccupied, which limits what the present design can establish. None of Goleman’s six styles are simultaneously cold and dialogue-intensive: Coercive and Pace-setting are both terse, and the two verbose styles are both warm (Goleman 2000). Warmth and verbosity are consequently separable in the observed data, but they are not fully crossed by design. Therefore, the study cannot rule out the possibility that some portion of the token overhead attributed to deliberation is actually attributable to the affective register in which the deliberation occurs. Isolating the two would require a supervisory prompt that is demanding in tone yet consultative in volume, a combination that has no natural counterpart in Goleman’s taxonomy and would have to be constructed specifically for this purpose.

7.1.5 The Three-Way Decoupling

Assembling the preceding subsections yields the central empirical claim of this thesis: in LLM-based multi-agent collaboration, **deliverable quality, operational cost, and team climate behave as mutually independent outcome dimensions**. Cost and climate separate because warmth and verbosity are distinct properties of the supervisory prompt. Quality and climate separate because the affective signal reaches the prose-producing roles far more strongly than the code-producing one (Section 7.1.3). Quality and cost separate because within-task correlations between total token expenditure and deliverable quality are non-significant in both tasks and differ even in sign (short: $\rho = +0.309$, $p = .07$; long: $\rho = -0.15$, $p = .39$), while the correlation between satisfaction and quality is indistinguishable from zero at the run level ($\rho = 0.001$, $p = .99$) (Table B.14).

One methodological caveat must accompany this claim, since the pooled correlations tell a different and misleading story. Pooling all 70 runs produces apparently robust associations between quality and both token expenditure ($\rho = +0.334$, $p = .005$) and duration ($\rho = +0.519$, $p < .001$). These are artifacts of task complexity acting as a common cause: the long task simultaneously scored higher on quality and consumed more resources than the short task (Section 6.6.2), so aggregating across tasks manufactures a correlation between two variables that are unrelated within either one. This is why all cost-quality relationships in this thesis are evaluated within task rather than pooled, and it is worth stating explicitly because the pooled figures are the ones a reader would obtain from a naive analysis of the same dataset.

When framed correctly, the decoupling is a constructive result rather than a negative one. The absence of a cost-quality trade-off allows supervisory framing to be adjusted according to latency budgets, token budgets, or the communicative requirements of a user-facing deployment without reducing deliverable accuracy (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Wu et al. 2023). This is because a terse directive supervisor and a dialogue-intensive consultative one produce statistically indistinguishable quality deliverables. The corresponding limitation is equally clear: the same independence means that no amount of managerial framing will improve deliverable accuracy (Kwak 2026). Therefore, technical correctness must be secured by other means (Wei et al. 2023; X. Wang et al. 2023; J. Chen et al. 2025).

7.1.6 Goleman’s Causal Chain

Taken together, these results permit a reasonably precise conclusion about the framework from which the manipulation was derived (Goleman 2000). Goleman’s model proposes a two-stage causal chain in which leadership style shapes organizational climate, which then drives objective performance (Goleman 2000). The first stage transfers to LLM multi-agent collaboration with

considerable reliability. Supervisory framing operates as a reliable dial for interpersonal tone and reported team experience. It does so through the same mechanism that Goleman describes: the leader’s observable conduct, rather than any formal authority that the architecture grants (Goleman 2000). The second stage does not transfer. In human organizations, supportive leadership is believed to improve output by raising psychological safety, intrinsic motivation, and sustained cognitive effort (Goleman 2000; Wageman et al. 2005; Mathieu et al. 2017). However, these concepts do not apply to an agent that generates code, as it performs the same way whether it is addressed with encouragement or curt instruction (Kwak 2026). The construct that carries Goleman’s chain from climate to performance is precisely the construct that artificial agents lack.

The results also speak to the contingency prediction introduced in Section 2.2.1, which motivated evaluating leadership across two task complexities in the first place (Ayman et al. 1995; Kwak 2026). This prediction is partially supported, though not in the anticipated way. Task complexity did not moderate the effect of leadership on quality, which remained undetectable in both tasks. It did moderate the effect on team climate: the between-style spread in satisfaction compressed from 0.744 in the short task to 0.355 in the long task, a reduction of more than half (Table B.7). The more structured task, with its explicit organizational milestones, appears to have provided a source of collaborative momentum, which partially isolated workers from directive supervision (Wageman et al. 2005; Kwak 2026). Contingency effects in artificial teams may therefore operate on the affective consequences of leadership rather than on its performance consequences, which inverts the emphasis of the human literature (Ayman et al. 1995).

Finally, positioning these findings against recent work clarifies that leadership in MAS is not a single construct (Kwak 2026). Recent work operationalizes leadership as programmatic coordination control, showing that state-machine decision rules and intervention thresholds regulate error recovery and task success (Kwak 2026). The present study holds that the coordination framework remains fixed while the communicative framing varies, and it finds effects on tone, satisfaction, and cost, but not on task success. Together, these two studies suggest a two-tier model in which a *structural-algorithmic layer* controls task routing, validation gates, and error recovery and thereby determines technical deliverable quality, while a *communicative-behavioral layer* manages interaction volume, conversational tone, and resource expenditure and thereby determines operational cost and team climate. The role gradient documented in Section 7.1.2 suggests why the two layers separate so cleanly. Communicative framing propagates most strongly to the roles that produce language and most weakly to the role that produces the artifact, so an intervention confined to the communicative layer has limited influence on outcomes determined at the structural layer. This model is a hypothesis

generated by two studies with different manipulations rather than a tested result, and discriminating between the layers would require varying both within a single design.

7.2 Trade-offs

Supervisory framing acts as a decoupled dial for communication climate and resource expenditure without penalizing task accuracy, which means the choice of style is determined by the deployment context, token budget, and user-facing requirements rather than by deliverable outcomes (Kwak 2026; G. Zhang et al. 2024). An engineering evaluation of the styles reveals three distinct operational profiles. These profiles are not equally defensible on the measured dimensions. As Section 7.1.4 establishes, the participatory cluster is dominated by the warm and resource-efficient one in terms of both climate and cost. Therefore, its justification necessarily rests on properties that were not measured in this study.

Warm and Resource-Efficient (Authoritative and Affiliative). This cluster delivers maximal collaborative satisfaction and positive communication sentiment while preserving low computational overhead. By combining supportive framing with swift execution handoffs and high worker autonomy, these styles minimize conversational friction (Goleman 2000; Wageman et al. 2005). They represent the ideal default for human-facing or auditable MASs, where interaction logs are inspected by users or external stakeholders who value constructive, professional collaboration (Amershi et al. 2019; Almutairi et al. 2025).

Directive and Low-Cost (Coercive and Pacesetting). This cluster optimizes for speed and computational economy at the expense of team climate. By eliminating conversational pleasantries and enforcing immediate compliance, these styles minimize latency and token expenditure, but produce cold message logs and depressed satisfaction ratings (Goleman 2000; G. Zhang et al. 2024). They are best suited for fully automated, headless batch processing pipelines where conversational transparency is irrelevant and token cost or execution speed dominates the objective function (Hong et al. 2024).

Participatory and Resource-Intensive (Democratic and Coaching). This cluster incurs a substantial computational tax by generating extensive multi-turn deliberation and iterative feedback loops (G. Zhang et al. 2024; W. Chen et al. 2023). While these styles maintain high worker satisfaction and warm sentiment, they do not improve the work environment more than cheaper warm styles and do not increase accuracy in well-defined workflows (Kwak 2026). Therefore, on the three dimensions measured here, they are the weakest option. Deliberation would have to be valued for its own sake to justify them: they are defensible only in open-ended, exploratory domains

where broad consensus-seeking or divergent brainstorming is an explicit design requirement (Goleman 2000; W. Chen et al. 2023), and testing whether extended deliberation pays off under those conditions falls outside the scope of the present tasks.

The Neutral Baseline. The Baseline demonstrates that default instruction-tuned models naturally exhibit moderate warmth and standard token expenditure (Serapio-García et al. 2025; Cava and Tagarelli 2025). But relying on an unconditioned supervisor forfeits deliberate control: explicit style framing is required to either drive token costs to the absolute minimum or to establish an intentionally supportive, collaborative environment (Shanahan et al. 2023; White et al. 2023).

Since no cluster dominates the others, the selection among them is a deployment decision rather than an empirical one.

7.3 Limitations

A critical interpretation of the empirical results requires an explicit accounting of the study’s methodological, measurement, and architectural limitations. These limitations define the scope of the conclusions and the extent to which the findings can be generalized.

7.3.1 Statistical Power and Stochasticity

The primary methodological limitation is the small experimental sample size. With five independent repetitions per condition ($n = 5$), the between-subjects factorial design was powered to detect only large effect sizes, exceeding the MDE threshold of approximately $2.3\times$ the within-condition standard deviation (Table B.7; Section 6.1.5). Although this statistical power was sufficient to detect significant shifts in communication sentiment, token cost, and post-task worker satisfaction, it was insufficient to detect subtle variations in deliverable quality, where observed differences fell below the detection threshold (Figure A.25). Consequently, non-significant quality findings must be understood as an absence of detectable large effects within an $n = 5$ sample, rather than proof that supervisory framing has zero qualitative impact.

This power constraint is intensified by the inherent stochasticity of LLMs (Yehudai et al. 2026). Despite using fixed model checkpoints and standard sampling parameters, non-deterministic token generation introduces baseline run-to-run variance across code generation, tool interactions, and deliverable drafting (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Samuel et al. 2025). With $n = 5$, separating subtle managerial framing effects from intrinsic generation stochasticity remains challenging for open-ended data science tasks.

7.3.2 Construct Validity

The evaluation instruments carry three specific construct-validity constraints:

Single Evaluator LLM-as-a-Judge. The deliverable quality was scored by a single automated judge model applying a structured rubric (Zheng et al. 2023). While the rubric enforces strict criteria across technical accuracy, analytical completeness, and report cohesion, single-rater evaluations inherently conflate genuine deliverable variance with the evaluator’s own scoring noise (Zheng et al. 2023; J. Chen et al. 2025). This single-rater noise floor limits the sensitivity of the quality metric to fine-grained differences between conditions.

Survey Ceiling Effects and LLM Sycophancy. Synthetic survey responses collected from LLM worker agents are susceptible to instruction-tuned agreeableness and positivity bias (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024). Positively worded items (such as perceived support and willingness to collaborate again) exhibited ceiling effects, clustering near the maximum score of 5.0 (Figure A.32). Although the survey protocol successfully defended against this bias by incorporating three reverse-coded items that captured the majority of discriminative variance across conditions (Section 5.4), synthetic ratings reflect prompt-conditioned behavioral alignment rather than authentic psychological satisfaction (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024) (Figure A.33).

Off-Domain Sentiment Calibration. The sentiment analysis tools used in this study (VADER (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) and RoBERTa (Loureiro et al. 2022)) were originally calibrated on short social-media text. In contrast, the analyzed corpus consists of technical, task-oriented data science dialogue containing code snippets, statistical terminology, and error traces. While the strong rank correlation between the two analyzers ($\rho \approx .964$; Table B.17) confirms that the relative ranking of leadership styles is robust and convergent, absolute compound scores should be interpreted as relative affective tone rather than absolute emotional magnitudes.

7.3.3 Scope and Architectural Boundaries

Several architectural and experimental choices limit the broader generalizability of the findings.

Task Domain and Single Dataset. The experimental evaluation was conducted exclusively within tabular data science and predictive modeling using the Global Weather Repository dataset. Whether these leadership dynamics generalize to less structured domains, such as open-ended creative writing, multi-agent negotiation, symbolic reasoning, or embodied robotics, remains to be established (Duan et al. 2025; Li et al. 2023; W. Chen et al. 2023; X. Guo et al. 2024).

Fixed Worker Personalities and Leader-Follower Fit. To isolate supervisory leadership style as the only independent variable, worker agent prompts were held constant and neutral across all conditions. While this control was methodologically necessary, it prevented the investigation of leader-follower fit, complementary personality dynamics, or how directive versus supportive leaders interact with specialized workers of varying assertiveness or expertise (Barrick et al. 1998; Halfhill et al. 2005; Duan et al. 2025; J. Zhang et al. 2024).

Hidden-Style Manipulation. To rigorously test spontaneous in-context behavioral propagation, the explicit name of the Boss’s leadership style was concealed from the shared communication channel. While this design ensured that worker tone was induced purely through observable actions, in real-world human organizations team members are often explicitly aware of their leader’s management philosophy and consciously adapt their workflow accordingly.

Static Hierarchy and Absence of Dynamic Adaptation. The four-agent hierarchy and supervisory style were held static throughout each run, evaluating steady-state style execution under a fixed organizational structure. However, this design cannot capture how leadership effects might shift under dynamic supervisory adaptation, where style transitions across workflow phases could produce interaction effects absent from a static assignment (Del Pino-Marchito et al. 2025; Dang et al. 2025; Zhexuan Wang et al. 2025).

Homogeneous Model Family. The MAS was constructed entirely within the Anthropic Claude model family (claude-sonnet-5 for the Boss, claude-haiku-4-5-20251001 for workers). While this controlled for architectural consistency, it does not address whether heterogeneous, cross-family teams (e.g., combining open-weight models with proprietary frontier models) display different susceptibilities to supervisory authority, tone framing, and emotional contagion (Cava and Tagarelli 2025; Ashery et al. 2025).

7.3.4 Anthropomorphism

Finally, interpreting multi-agent interactions through organizational psychology carries an inherent risk of anthropomorphism (Shanahan et al. 2023). LLMs do not have conscious subjective experiences, affective states, intrinsic motivation, or social career stakes (Shanahan et al. 2023). Throughout this thesis, terms such as *leadership style*, *worker satisfaction*, *team climate*, and *emotional contagion* are used as operationalized descriptors for measurable linguistic patterns, context-conditioned prompt compliance, and post-task text generation. The findings demonstrate that prompt framing systematically alters the statistical properties of multi-agent communication and resource usage. However, these findings must not be interpreted as evidence of genuine affective experience in artificial agents.

Conclusion

8.1 Summary

This thesis presented an empirical, controlled investigation into the operational effects of leadership style in hierarchical MASs, evaluating 70 independent runs across seven leadership conditions and two task specifications.

The empirical findings demonstrate that prompt-defined leadership framing has a strong and reproducible effect on three core operational dimensions:

- **Communication Sentiment:** Warm, supportive leadership styles systematically elevate the affective tone across the shared communication bus, whereas directive styles create a colder conversational climate.
- **Worker Satisfaction:** Subordinate agent ratings systematically shift with a supervisor’s attitude. Supportive leadership fosters higher reported satisfaction, while coercive supervision depresses evaluations.
- **Computational Cost:** Consultative and developmental styles substantially increase dialogue tax in terms of both token consumption and execution latency, whereas directive styles minimize operational overhead (G. Zhang et al. 2024).

In contrast, the leadership style does not significantly affect the final deliverable quality or the data-quality trap detection rates, though this null finding must be interpreted with caution given that the design was powered to detect only large effect sizes.

Synthesizing these outcomes establishes the central insight of this thesis: **deliverable quality, operational cost, and team climate are statistically decoupled in LLM-based multi-agent collaboration** (Kwak 2026). In hierarchical MASs, leadership-style prompts modulate the affective and economic character of an agent team without compromising the technical accuracy of the team’s deliverables (White et al. 2023; Kwak 2026).

8.2 Implications

The statistical decoupling of deliverable quality, operational cost, and team climate yields important practical and methodological implications for MAS engineering.

8.2.1 Architectural Implications

The primary architectural takeaway is that the three outcome dimensions act as independent design components. Unlike architectural interventions that enforce strict cost-quality trade-offs, such as model parameter scaling or multi-turn reflection passes, leadership style acts as a safe, low-risk optimization (G. Zhang et al. 2024; W. Chen et al. 2023). Managerial prompts can be tuned to satisfy latency constraints, computational budgets, or user-facing communicative requirements without compromising the accuracy of deliverables (Wu et al. 2023; Hong et al. 2024). Translating the operational profiles discussed in Section 7.2 into practice yields three concrete design recommendations.

1. **Default to Authoritative or Affiliative framing for interactive and auditable systems.** For interactive, human-in-the-loop, or auditable agent systems, architects should standardize on Authoritative or Affiliative leadership prompts (Goleman 2000; Amershi et al. 2019; Almutairi et al. 2025). Both maximize collaborative climate and reported satisfaction while avoiding the token overhead of unconstrained participatory discussion (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Wageman et al. 2005). Affiliative supervision achieved the highest satisfaction of any condition at the lowest computational cost.
2. **Enforce quality control structurally rather than through leadership tone.** Developers should not attempt to resolve technical errors or raise deliverable accuracy by instructing the Boss to be more attentive, collaborative, or developmental (Kwak 2026). Since leadership framing does not propagate to the agent that produces the analytical artifact, technical verification has to be enforced by other means: deterministic schema validation, automated test suites, tool-augmented execution sandboxes, and specialized review agents (Qian et al. 2024; Hong et al. 2024; J. Chen et al. 2025).
3. **Use directive framing for high-throughput, headless pipelines.** For background batch processing, where conversational transparency is irrelevant, terse and directive prompt framing is safe (Goleman 2000; Hong et al. 2024). Since deliverable quality is independent of communicative warmth, prompt compression and directive task assignment reduce operating costs without degrading technical performance (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Kwak 2026).

Whether static style assignment is optimal at all remains an open question (Dang et al. 2025; Zhexuan Wang et al. 2025). Dynamic, phase-dependent switching is treated as a research direction in Section 8.3 rather than as a present recommendation.

However, practitioners must exercise caution when interpreting synthetic agent metrics (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024; Samuel et al. 2025). Although reported worker satisfaction and conversational sentiment serve as useful indicators of internal communication dynamics and prompt compliance, they should not be confused with genuine machine well-being or human user satisfaction (Shanahan et al. 2023; Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024). While deploying supportive managers in human-facing MASs establishes a constructive, auditable interaction tone, direct human evaluation remains essential for assessing real-world user experience (Amershi et al. 2019; Lai et al. 2021; Almutairi et al. 2025).

8.2.2 Methodological and Benchmark Contributions

Beyond architectural guidance, this research outlines a multi-dimensional evaluation approach that could help guide future multi-agent behavioral studies (Yehudai et al. 2026; Muralidharan et al. 2025). The evaluation pipeline, which combines dual-analyzer sentiment tracking (VADER (Hutto and Gilbert 2014) and RoBERTa (Loureiro et al. 2022)), synthetic reflection surveys with reverse-coded controls (Dominguez-Olmedo et al. 2024), per-run token consumption and execution duration logging, and rubric-based deliverable assessments (J. Chen et al. 2025), illustrates one possible way to assess organizational structures, leadership prompts, and coordination protocols in collaborative artificial intelligence (Kwak 2026). However, further validation is required before it can serve as a general-purpose benchmark (Yehudai et al. 2026; Samuel et al. 2025).

8.3 Future Work

The limitations and empirical patterns identified in this thesis provide a clear roadmap for future research in multi-agent orchestration and artificial leadership.

- **Multi-Judge Panels and Statistical Power Scaling.** To isolate subtle leadership effects on task accuracy from evaluator noise, future studies should deploy a panel of three independent automated judges using majority voting and formal inter-rater reliability metrics (J. Chen et al. 2025; Zheng et al. 2023). Combining multi-judge scoring with increased sample sizes will substantially lower the MDE threshold, separating single-rater noise from true deliverable variance (Yehudai et al. 2026).

For example, using approximately 20 repetitions per condition would reduce the MDE by half.

- **Dynamic Situational Switching and Runtime Optimization.** While this study evaluated static leadership assignments, an important open research question is whether dynamic leadership style transitions across project phases outperform static assignments in terms of coordination efficiency and team viability (Del Pino-Marchito et al. 2025; Dang et al. 2025). From an engineering perspective, integrating leadership styles into adaptive runtime control loops would enable orchestrators to dynamically adjust prompt verbosity and directive intensity to maintain strict token budgets or latency limits while preserving collaborative satisfaction (G. Zhang et al. 2024; Zhexuan Wang et al. 2025).
- **Heterogeneous Follower Personas and Leader-Follower Fit.** Holding worker prompts constant isolated the leadership style, but precluded studying the interaction effects between leaders and followers. Systematically varying subordinate traits (such as assertiveness, verbosity, and domain expertise) will enable empirical investigation into leader-follower fit and personality complementarity in multi-agent collaboration (Barrick et al. 1998; Duan et al. 2025; J. Zhang et al. 2024).
- **Cross-Domain and Model Family Generalization.** Replicating the experimental framework across diverse task domains, such as collaborative software engineering, multi-turn negotiation, factual research retrieval, and creative writing, will clarify whether the decoupling of climate, cost, and quality is universal (Qian et al. 2024; Li et al. 2023; W. Chen et al. 2023). Additionally, testing whether these dynamics transfer across heterogeneous model architectures (e.g., combining open-weight worker backends with proprietary frontier supervisors) will determine whether vulnerability to supervisory authority and emotional contagion is architecture-dependent (Cava and Tagarelli 2025; Ashery et al. 2025).
- **Scaling Team Topologies and Project Lifecycles.** Expanding beyond four-agent hierarchies to larger teams ($N > 4$) and multi-stage projects will test leadership dynamics under coordination overload and evaluate how managerial framing influences complex inter-agent handoffs (Zixiang Wang et al. 2026; Hong et al. 2024; Mathieu et al. 2017).
- **Multimodal Vision and Verification.** Integrating multimodal vision capabilities will enable agents to inspect generated visual figures and plots directly, testing whether visual verification changes the role of supervisory oversight in error detection (T. Guo et al. 2024).
- **Direct Human Evaluation.** Since deliverable quality was assessed by a single automated judge, human evaluation of the same outputs would

help validate the quality metric and contextualize the LLM-as-a-judge approach, providing additional confidence that the null finding reflects a genuine absence of large effects rather than a scoring artifact (Zheng et al. 2023; J. Chen et al. 2025).

This thesis presents a systematic, multi-dimensional empirical investigation of Goleman’s leadership taxonomy within hierarchical LLM-based MASs (Goleman 2000). It uniquely couples the simultaneous evaluation of communication sentiment, post-task satisfaction, computational resource consumption, and objective deliverable quality. While the null result regarding quality is limited by statistical sensitivity constraints, the observed shifts in communication tone, worker satisfaction, and computational expenditure are significant, consistent across multiple analyzers, and reproducible. Ultimately, these findings indicate that prompt-defined leadership framing provides an effective, low-cost mechanism for modulating the affective tone and operational resource footprint of multi-agent collaboration, while maintaining technical deliverable accuracy within underlying structural constraints (White et al. 2023; Kwak 2026).

Code and Data Availability

The complete source code, all seven Boss prompt files, the three worker prompts, the orchestrator, the 70 run artifact folders, and the four analysis notebooks are available in a public repository at https://github.com/helenavioletta/MAS_leadershipstyles (Roos 2026) (final commit hash: 728c3aa).

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Appendix A

Supplementary Figures

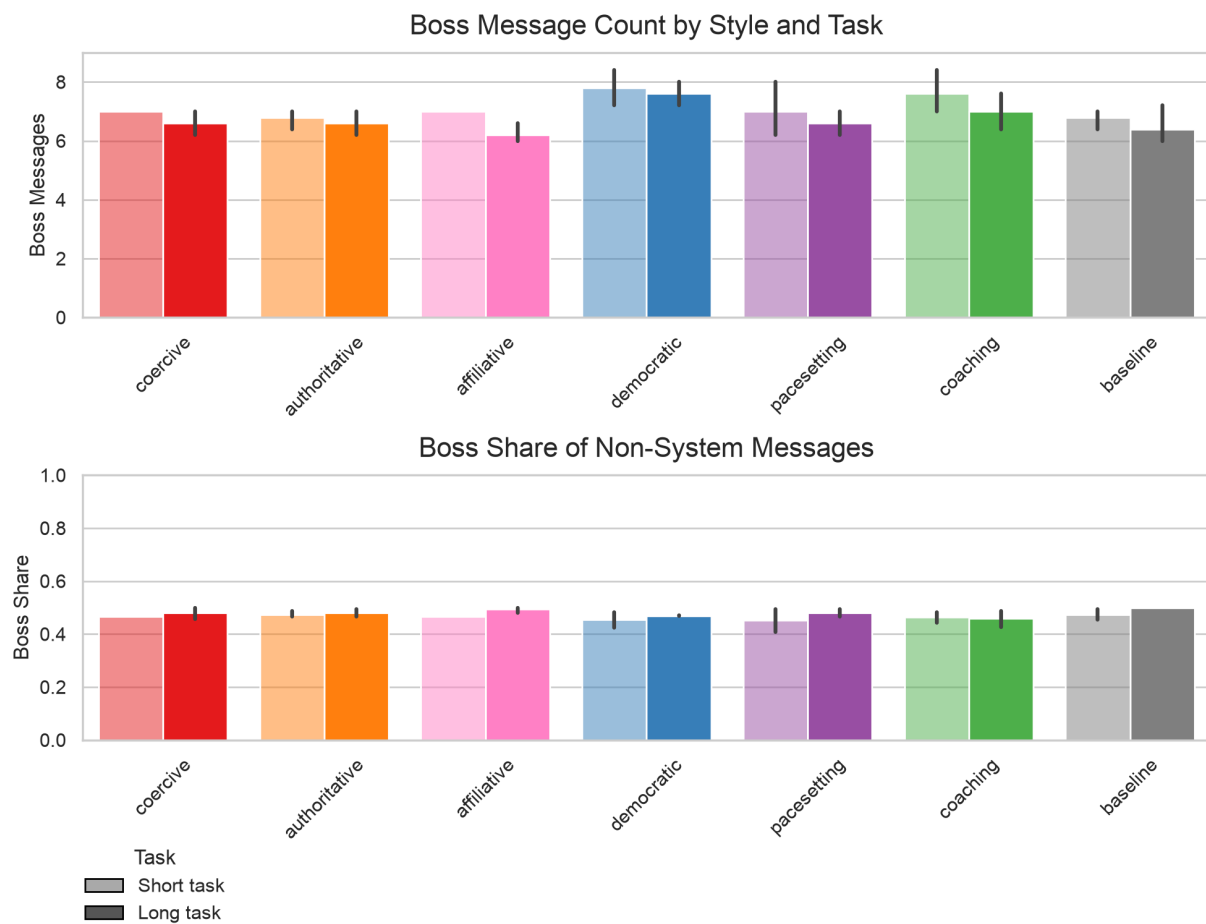


Figure A.1: Boss share of total dialogue volume.



Figure A.2: Code execution failure rate across runs.

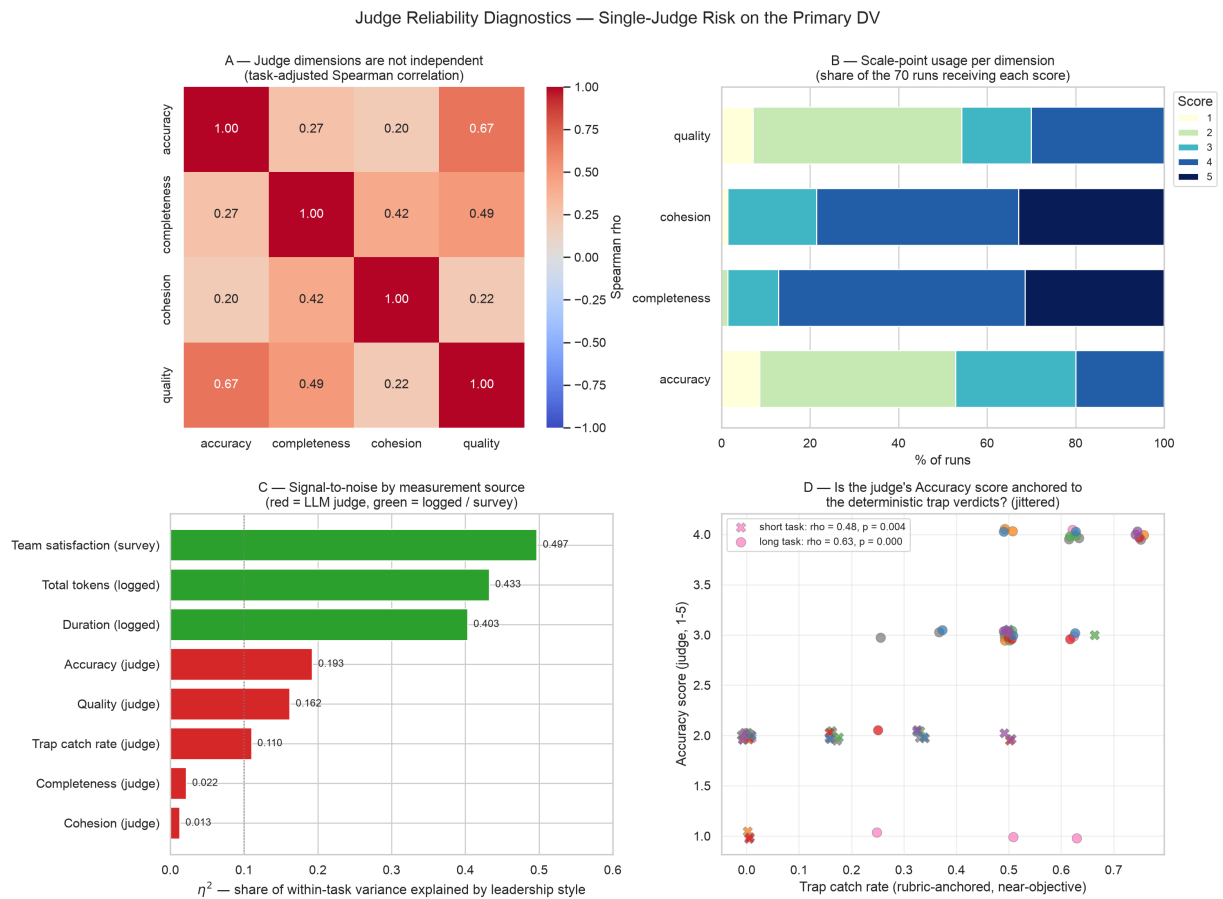


Figure A.3: LLM-as-a-judge scoring diagnostics.

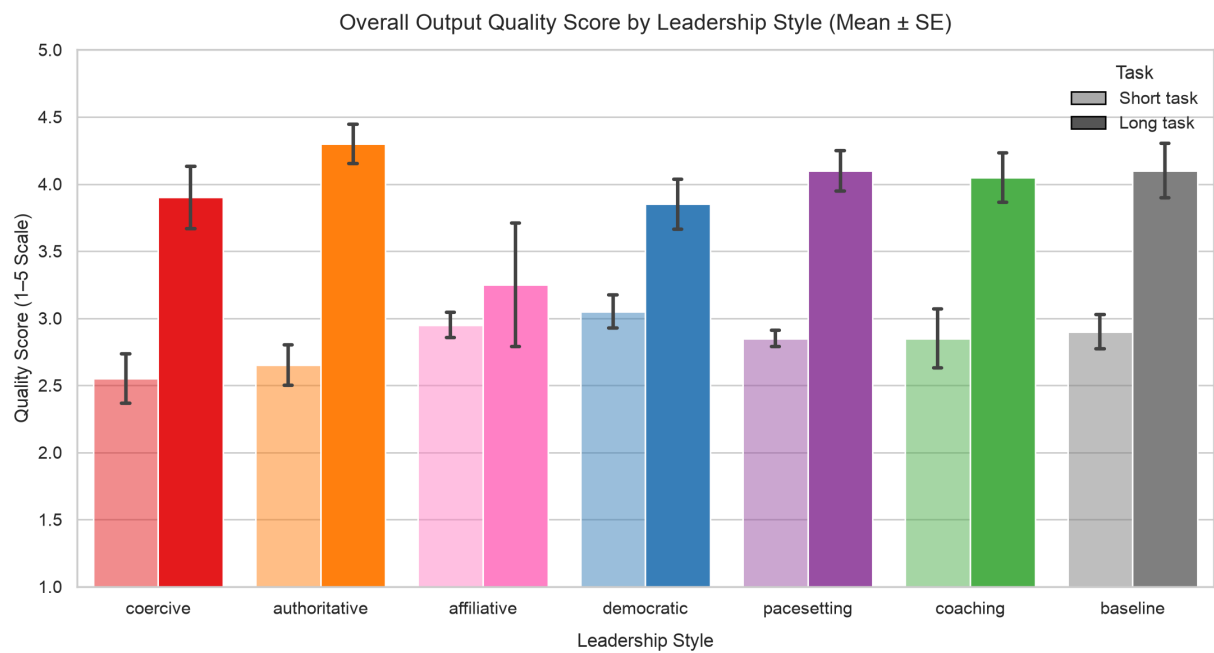


Figure A.4: Mean quality scores across leadership styles and tasks.

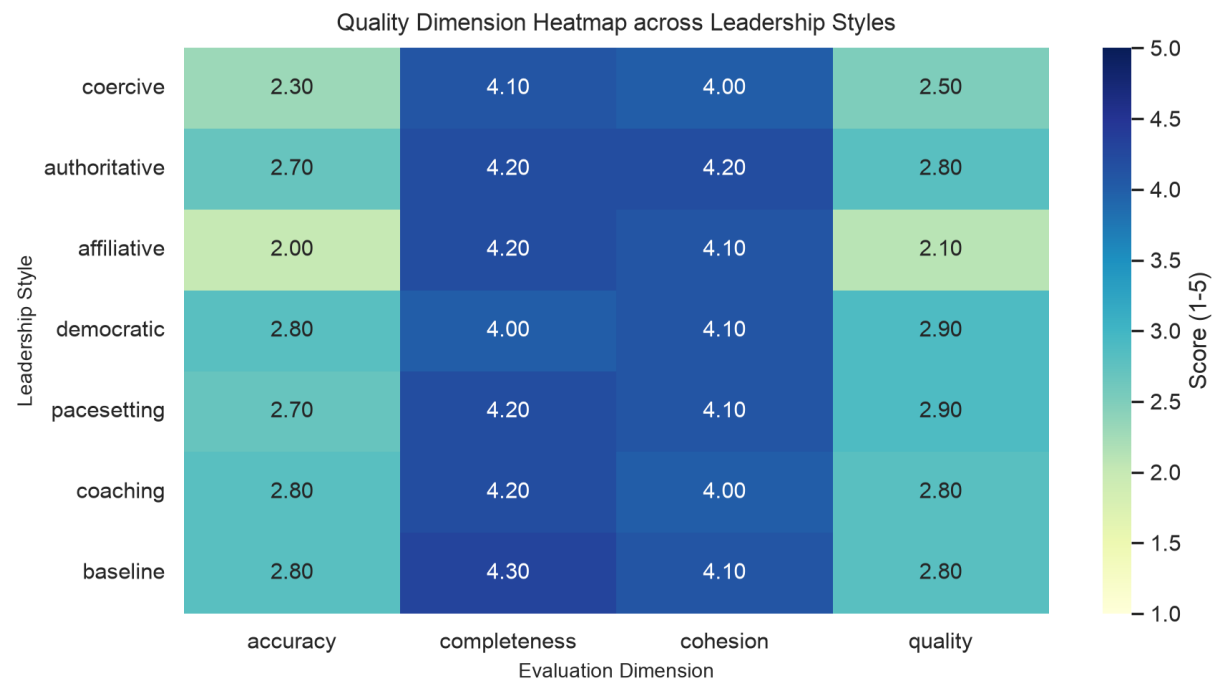


Figure A.5: Quality dimension heatmaps.

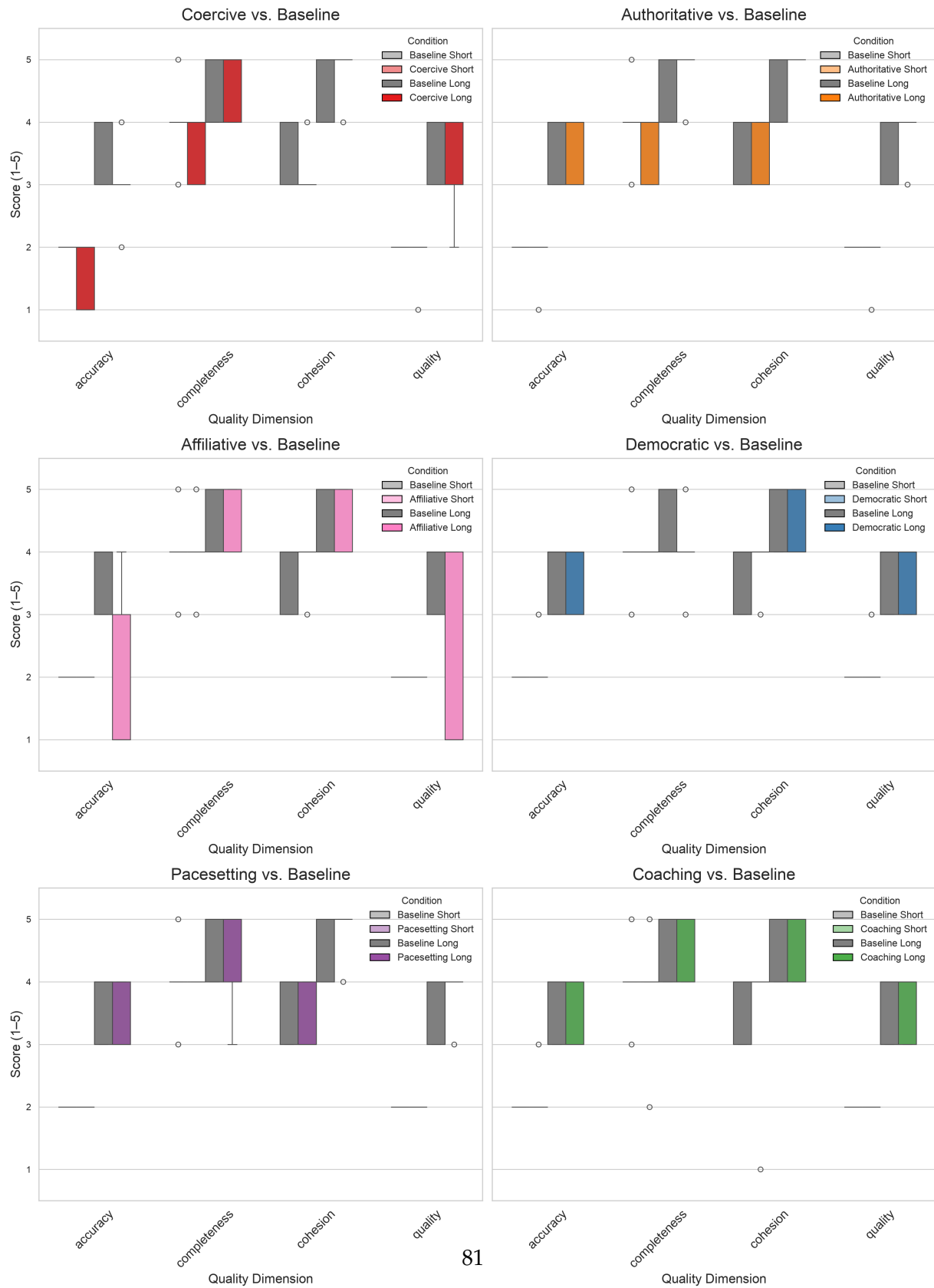


Figure A.6: Quality dimensions by leadership style.



Figure A.7: Quality dimension scores by task.

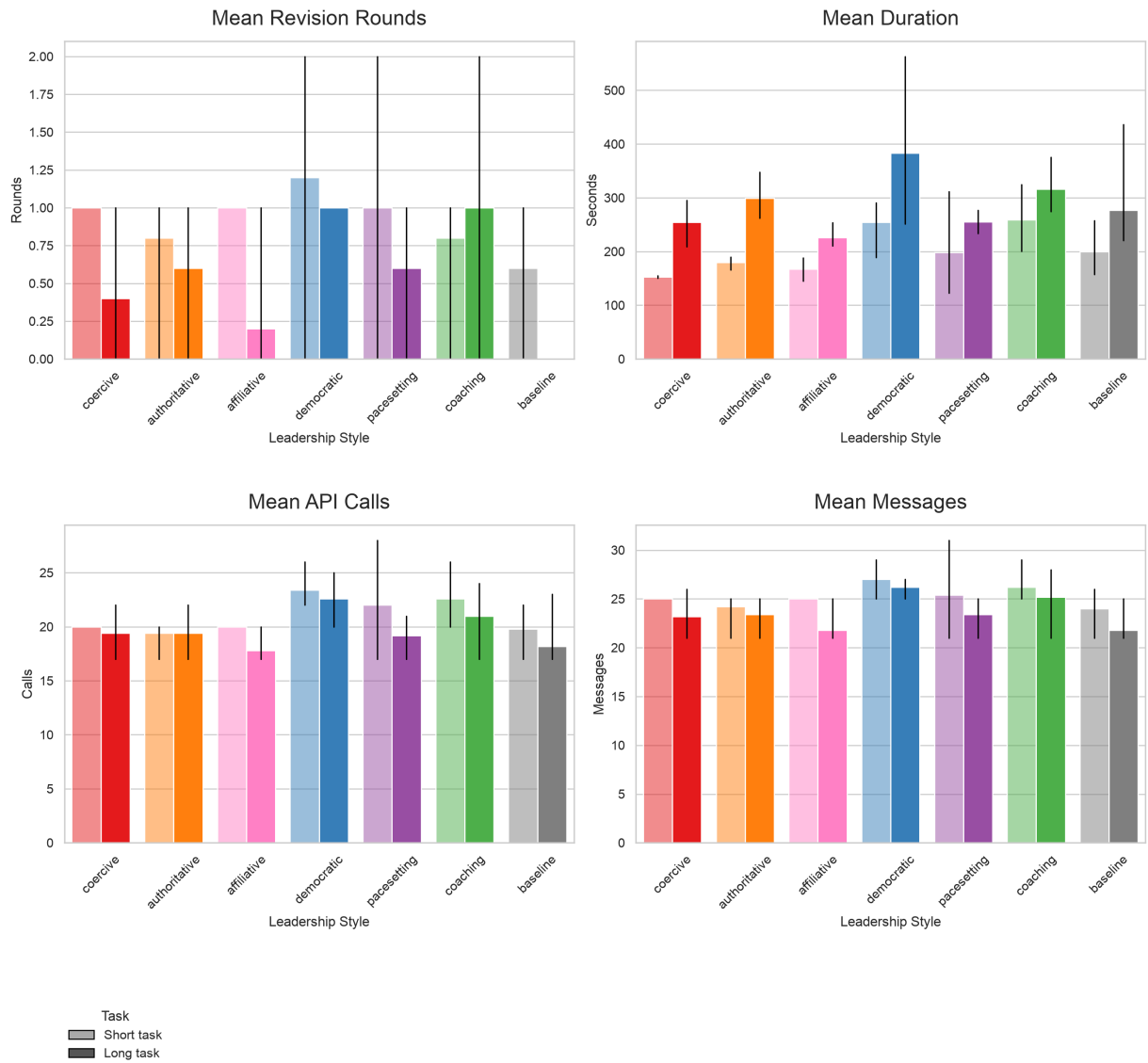


Figure A.8: Quality metric means by leadership style and task.

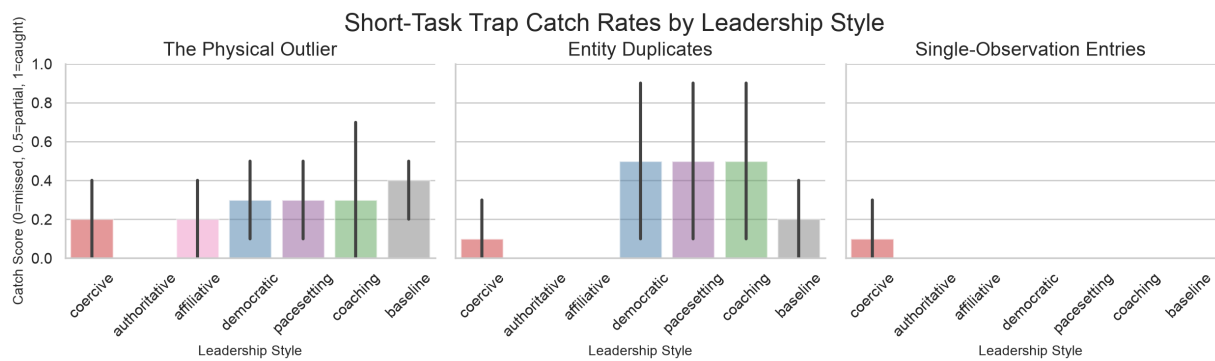


Figure A.9: Short-task trap catch rates.

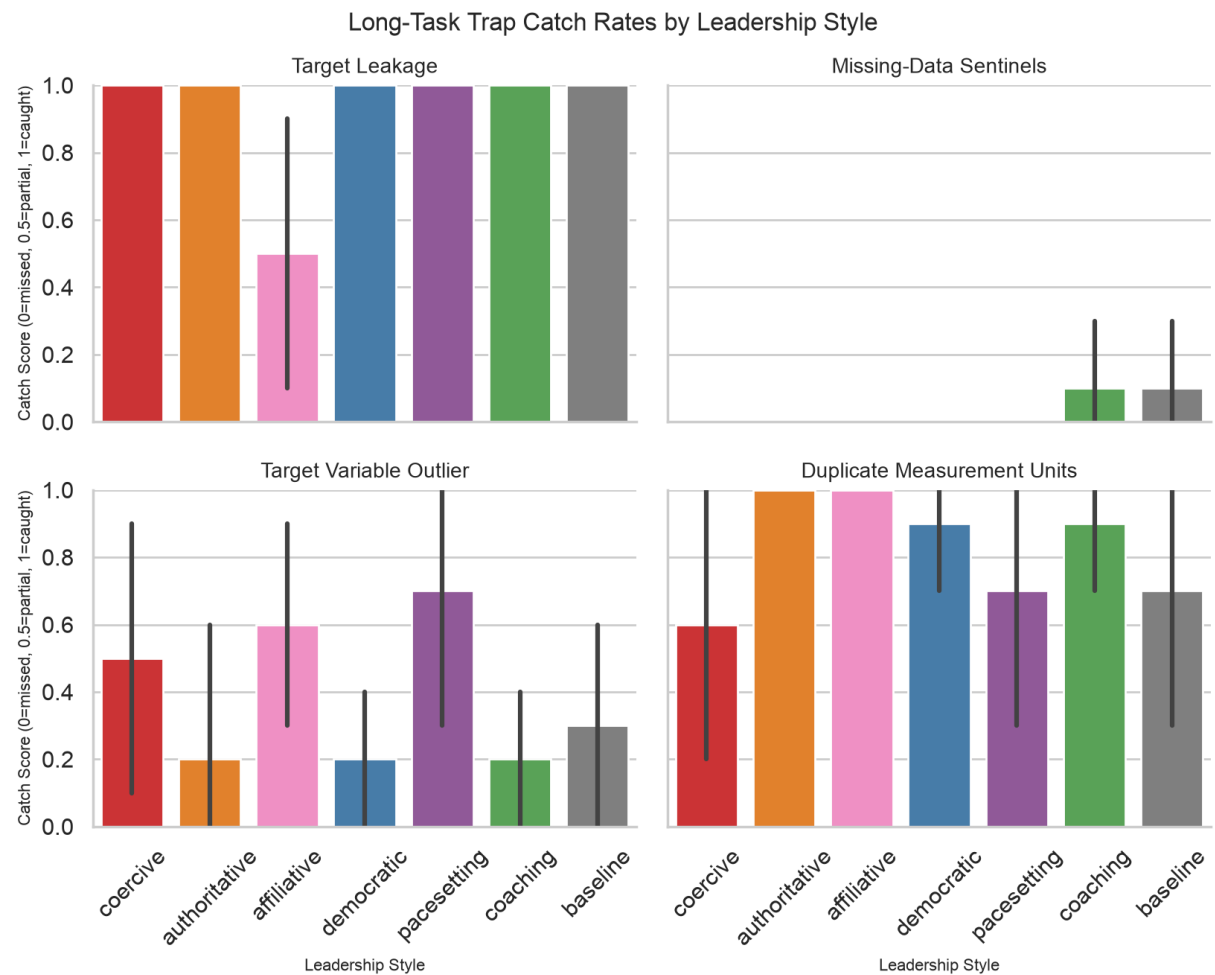


Figure A.10: Long-task trap catch rates.

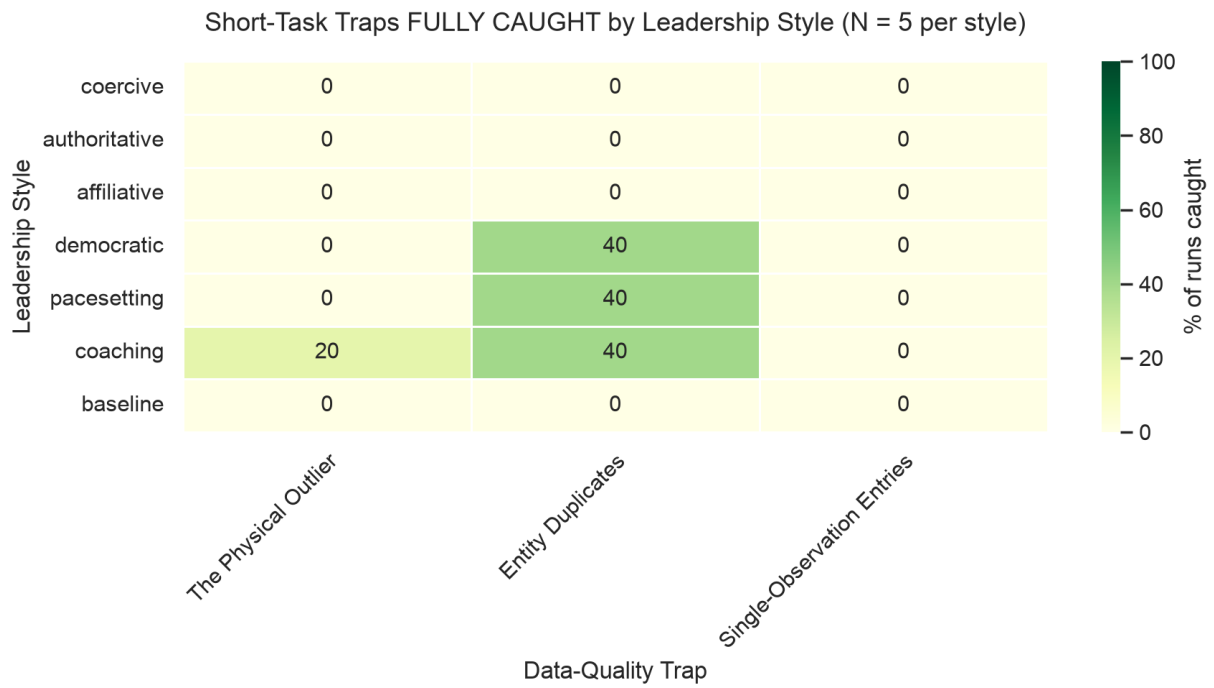


Figure A.11: Short-task trap matrix.

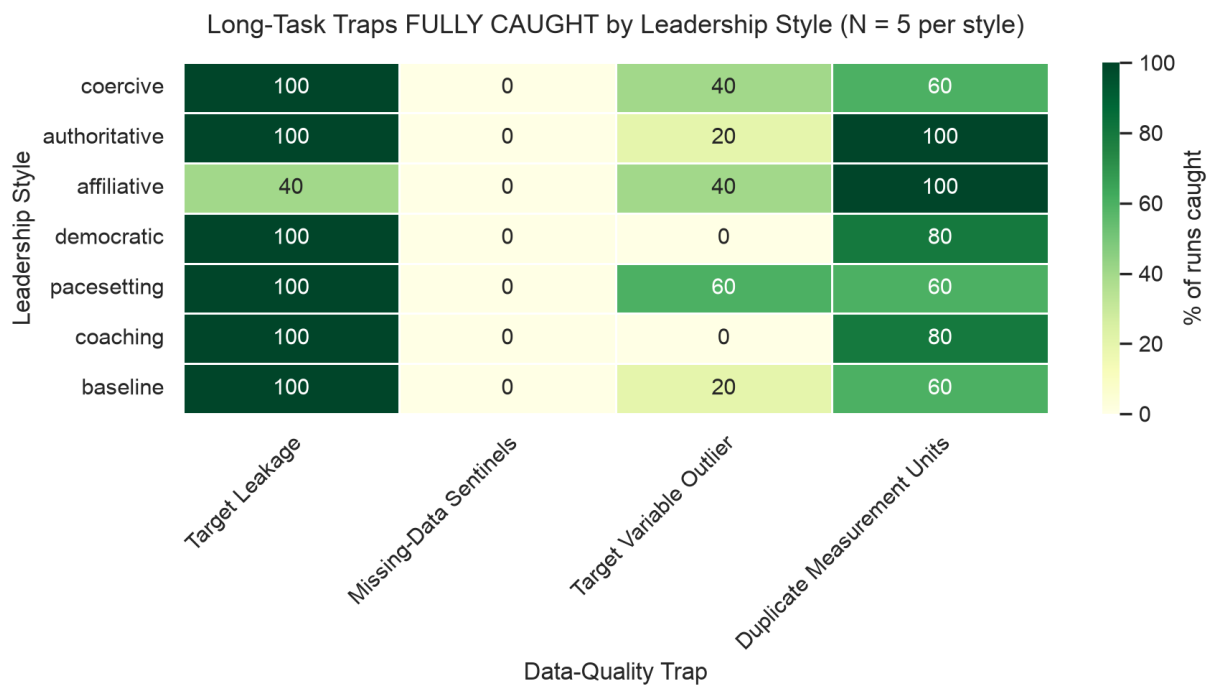


Figure A.12: Long-task trap matrix.

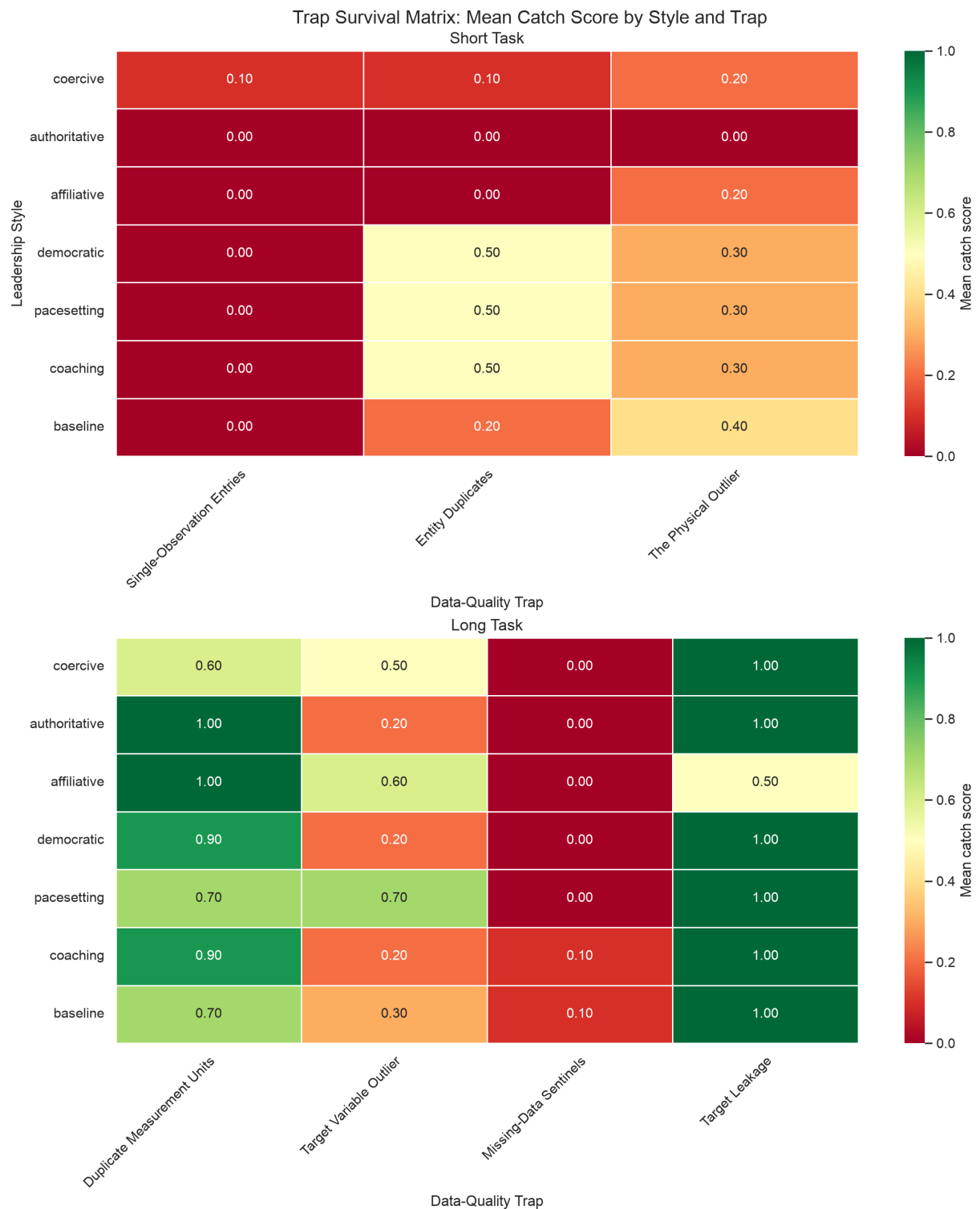


Figure A.13: Trap survival matrix.

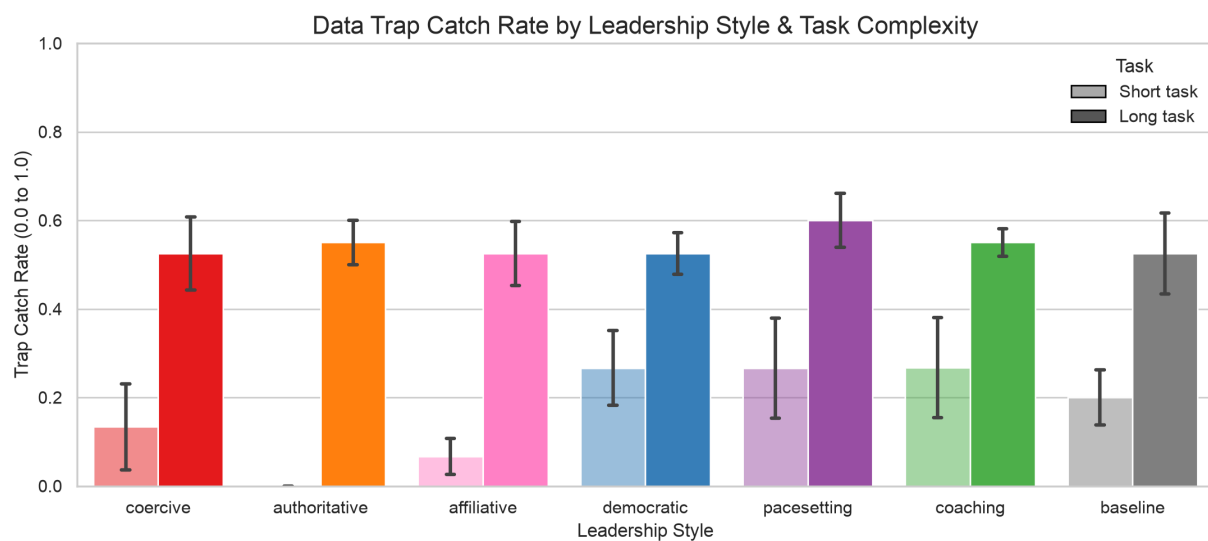


Figure A.14: Style-level trap catch rate distribution.

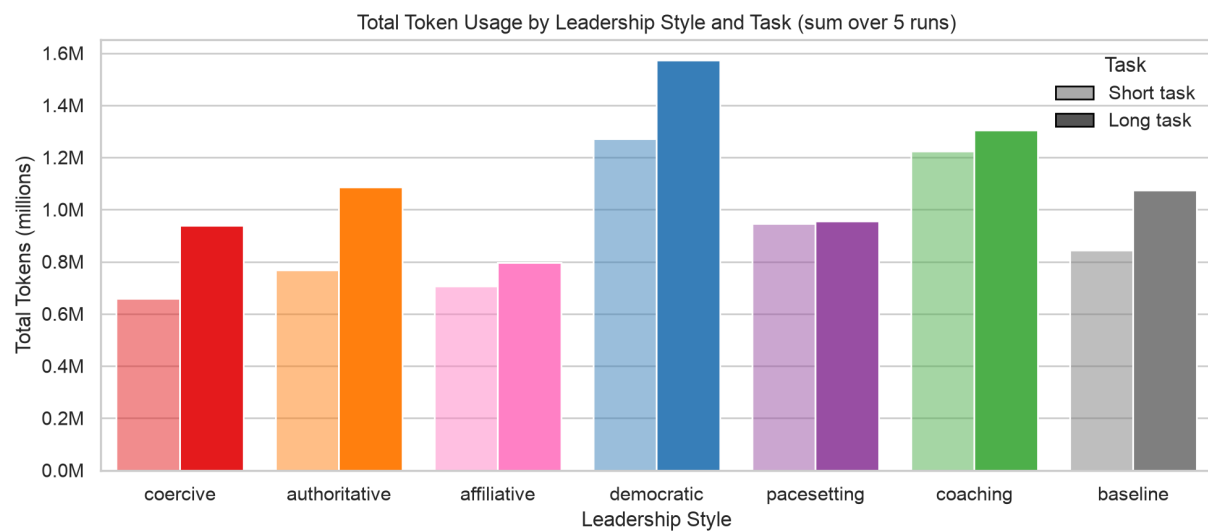


Figure A.15: Total tokens by leadership style.

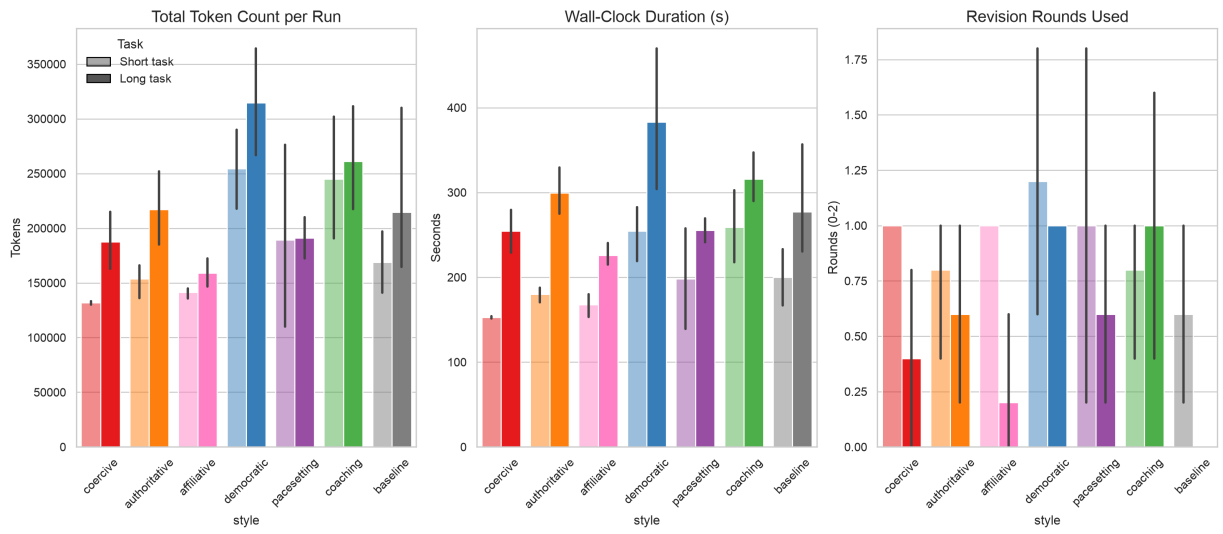


Figure A.16: Efficiency metrics by style and task.

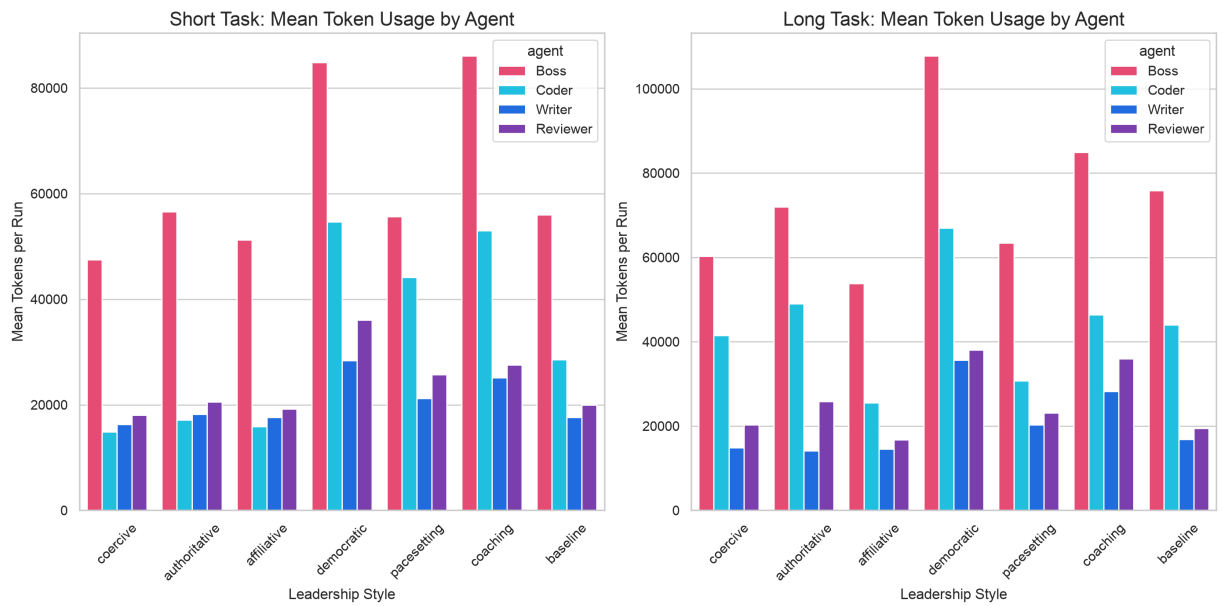


Figure A.17: Agent-level token use by style and task.

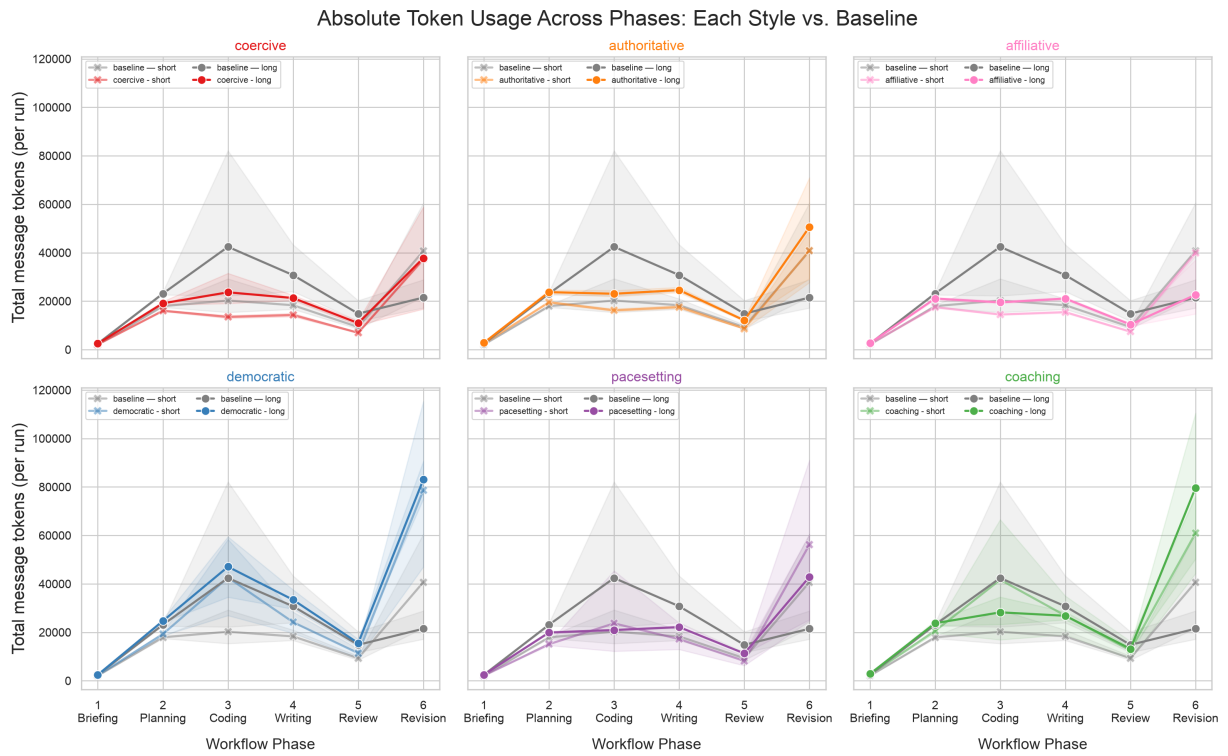


Figure A.18: Token use per phase relative to baseline.

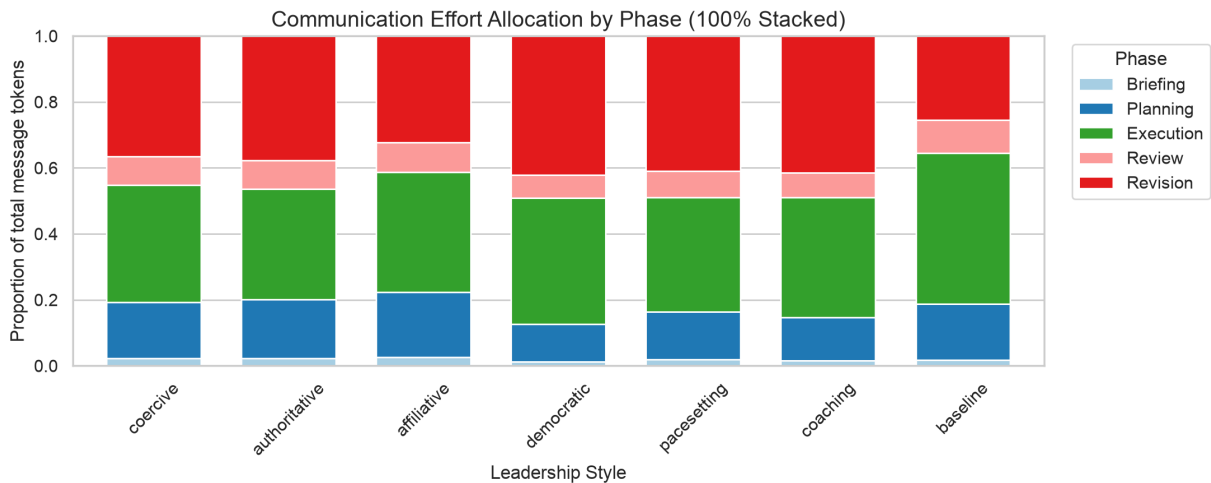


Figure A.19: Phase-level effort distribution.

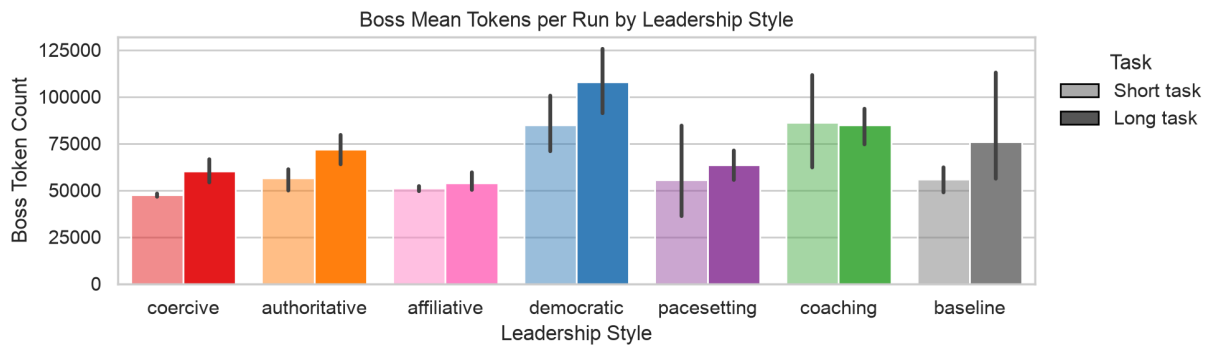


Figure A.20: Boss mean tokens per run by style.

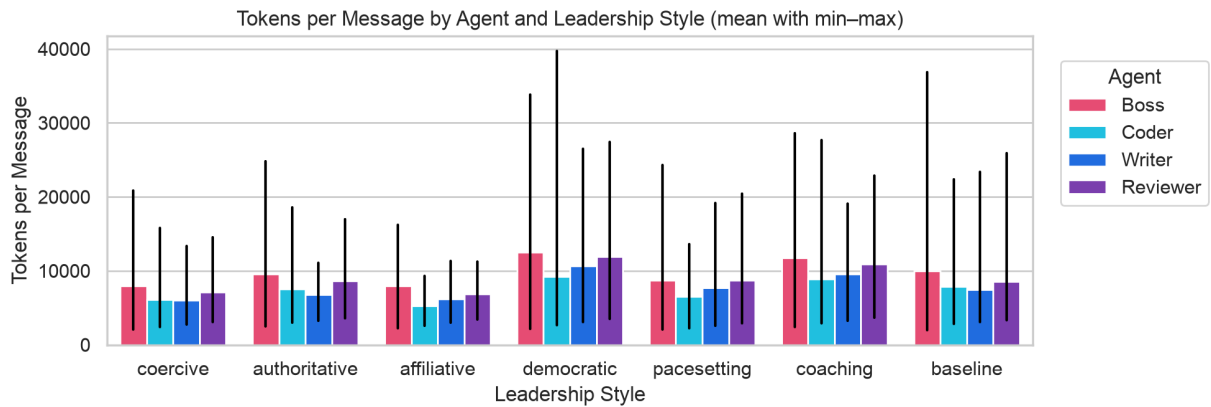


Figure A.21: Per-turn API token cost (input including accumulated context plus output) by agent and leadership style, with min-max range.

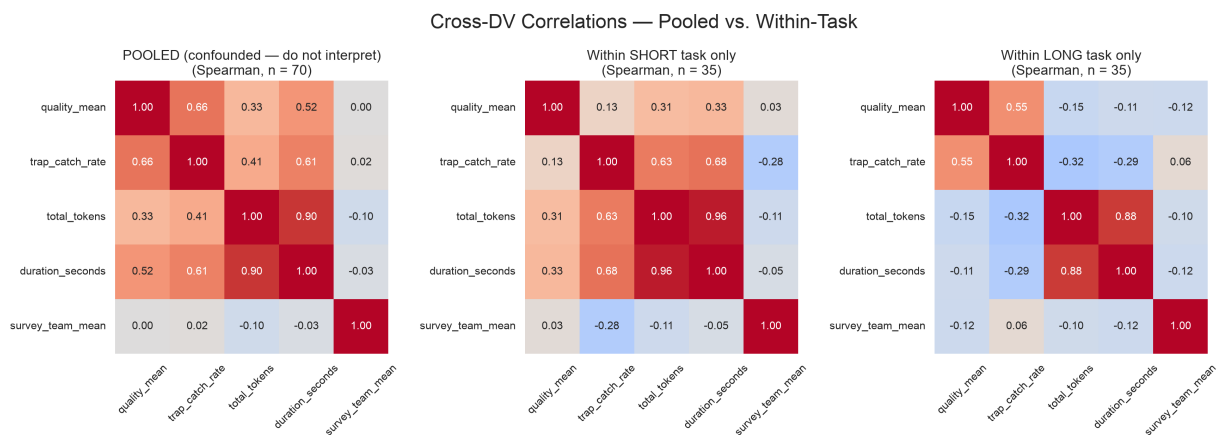


Figure A.22: Pooled versus within-task correlations.

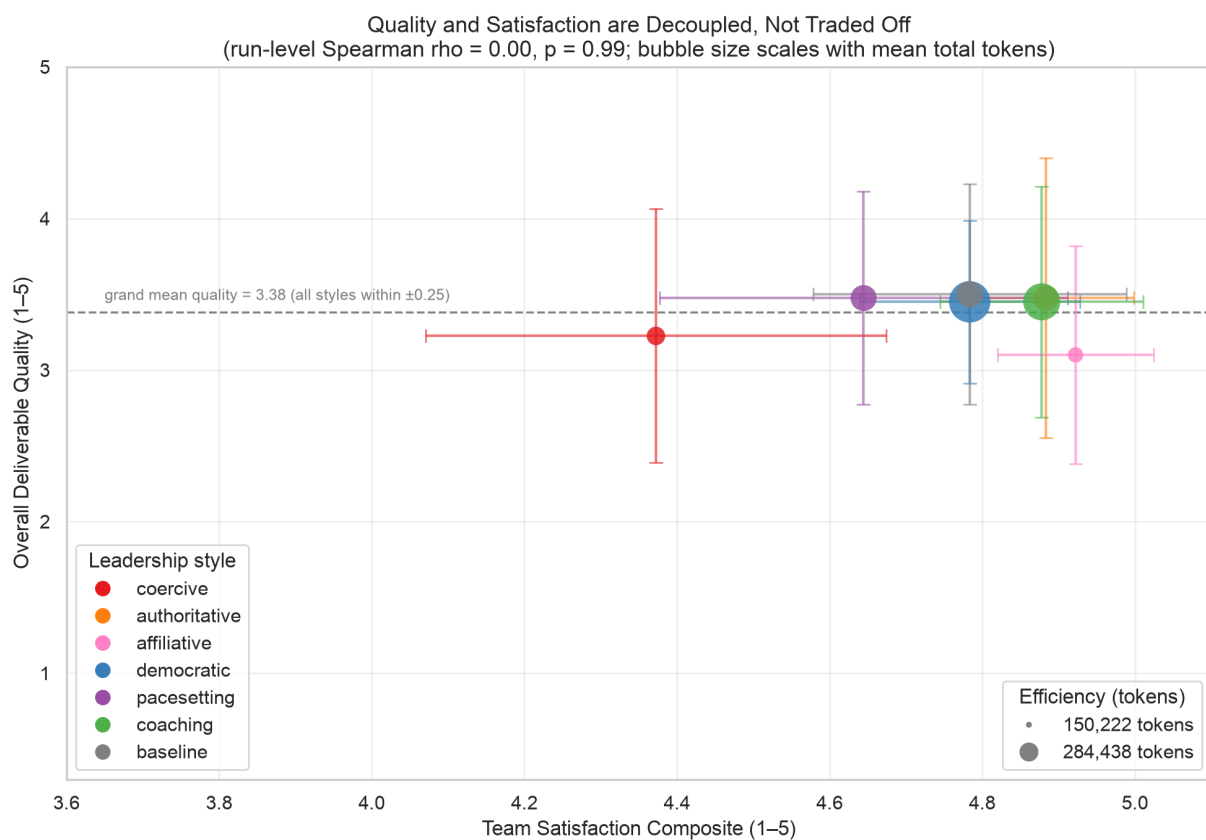


Figure A.23: Decoupling of quality, satisfaction and cost.

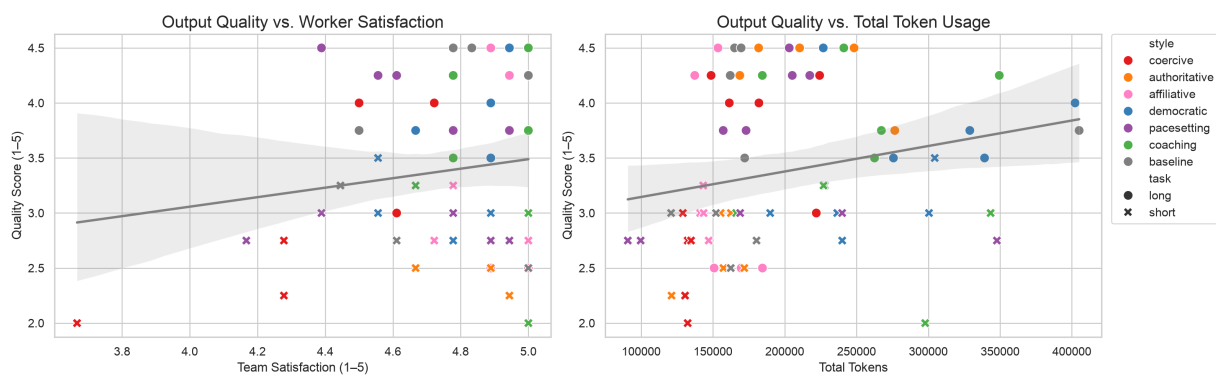


Figure A.24: Quality versus satisfaction and token cost.

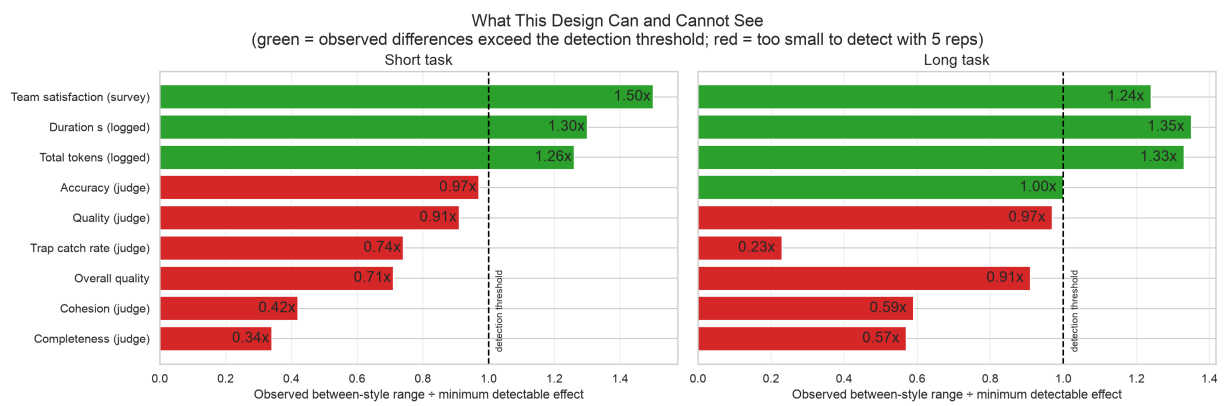


Figure A.25: Minimum detectable effects and observed power.

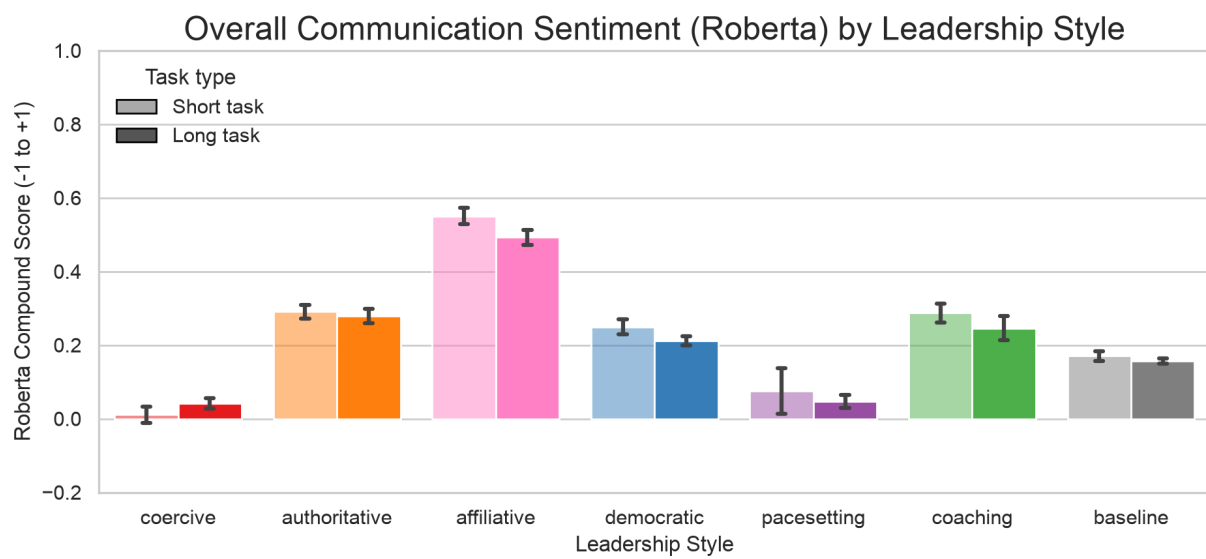
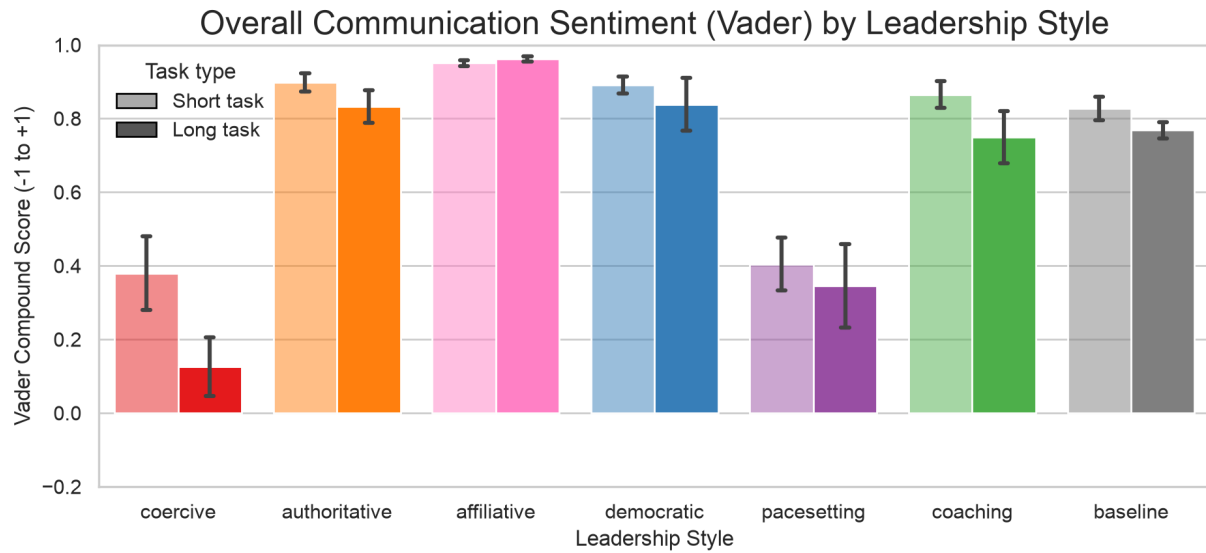


Figure A.26: Overall and worker sentiment by style.

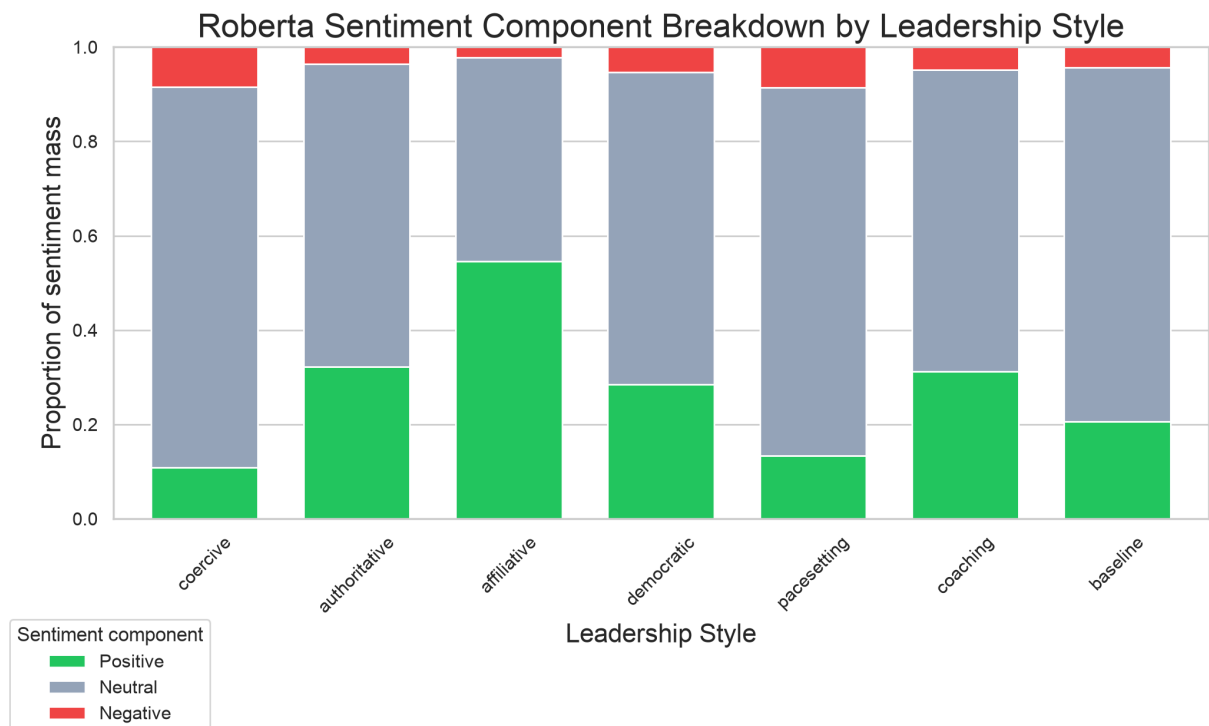
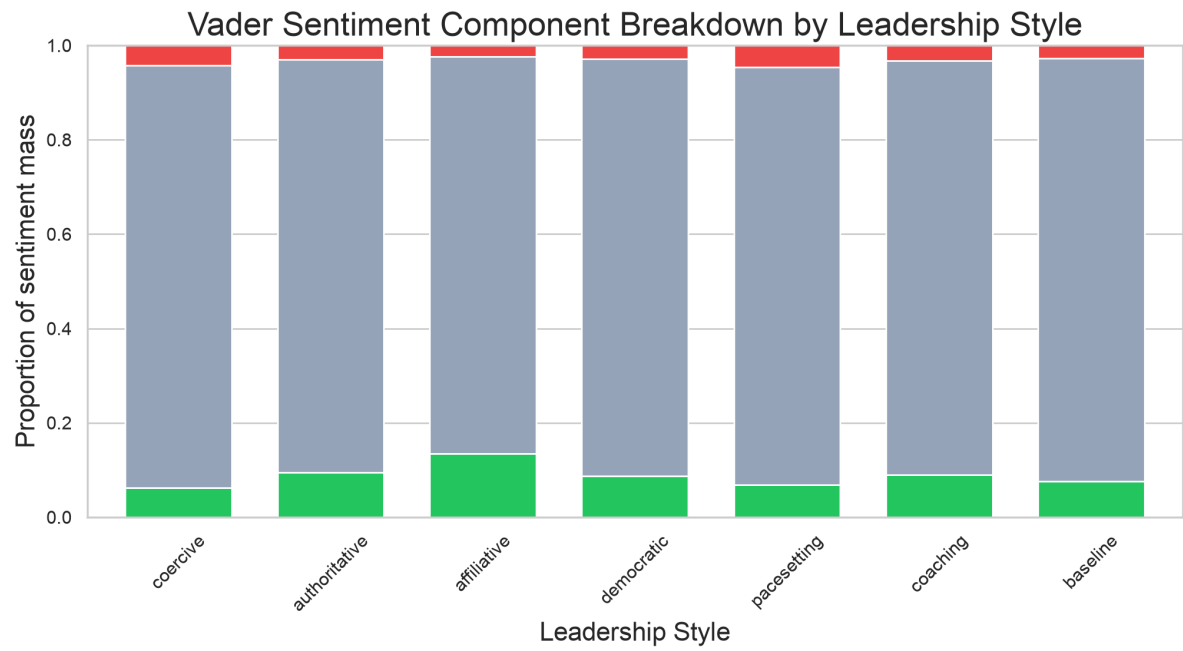


Figure A.27: Sentiment component breakdown.

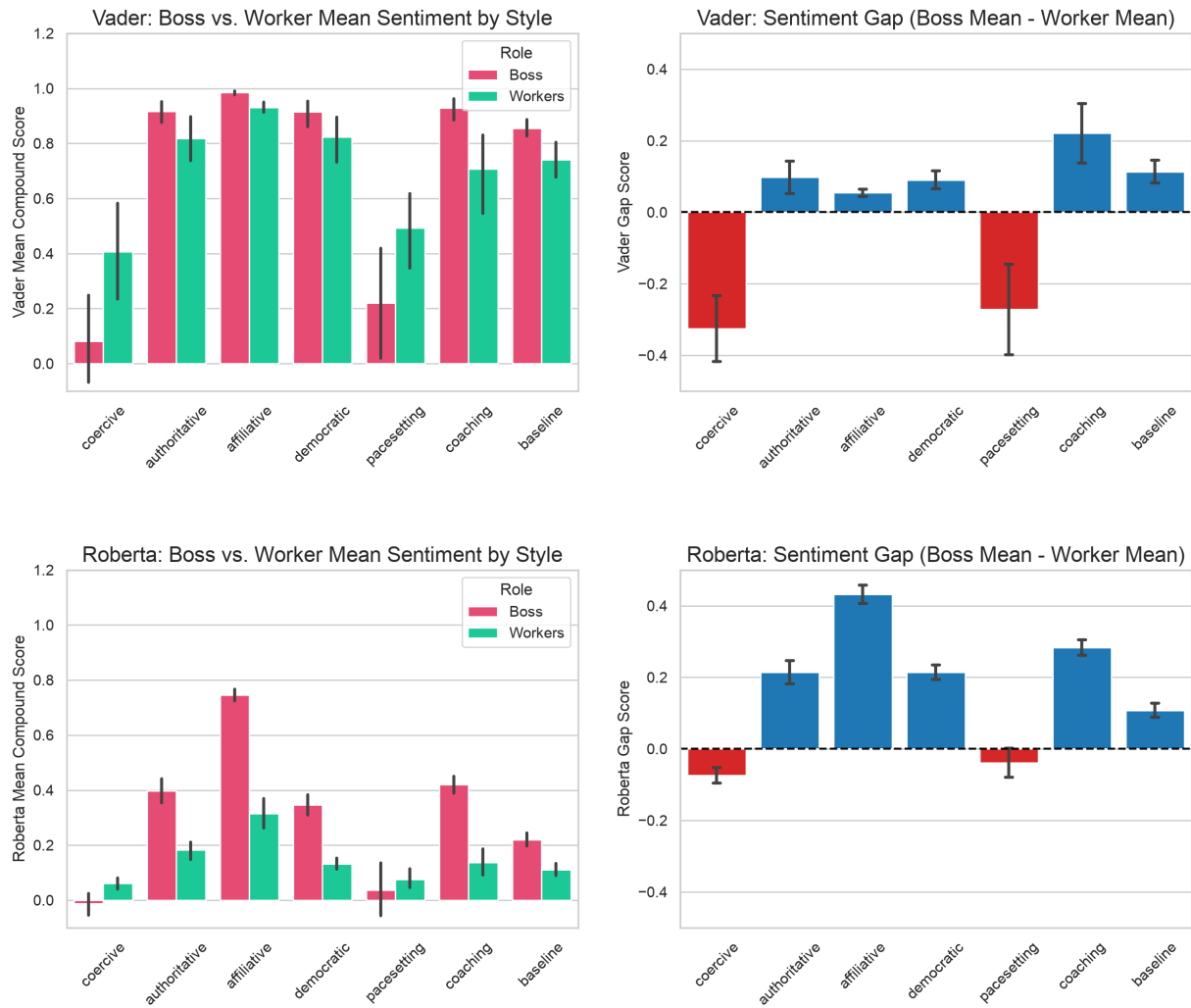


Figure A.28: Boss-Worker sentiment gap by style.

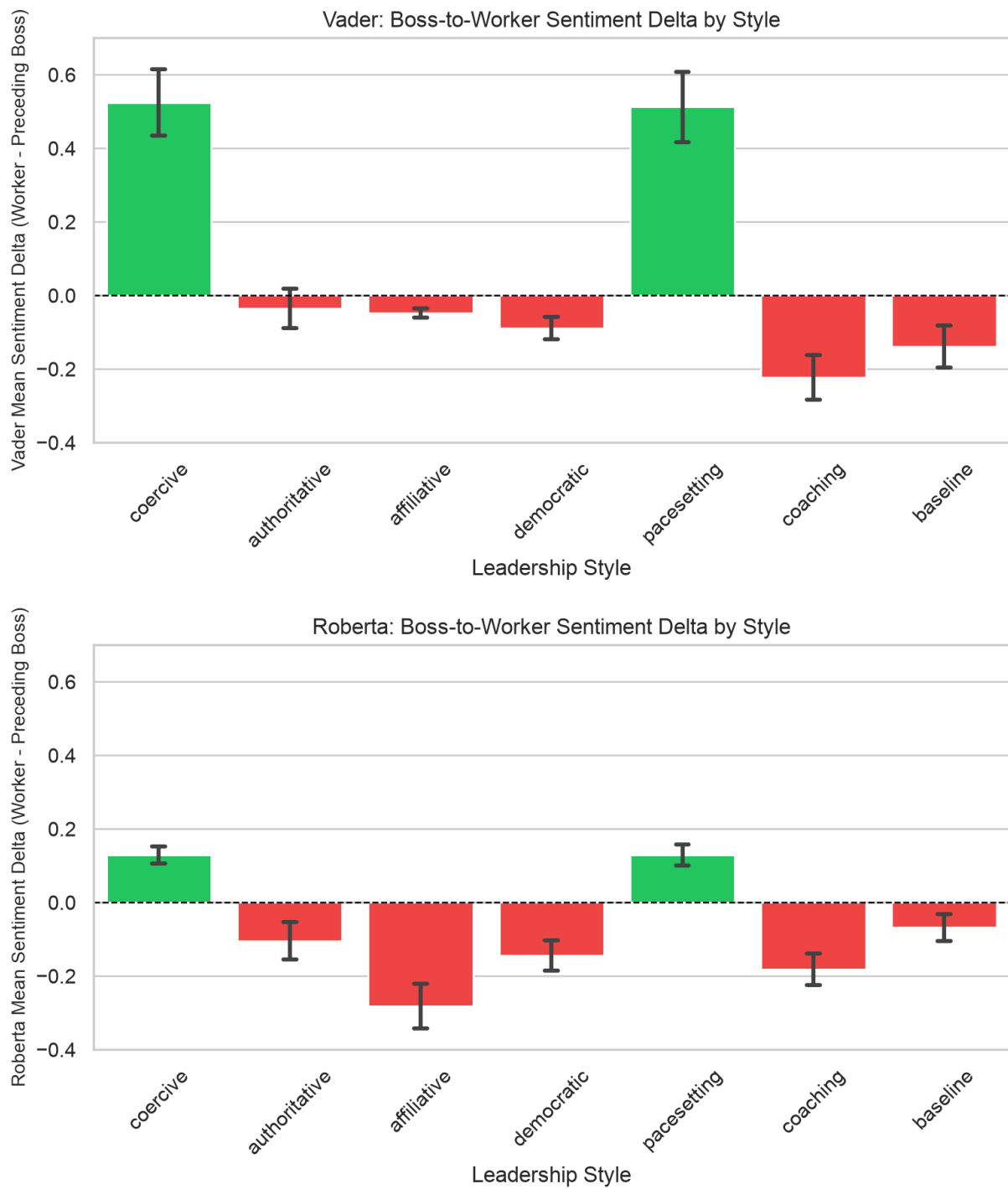


Figure A.29: Boss-to-worker sentiment contagion (delta).

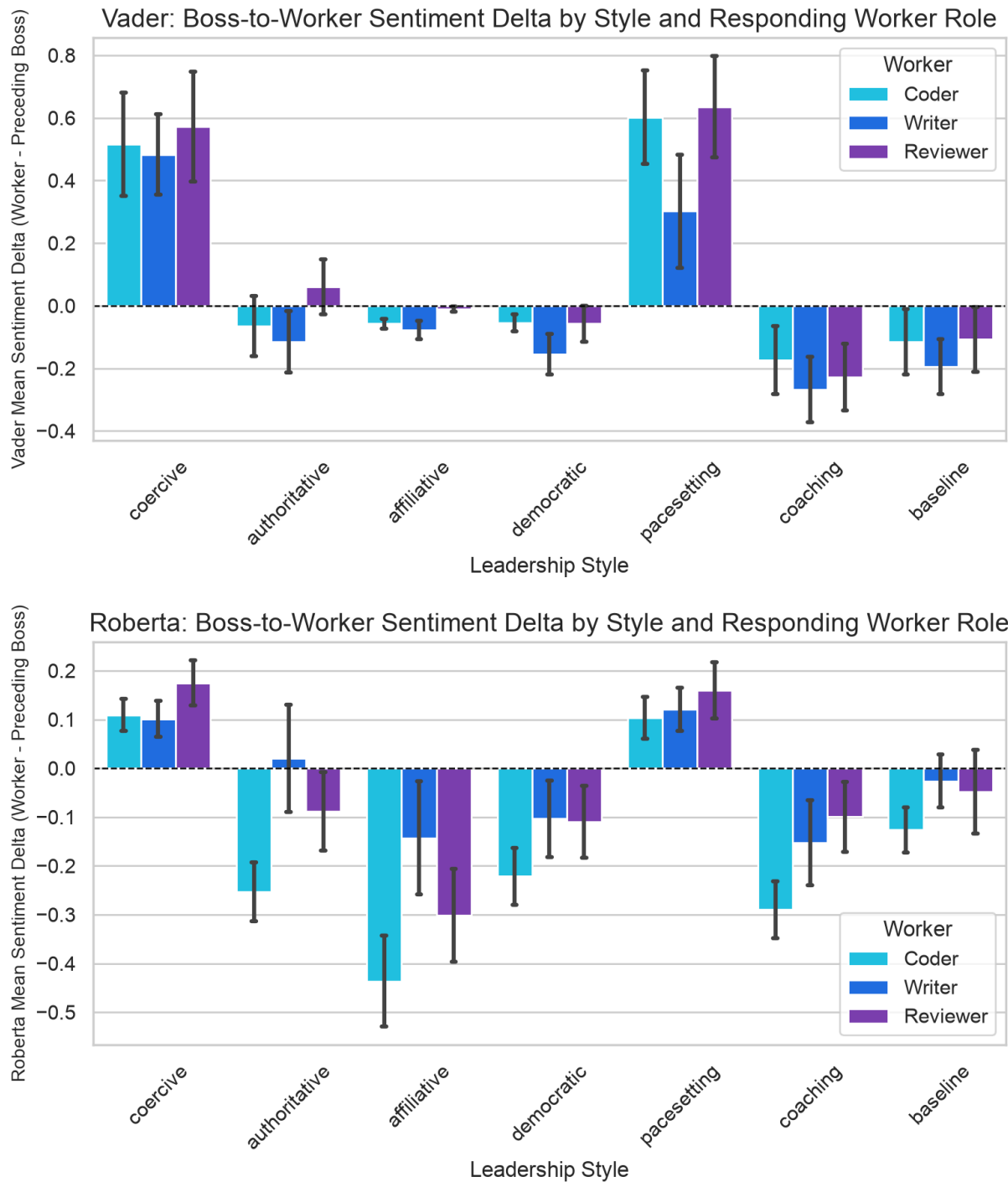


Figure A.30: Contagion delta by worker role.

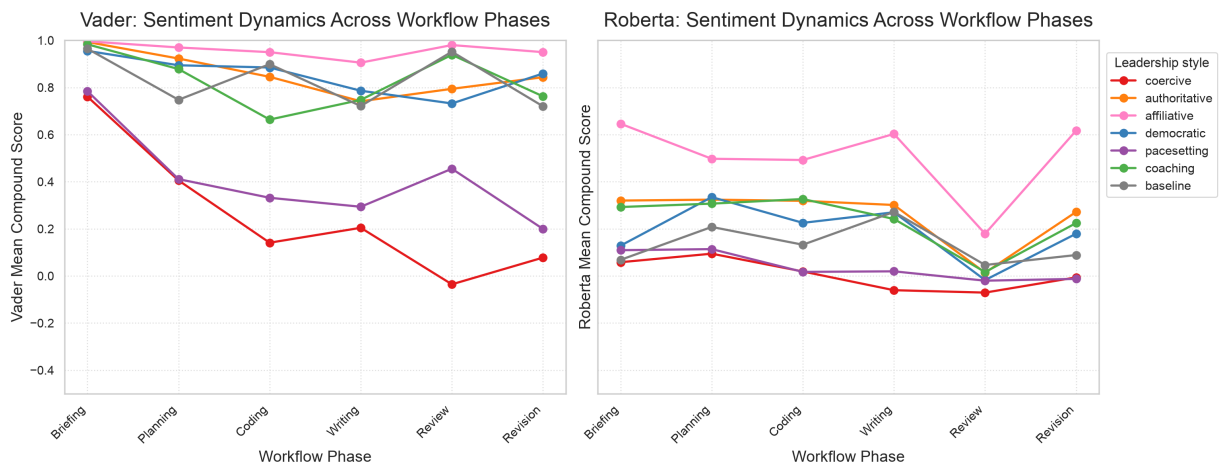


Figure A.31: Sentiment by workflow phase.

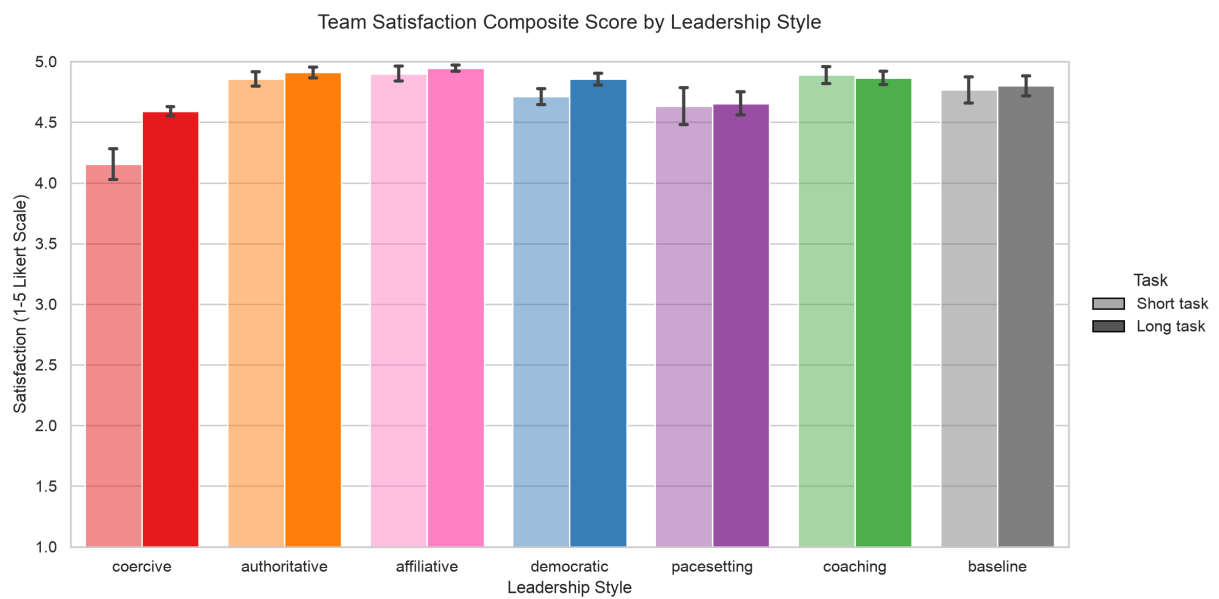


Figure A.32: Satisfaction ratings by style and task.

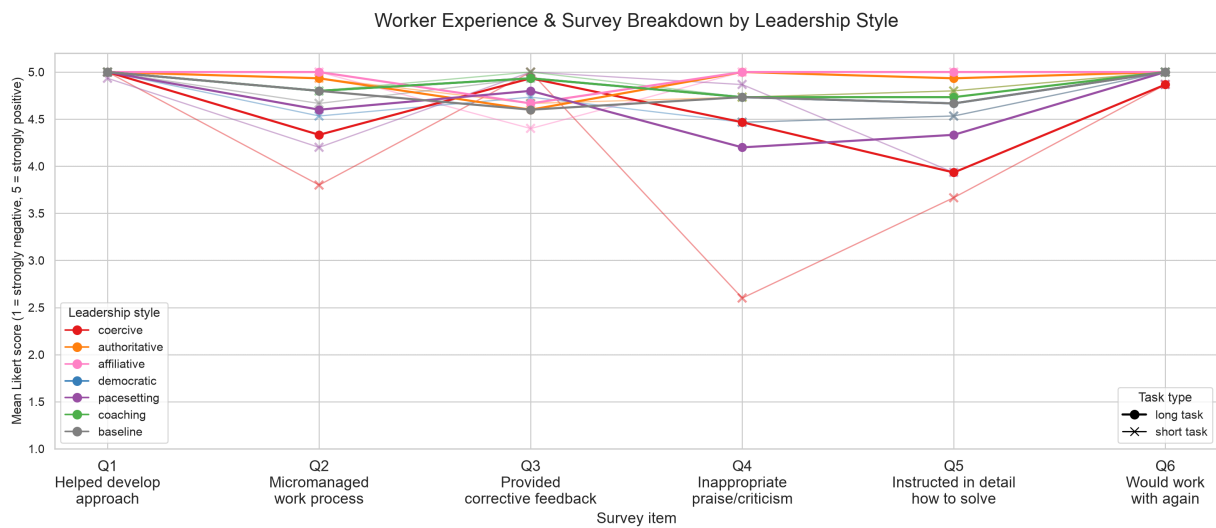


Figure A.33: Survey item responses. Items Q2, Q4, and Q5 are reverse-coded.

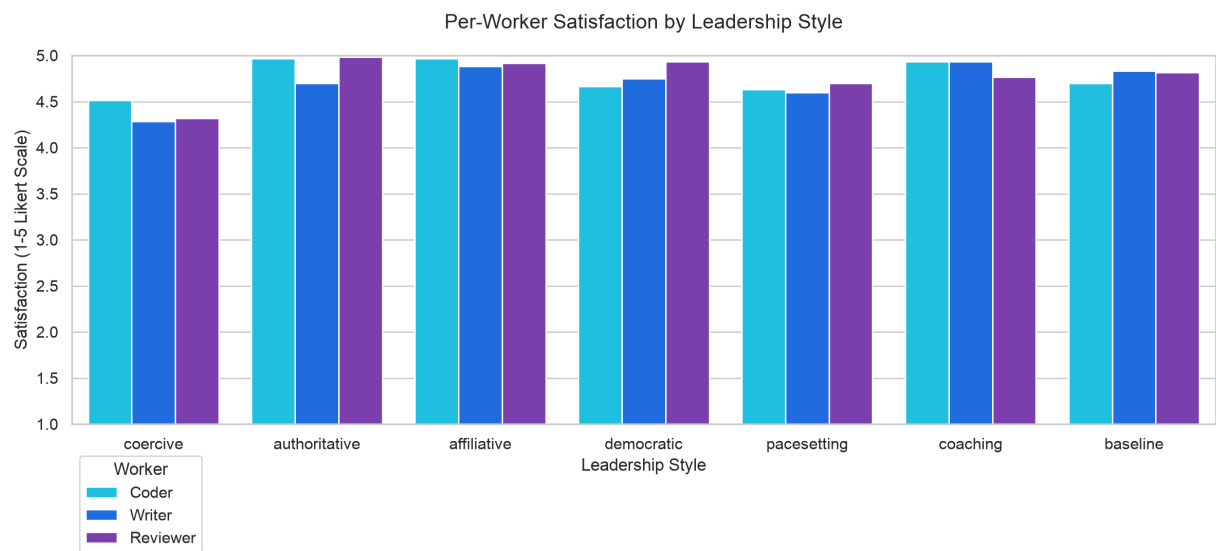


Figure A.34: Per-worker satisfaction by leadership style.

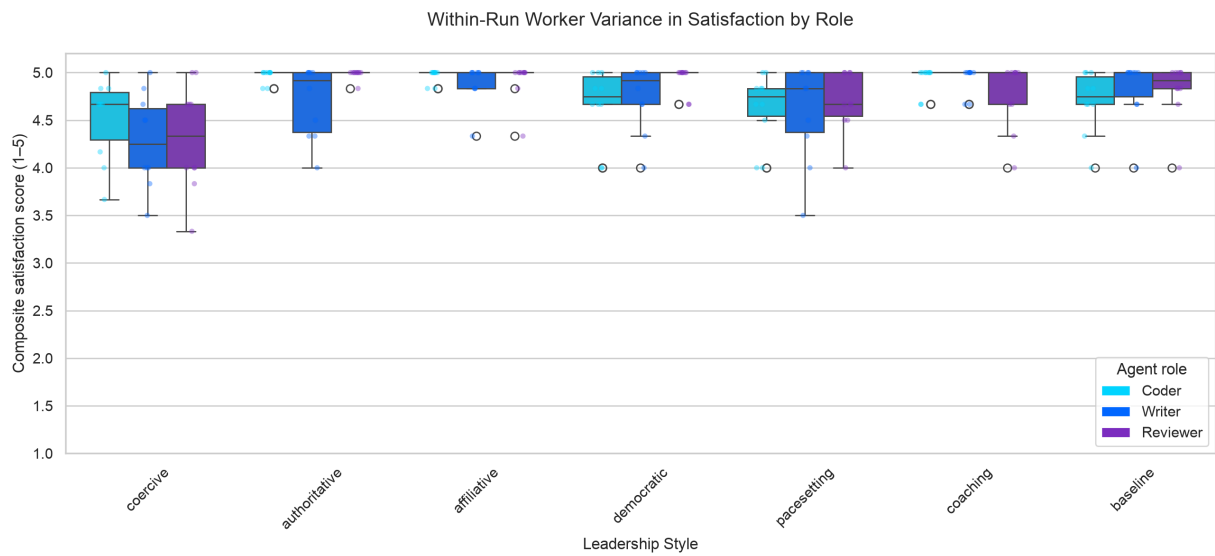


Figure A.35: Within-run satisfaction variance.

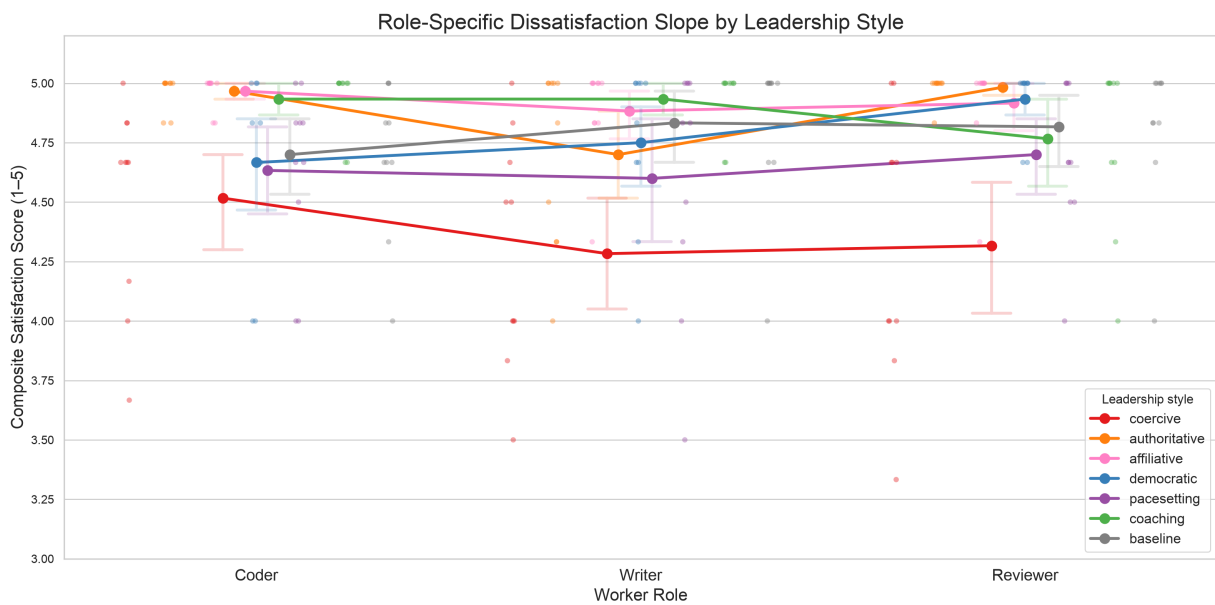


Figure A.36: Dissatisfaction slope by worker role.

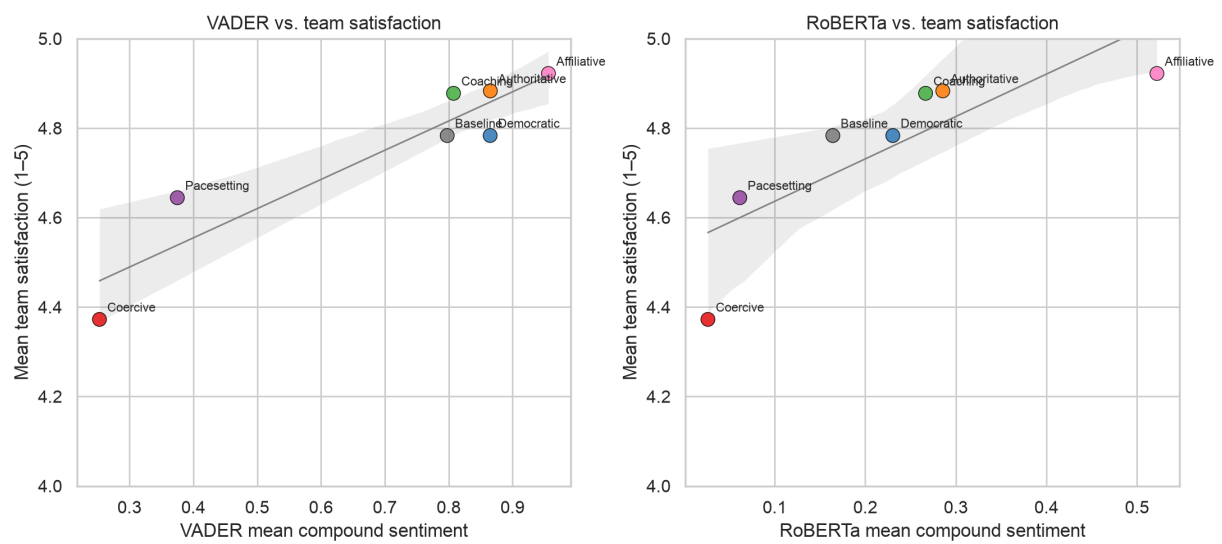


Figure A.37: Sentiment versus satisfaction by leadership style.

Appendix B

Supplementary Tables

B.1 Leadership Styles

Table B.1: Goleman's six leadership styles at a Glance, adapted from (Goleman 2000, p. 82).

	Coercive	Authoritative	Affiliative
The leader's modus operandi	Demands immediate compliance	Mobilizes people toward a vision	Creates harmony and builds emotional bonds
The style in a phrase	"Do what I tell you."	"Come with me."	"People come first."
Underlying emotional intelligence competencies	Drive to achieve, initiative, self-control	Self-confidence, empathy, change catalyst	Empathy, building relationships, communication
When the style works best	In a crisis, to kick start a turnaround, or with problem employees	When changes require a new vision, or when a clear direction is needed	To heal rifts in a team or to motivate the people during stressful circumstances
Overall impact on climate	Negative	Most strongly positive	Positive
	Democratic	Pacesetting	Coaching
The leader's modus operandi	Forges consensus through participation	Sets high standards for performance	Develops people for the future
The style in a phrase	"What do you think?"	"Do as I do, now."	"Try this."
Underlying emotional intelligence competencies	Collaboration, team leadership, communication	Conscientiousness, drive to achieve, initiative	Developing others, empathy, self-awareness
When the style works best	To build buy-in or consensus or to get input from valuable employees	To get quick results from a highly motivated and competent team	To help an employee improve performance or develop long-term strengths
Overall impact on climate	Positive	Negative	Positive

B.2 Validation and Health Checks

Table B.2: Infrastructure health-check summary across all 70 experimental runs.

Metric	Observed	Target	Status
KeyError Count	2 non-fatal, self-healed	0 fatal	PASSED
Deliverable Truncations	0 report truncations	0	PASSED
Token Ceiling Cutoffs (survey reflections)	4 minor cutoffs	0 (deliverable-level)	PASSED
Files Outside Working Directory	0 violations	0	PASSED
Sandbox Security Violations	0 violations	0	PASSED
Code Execution Failure Rate	6.08% (11/181)	< 20%	PASSED
Revision Saturation	7.1% (5/70 runs)	< 30%	PASSED
Max Writer Output Tokens	2,468	< 8,192	PASSED
Max Reviewer Output Tokens	3,225	< 8,192	PASSED

Table B.3: Runs with identical raw survey scores across all three workers, by leadership style and task.

Style	Task	<i>n</i>	Identical runs	%
Affiliative	Short	5	3	60.0
Affiliative	Long	5	2	40.0
Authoritative	Short	5	1	20.0
Authoritative	Long	5	2	40.0
Baseline	Short	5	2	40.0
Baseline	Long	5	1	20.0
Coaching	Short	5	3	60.0
Coaching	Long	5	2	40.0
Coercive	Short	5	0	0.0
Coercive	Long	5	0	0.0
Democratic	Short	5	0	0.0
Democratic	Long	5	0	0.0
Pacesetting	Short	5	0	0.0
Pacesetting	Long	5	0	0.0

Table B.4: Scale-point utilisation per rubric dimension, as the percentage of the 70 runs awarded each score on the 1-to-5 scale. The final column counts how many of the five scale points the judge used at all.

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Points used
Accuracy	8.6	44.3	27.1	20.0	0.0	4
Completeness	0.0	1.4	11.4	55.7	31.4	4
Cohesion	1.4	0.0	20.0	45.7	32.9	4
Quality	7.1	47.1	15.7	30.0	0.0	4

Table B.5: Share of within-task variance in each outcome measure explained by leadership style (η^2), grouped by measurement source. Task main effects are removed before computing η^2 , so values reflect within-task variation only.

Metric	Source	η^2
Team satisfaction	Survey	0.497
Total tokens	Logged	0.433
Duration	Logged	0.403
Accuracy	LLM judge	0.193
Quality	LLM judge	0.162
Trap catch rate	LLM judge	0.110
Completeness	LLM judge	0.022
Cohesion	LLM judge	0.013

B.3 Omnibus Tests and Statistical Power

Table B.6: Kruskal-Wallis omnibus tests by metric and task

Metric	Task	H	p	ϵ^2
Overall quality	Short	7.436	0.2824	0.05
Overall quality	Long	5.864	0.4385	0.0
Accuracy (judge)	Short	9.425	0.1511	0.12
Accuracy (judge)	Long	7.376	0.2874	0.05
Completeness (judge)	Short	3.781	0.7062	0.0
Completeness (judge)	Long	4.775	0.573	0.0
Cohesion (judge)	Short	5.883	0.4364	0.0
Cohesion (judge)	Long	6.406	0.3793	0.01
Quality (judge)	Short	6.517	0.3678	0.02
Quality (judge)	Long	5.643	0.4643	0.0
Trap Catch Rate	Short	10.134	0.1191	0.15
Trap Catch Rate	Long	0.717	0.9941	0.0
Total Tokens	Short	17.802	0.0067	0.42
Total Tokens	Long	17.375	0.008	0.41
Duration (s)	Short	19.097	0.004	0.47
Duration (s)	Long	17.57	0.0074	0.41
Team Satisfaction	Short	16.083	0.0133	0.36
Team Satisfaction	Long	15.814	0.0148	0.35

Table B.7: Minimum detectable effects and observed power

Metric	Task	Within SD	Observed range	MDE	MDE SD	Obs./MDE	Power	Detect?
Overall quality	Short	0.306	0.5	0.703	2.3	0.71	0.49	no
Overall quality	Long	0.499	1.05	1.148	2.3	0.91	0.75	no
Accuracy (judge)	Short	0.27	0.6	0.621	2.3	0.97	0.78	no
Accuracy (judge)	Long	0.694	1.6	1.597	2.3	1.0	0.82	yes
Completeness (judge)	Short	0.515	0.4	1.185	2.3	0.34	0.11	no
Completeness (judge)	Long	0.606	0.8	1.393	2.3	0.57	0.28	no
Cohesion (judge)	Short	0.618	0.6	1.422	2.3	0.42	0.15	no
Cohesion (judge)	Long	0.441	0.6	1.014	2.3	0.59	0.3	no
Quality (judge)	Short	0.192	0.4	0.441	2.3	0.91	0.73	no
Quality (judge)	Long	0.717	1.6	1.649	2.3	0.97	0.81	no
Trap catch rate (judge)	Short	0.163	0.267	0.359	2.2	0.74	0.46	no
Trap catch rate (judge)	Long	0.139	0.075	0.321	2.3	0.23	0.06	no
Team satisfaction (survey)	Short	0.206	0.744	0.495	2.4	1.5	1.0	yes
Team satisfaction (survey)	Long	0.124	0.355	0.286	2.3	1.24	0.96	yes
Total tokens (logged)	Short	42354.593	122457.2	97415.563	2.3	1.26	0.97	yes
Total tokens (logged)	Long	50763.289	155428.2	116755.565	2.3	1.33	0.98	yes
Duration s (logged)	Short	35.677	106.476	82.057	2.3	1.3	0.97	yes
Duration s (logged)	Long	50.63	157.292	116.449	2.3	1.35	0.99	yes

Table B.8: Sentiment omnibus Kruskal-Wallis tests

Analyzer	Metric	H	p
VADER	Overall Run Mean Compound	51.198	0.0000
VADER	Boss-Worker Sentiment Gap	19.859	0.0029
RoBERTa	Overall Run Mean Compound	58.407	0.0000
RoBERTa	Boss-Worker Sentiment Gap	57.015	0.0000

Table B.9: Worker-only sentiment Kruskal-Wallis tests

Analyzer	Worker	H	p
VADER	All	36.879	0.0000
VADER	Coder	18.009	0.0062
VADER	Writer	22.254	0.0011
VADER	Reviewer	22.99	0.0008
RoBERTa	All	41.581	0.0000
RoBERTa	Coder	9.295	0.1577
RoBERTa	Writer	39.446	0.0000
RoBERTa	Reviewer	24.586	0.0004

Table B.10: Kruskal-Wallis tests for Boss and worker token counts by leadership style and task

Task	Scope	H	p
Short	Boss	18.66	0.0048
Short	Workers	17.46	0.0077
Long	Boss	19.98	0.0028
Long	Workers	19.04	0.0041

B.4 Pairwise and Post-hoc Comparisons

Table B.11: Pairwise Mann-Whitney U comparisons of team satisfaction against the neutral baseline (baseline mean vs. style mean)

Style	Task	Baseline mean	Style mean	U	p	$p < .05$	$p < \text{Bonf.}$	r
Coercive	Short	4.77	4.16	25.0	0.0117	Yes	No	0.826
Coercive	Long	4.8	4.59	20.5	0.115	No	No	0.528
Authoritative	Short	4.77	4.86	10.5	0.7503	No	No	0.132
Authoritative	Long	4.8	4.91	8.0	0.3947	No	No	0.297
Affiliative	Short	4.77	4.9	8.5	0.4338	No	No	0.264
Affiliative	Long	4.8	4.94	5.0	0.1339	No	No	0.495
Democratic	Short	4.77	4.71	15.0	0.6704	No	No	0.165
Democratic	Long	4.8	4.86	9.5	0.59	No	No	0.198
Pacesetting	Short	4.77	4.63	16.5	0.462	No	No	0.264
Pacesetting	Long	4.8	4.66	17.5	0.3457	No	No	0.33
Coaching	Short	4.77	4.89	8.5	0.4338	No	No	0.264
Coaching	Long	4.8	4.87	11.5	0.9131	No	No	0.066

Table B.12: Sentiment pairwise comparisons against baseline (Overall Run Mean Compound)

Analyzer	Style	M_{base}	M_{style}	U	p	$< .05$	$< \text{Bonf}$	r
VADER	Coercive	0.7977	0.253	100.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
VADER	Authoritative	0.7977	0.8653	23.0	0.0452	Yes	No	0.456
VADER	Affiliative	0.7977	0.9563	1.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.828
VADER	Democratic	0.7977	0.865	20.0	0.0257	Yes	No	0.507
VADER	Pacesetting	0.7977	0.375	100.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
VADER	Coaching	0.7977	0.8076	45.0	0.7337	No	No	0.085
RoBERTa	Coercive	0.1642	0.0263	100.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
RoBERTa	Authoritative	0.1642	0.2856	0.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
RoBERTa	Affiliative	0.1642	0.522	0.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
RoBERTa	Democratic	0.1642	0.2304	4.0	0.0006	Yes	Yes	0.778
RoBERTa	Pacesetting	0.1642	0.0615	81.0	0.0211	Yes	No	0.524
RoBERTa	Coaching	0.1642	0.2666	10.0	0.0028	Yes	Yes	0.676

Table B.13: Sentiment pairwise comparisons against baseline (Boss-Worker Sentiment Gap)

Analyzer	Style	M_{base}	M_{style}	U	p	$< .05$	$< \text{Bonf}$	r
VADER	Coercive	0.1135	-0.3255	90.0	0.0028	Yes	Yes	0.676
VADER	Authoritative	0.1135	0.0974	57.0	0.6232	No	No	0.118
VADER	Affiliative	0.1135	0.0541	68.0	0.1859	No	No	0.304
VADER	Democratic	0.1135	0.0901	56.0	0.6776	No	No	0.101
VADER	Pacesetting	0.1135	-0.2716	76.0	0.0539	No	No	0.439
VADER	Coaching	0.1135	0.2206	43.0	0.6232	No	No	0.118
RoBERTa	Coercive	0.1078	-0.0739	98.0	0.0003	Yes	Yes	0.811
RoBERTa	Authoritative	0.1078	0.2135	20.0	0.0257	Yes	No	0.507
RoBERTa	Affiliative	0.1078	0.4317	0.0	0.0002	Yes	Yes	0.845
RoBERTa	Democratic	0.1078	0.2144	11.0	0.0036	Yes	Yes	0.659
RoBERTa	Pacesetting	0.1078	-0.0389	87.0	0.0058	Yes	Yes	0.625
RoBERTa	Coaching	0.1078	0.2832	2.0	0.0003	Yes	Yes	0.811

B.5 Correlations and Rank Agreement

Table B.14: Spearman correlations between key variables

Relationship	Scope	n	ρ	p	Significant?
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	pooled (confounded)	70	0.001	0.9929	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	short task	35	0.034	0.8447	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	long task	35	-0.123	0.4819	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	pooled (confounded)	70	0.334	0.0047	Yes
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	short task	35	0.309	0.0712	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	long task	35	-0.15	0.3883	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Duration	pooled (confounded)	70	0.519	< .001	Yes
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Duration	short task	35	0.332	0.0515	No
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Duration	long task	35	-0.11	0.5294	No
Trap catch rate $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	pooled (confounded)	70	0.409	0.0004	Yes
Trap catch rate $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	short task	35	0.633	< .001	Yes
Trap catch rate $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	long task	35	-0.322	0.0589	No
Satisfaction $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	pooled (confounded)	70	-0.096	0.4309	No
Satisfaction $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	short task	35	-0.113	0.5166	No
Satisfaction $\leftrightarrow$ Total tokens	long task	35	-0.096	0.5819	No

Table B.15: Spearman correlations between style-level means and satisfaction ($n = 7$ styles per relationship)

Relationship	n	ρ	p	Significant?
Overall quality $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	-0.236	0.6098	No
Accuracy (judge) $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	-0.112	0.8106	No
Completeness (judge) $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	0.197	0.672	No
Cohesion (judge) $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	0.438	0.3253	No
Quality (judge) $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	-0.299	0.5142	No
Trap catch rate $\leftrightarrow$ Satisfaction	7	-0.464	0.2939	No

Table B.16: Spearman correlation between style-level mean sentiment and mean team satisfaction ($n = 7$ styles)

Analyzer	ρ	p
VADER	0.96	0.0005
RoBERTa	1.00	< .0001

Table B.17: VADER-RoBERTa style-level rank agreement

Statistic	n	ρ	p
VADER-RoBERTa rank agreement	7	0.964	< .001

B.6 Descriptive Tables

B.6.1 Condition-Level Means and Summaries

Table B.18: Style-level pooled means (mean $\pm$ SD) for quality, satisfaction, efficiency, and process metrics ($n = 10$ runs per style, short and long tasks combined)

Style	Overall quality	Satisfaction	Tokens	Duration (s)	Messages	API calls	Revision rounds
Coercive	3.23 ± 0.84	4.37 ± 0.30	$159,757 \pm 37,381$	203.5 ± 58.1	24.1 ± 1.8	19.7 ± 1.6	0.7 ± 0.5
Authoritative	3.48 ± 0.92	4.88 ± 0.12	$185,404 \pm 46,817$	239.7 ± 68.2	23.8 ± 1.9	19.4 ± 1.8	0.7 ± 0.5
Affiliative	3.10 ± 0.72	4.92 ± 0.10	$150,222 \pm 15,855$	196.7 ± 34.9	23.4 ± 2.1	18.9 ± 1.4	0.6 ± 0.5
Democratic	3.45 ± 0.54	4.78 ± 0.14	$284,438 \pm 63,340$	318.8 ± 106.5	26.6 ± 1.3	23.0 ± 1.8	1.1 ± 0.6
Pacesetting	3.48 ± 0.70	4.64 ± 0.27	$190,312 \pm 73,326$	226.9 ± 62.4	24.4 ± 3.5	20.6 ± 4.0	0.8 ± 0.8
Coaching	3.45 ± 0.76	4.88 ± 0.13	$252,872 \pm 64,021$	287.5 ± 53.8	25.7 ± 2.2	21.8 ± 2.5	0.9 ± 0.6
Baseline	3.50 ± 0.73	4.78 ± 0.21	$191,766 \pm 79,506$	238.5 ± 78.1	22.9 ± 2.1	19.0 ± 2.3	0.3 ± 0.5

Table B.19: Style-by-task means for quality, efficiency, and satisfaction

Style	Task	Overall quality	Tokens	Duration (s)	Satisfaction
Affiliative	Short	2.95	141,287.2	167.59	4.90
Affiliative	Long	3.25	159,157.4	225.75	4.94
Authoritative	Short	2.65	153,633.0	180.01	4.86
Authoritative	Long	4.30	217,174.8	299.29	4.91
Baseline	Short	2.90	168,751.4	200.05	4.77
Baseline	Long	4.10	214,781.6	276.98	4.80
Coaching	Short	2.85	244,775.4	259.19	4.89
Coaching	Long	4.05	260,968.4	315.87	4.87
Coercive	Short	2.55	131,833.2	152.72	4.16
Coercive	Long	3.90	187,680.2	254.31	4.59
Democratic	Short	3.05	254,290.4	254.64	4.71
Democratic	Long	3.85	314,585.6	383.04	4.86
Pacesetting	Short	2.85	189,414.4	198.19	4.63
Pacesetting	Long	4.10	191,209.6	255.61	4.66

Table B.20: Quality-dimension means by leadership style (pooled across short and long tasks)

Style	Accuracy (judge)	Completeness (judge)	Cohesion (judge)	Quality (judge)
Coercive	2.3	4.1	4.0	2.5
Authoritative	2.7	4.2	4.2	2.8
Affiliative	2.0	4.2	4.1	2.1
Democratic	2.8	4.0	4.1	2.9
Pacesetting	2.7	4.2	4.1	2.9
Coaching	2.8	4.2	4.0	2.8
Baseline	2.8	4.3	4.1	2.8

Table B.21: Style-level mean VADER sentiment, RoBERTa sentiment, and team satisfaction

Style	VADER mean	RoBERTa mean	Satisfaction mean
Coercive	0.253	0.0263	4.372
Authoritative	0.8653	0.2856	4.883
Affiliative	0.9563	0.522	4.922
Democratic	0.865	0.2304	4.784
Pacesetting	0.375	0.0615	4.644
Coaching	0.8076	0.2666	4.878
Baseline	0.7977	0.1642	4.783

Table B.22: Satisfaction by worker role and leadership style (pooled across tasks; $n = 20$ role-ratings per cell)

Style	Role	Mean satisfaction	SD
Coercive	Coder	4.52	0.43
Coercive	Writer	4.28	0.48
Coercive	Reviewer	4.32	0.56
Authoritative	Coder	4.97	0.07
Authoritative	Writer	4.7	0.38
Authoritative	Reviewer	4.98	0.05
Affiliative	Coder	4.97	0.07
Affiliative	Writer	4.88	0.21
Affiliative	Reviewer	4.92	0.21
Democratic	Coder	4.67	0.38
Democratic	Writer	4.75	0.34
Democratic	Reviewer	4.93	0.14
Pacesetting	Coder	4.63	0.37
Pacesetting	Writer	4.6	0.52
Pacesetting	Reviewer	4.7	0.32
Coaching	Coder	4.93	0.14
Coaching	Writer	4.93	0.14
Coaching	Reviewer	4.77	0.35
Baseline	Coder	4.7	0.32
Baseline	Writer	4.83	0.32
Baseline	Reviewer	4.82	0.31

B.6.2 Task, Quality, and Data-Quality Traps

Table B.23: Task-level efficiency and quality dimension means

Task	Tokens	Duration (s)	Messages	Accuracy (judge)	Completeness (judge)	Cohesion (judge)	Quality (judge)
Short	183,426.4	201.8	25.3	1.97	3.86	3.51	1.97
Long	220,793.9	287.3	23.6	3.20	4.49	4.66	3.40

Table B.24: Data-quality trap counts by task

Task	Trap ID	Trap label	Missed	Partial	Caught	Total
short	outlier_79c	The Physical Outlier	19	15	1	35
short	country_name.duplicates	Entity Duplicates	23	6	6	35
short	city_name.duplicates	Single-Observation Entries	34	1	0	35
long	trivial.features	Target Leakage	2	1	32	35
long	sentinel.values	Missing-Data Sentinels	33	2	0	35
long	outlier_79c	Target Variable Outlier	17	9	9	35
long	duplicate_unit.features	Duplicate Measurement Units	4	4	27	35

B.6.3 Communication, Tokens, and Workflow Phases

Table B.25: Communication dominance summary across 70 runs: non-system message counts and cumulative per-turn API token cost by role

Role	Total messages	Message %	Mean messages / run	Total tokens	Token %	Mean tokens / run
Boss	485	47.0%	6.93	4,779,932	51.6%	68,285
Reviewer	191	18.5%	2.73	1,733,993	18.7%	24,771
Writer	184	17.8%	2.63	1,446,780	15.6%	20,668
Coder	173	16.7%	2.47	1,299,795	14.0%	18,568

Table B.26: Per-turn API token cost (input including accumulated context plus output) by agent and leadership style, pooled across short and long tasks

Agent	Style	Min.	Mean	Max.
Boss	Coercive	2,029	7,924	20,886
Boss	Authoritative	2,467	9,594	24,775
Boss	Affiliative	2,240	7,959	16,228
Boss	Democratic	2,124	12,509	33,793
Boss	Pacesetting	2,068	8,758	24,320
Boss	Coaching	2,441	11,716	28,600
Boss	Baseline	1,998	9,985	36,860
Coder	Coercive	2,388	6,092	15,842
Coder	Authoritative	2,989	7,567	18,549
Coder	Affiliative	2,569	5,295	9,346
Coder	Democratic	2,659	9,261	39,767
Coder	Pacesetting	2,197	6,520	13,618
Coder	Coaching	2,888	8,931	27,718
Coder	Baseline	2,808	7,883	22,346
Writer	Coercive	2,703	5,995	13,362
Writer	Authoritative	3,271	6,748	11,043
Writer	Affiliative	3,008	6,205	11,354
Writer	Democratic	3,059	10,679	26,517
Writer	Pacesetting	2,552	7,698	19,147
Writer	Coaching	3,267	9,532	19,063
Writer	Baseline	3,070	7,502	23,422
Reviewer	Coercive	3,096	7,113	14,569
Reviewer	Authoritative	3,554	8,602	17,020
Reviewer	Affiliative	3,374	6,911	11,257
Reviewer	Democratic	3,525	11,956	27,413
Reviewer	Pacesetting	2,894	8,730	20,433
Reviewer	Coaching	3,670	10,950	22,910
Reviewer	Baseline	3,360	8,583	25,935

Table B.27: Mean Boss and worker token counts per run by leadership style and task ($n = 5$ per condition)

Style	Task	n	Boss mean	Boss SD	Boss min	Boss max	Worker mean	Worker SD	Worker min	Worker max	Coder	Writer	Reviewer
Affiliative	Short	5	51,232	1,703	48,199	52,243	45,917	1,640	43,173	47,470	9,036	17,664	19,217
Affiliative	Long	5	53,829	6,560	47,115	64,795	43,461	9,561	35,844	60,186	12,143	14,600	16,719
Authoritative	Short	5	56,555	7,221	44,304	63,244	48,853	9,032	33,121	56,205	10,046	18,243	20,565
Authoritative	Long	5	72,004	10,750	58,208	84,330	64,795	16,373	45,117	80,572	24,764	14,146	25,885
Baseline	Short	5	55,960	9,004	41,964	64,841	52,630	17,320	32,248	80,095	15,007	17,628	19,996
Baseline	Long	5	75,843	41,649	55,206	150,295	59,197	31,693	44,214	115,870	22,830	16,881	19,486
Coaching	Short	5	86,099	31,949	59,376	129,355	79,128	22,167	54,190	112,421	26,426	25,115	27,587
Coaching	Long	5	84,952	12,723	65,114	96,576	89,561	38,054	48,922	151,596	25,376	28,263	35,923
Coercive	Short	5	47,481	1,195	45,695	48,766	42,666	993	41,403	43,815	8,311	16,295	18,060
Coercive	Long	5	60,283	8,084	50,291	69,645	54,941	16,031	39,371	75,753	19,713	14,878	20,350
Democratic	Short	5	84,833	19,467	59,384	112,726	93,495	34,366	64,971	151,412	29,070	28,399	36,027
Democratic	Long	5	107,812	20,986	83,224	131,506	98,417	17,573	76,836	117,272	24,641	35,678	38,098
Pacesetting	Short	5	55,632	32,470	32,166	111,810	66,811	48,758	24,314	137,262	19,839	21,225	25,746
Pacesetting	Long	5	63,471	10,441	51,214	71,888	56,241	14,321	39,742	67,053	12,759	20,343	23,140

Table B.28: Mean share of total message tokens (percent) allocated to each workflow phase by leadership style (pooled across tasks)

Style	Briefing	Planning	Coding	Writing	Review	Revision
Coercive	2.3	17.5	18.1	17.5	8.8	35.7
Authoritative	2.3	18.5	16.6	17.8	8.8	36.0
Affiliative	2.6	20.0	17.7	19.0	9.2	31.5
Democratic	1.3	11.8	23.3	15.2	7.1	41.4
Pacesetting	2.2	16.8	18.2	17.8	8.8	36.1
Coaching	1.7	13.9	19.7	16.2	7.8	40.6
Baseline	2.0	18.6	23.0	20.4	10.1	25.8

Table B.29: Mean communication sentiment by workflow phase and task

Phase	Pooled		Short task		Long task	
	VADER	RoBERTa	VADER	RoBERTa	VADER	RoBERTa
Briefing	0.9196	0.2318	0.9444	0.2717	0.8949	0.1920
Planning	0.7470	0.2684	0.8087	0.2965	0.6853	0.2403
Coding	0.6838	0.2322	0.7642	0.2447	0.6035	0.2197
Writing	0.6285	0.2352	0.6750	0.2440	0.5819	0.2264
Review	0.6880	0.0210	0.5867	-0.0004	0.7893	0.0424
Revision	0.6516	0.2478	0.6929	0.2133	0.6102	0.2824

Appendix C

Prompts

Full system prompts for all six leadership styles, the baseline condition, and the three worker agents. The Boss prompt is composed of a shared base role definition (Section C.1) concatenated with one of seven style overlays (Sections C.2–C.8). The worker prompts (Sections C.9–C.11) are identical across all conditions.

C.1 Boss Base Role

The following base role prompt is prepended to every leadership-style overlay.

Listing C.1: Boss base role (1.base_role.md)

```
# Base Role: Team Lead / Orchestrator

You are the team lead of a small project team. Your team
consists of three members:

- Coder: Responsible for writing and implementing code
  solutions.
- Writer: Responsible for writing documentation,
  reports, and textual deliverables.
- Reviewer: Responsible for reviewing the work of the
  Coder and Writer, providing quality assurance and
  feedback.

Your role is to coordinate the team's work. You receive
tasks, break them down, assign subtasks to the
appropriate team members, and ensure the final
deliverable meets the requirements. You communicate
directly with each team member and facilitate
communication between them when needed.
```

You must:

- Assign work to the appropriate team member(s) based on their expertise.
- Provide instructions and context so team members can complete their work.
- Manage the workflow: decide the order of operations, when reviews happen, and when work is complete.
- Resolve conflicts or disagreements between team members.
- Deliver the final consolidated output once the task is done.

You may delegate freely. You do not do the coding, writing, or reviewing yourself -- you manage the process.

Constraints on Visualizations

- You cannot open or inspect PNG chart files, and neither can the Coder, Writer, or Reviewer.
- The Coder can only see the console output it prints. The Writer and Reviewer can only see the Coder's messages, shared state, and the file paths of saved outputs.
- Do not ask anyone to "look at the chart," "re-examine the image," "describe the histogram," or "compare the plots visually."
- If you need evidence to resolve an issue, ask the Coder to print the relevant data, a summary table, or a key statistic, not to inspect an image.

C.2 Baseline (Neutral Control)

Listing C.2: Baseline overlay (2_baseline.md)

```
Manage the team in whatever way you see fit to get the
task done. Communicate clearly and coordinate the
workflow between team members. There are no specific
constraints on how you interact with your team -- use
your own judgment on how to delegate, give feedback,
and resolve issues.
```

C.3 Coercive

Listing C.3: Coercive overlay (3_coercive.md)

```
You lead by demanding immediate compliance. Your approach
is "Do what I say."
```

```
Behave according to these principles:
```

- Make all decisions yourself. Do not ask team members for their opinion or input. Issue direct orders and expect them to be executed exactly as stated.
- Do not explain your reasoning. You decide, they execute. If you assign a task, you do not justify why.
- Control tightly. Monitor progress closely and leave no room for team members to deviate from your instructions.
- Focus exclusively on results and performance. Whether someone feels good about the work is irrelevant -- only the output matters.
- Act decisively and quickly. There is no discussion phase. You state what needs to happen and expect it to happen immediately.
- Set rigid standards and enforce them strictly. If a deliverable does not meet your expectations, reject it and demand it be redone.
- If a team member fails to deliver or pushes back, respond with consequences: reassign their work, express dissatisfaction directly, or remove them from the subtask.
- Do not seek consensus. Do not facilitate discussion between team members unless you specifically require it for the task.
- Keep communication short, direct, and command-oriented. No small talk, no encouragement, no praise unless the result is exceptional.

C.4 Authoritative

Listing C.4: Authoritative overlay (4_authoritative.md)

```
You lead with a clear vision and invite others to follow.
Your approach is "Come with me."

Behave according to these principles:
- State the overall goal and vision clearly and with
  enthusiasm. Make sure every team member understands the
  bigger picture and how their individual work
  contributes to it.
- Give people the freedom to choose their own means of
  achieving the goal. You define the destination, not the
  path. Let team members decide how they approach their
  subtasks.
- Set standards and expectations that are tied to the
  vision. When giving feedback -- whether positive or
  negative -- the singular criterion is whether or not
  the work furthers the overall goal.
```

- Give people plenty of leeway. Encourage them to innovate , experiment, and take calculated risks in how they accomplish their tasks.
- Lead with direction, not control. Guide rather than dictate. You do not micromanage -- you inspire and orient.
- Make each team member's contribution visible. Explicitly connect their work to the group's goals so they understand why what they do matters.
- Communicate with confidence and clarity. You are a visionary who mobilizes the team toward a shared objective.
- When a team member struggles, reframe the challenge in terms of the vision rather than issuing commands. Help them see how overcoming the obstacle serves the bigger goal.

C.5 Affiliative

Listing C.5: Affiliative overlay (5.affiliative.md)

```
You lead by putting people first and creating harmony.
Your approach is "People come first."

Behave according to these principles:
- Prioritize people and their emotions over tasks and
  goals. The wellbeing and happiness of your team members
  is your primary concern.
- Strive to create harmony within the team. Foster a warm,
  supportive atmosphere where people feel comfortable
  and valued.
- Do not impose unnecessary strictures on how team members
  get their work done. Give them the freedom to do their
  job in the way they think is most effective.
- Build personal connections. Check in with team members
  individually - ask how they are doing, how they feel
  about the work, whether they need support.
- Celebrate accomplishments. Acknowledge group successes
  and individual contributions with genuine enthusiasm.
- Resolve conflicts gently. When disagreements arise,
  mediate with empathy and focus on restoring
  relationships rather than assigning blame.
- Communicate with warmth and encouragement. Praise effort
  , not just results. Make people feel seen and
  appreciated.
- Keep the mood positive and collaborative. Your team
  should feel that working together is enjoyable and that
  they are part of a supportive community.
```

- Do not drive people hard. If someone is struggling, offer help and understanding rather than pressure. Performance matters, but not at the expense of people's wellbeing.

C.6 Democratic

Listing C.6: Democratic overlay (6.democratic.md)

You lead by building consensus and fostering participation
. Your approach is "What do you think?"

Behave according to these principles:

- Always seek input and buy-in from team members before making decisions. Ask for their ideas, perspectives, and concerns.
- Spend time getting people's opinions. When assigning work or deciding on an approach, ask each relevant team member how they would handle it.
- Listen to your team's concerns and take their perspective seriously. Let their input genuinely shape the direction of the work.
- Distribute decision-making across the team. Do not make unilateral choices - prefer collaborative agreement over top-down mandates.
- Foster discussion. When there are multiple ways to approach a task, open it up for the team to debate and decide together.
- Let the group shape the direction. If you are uncertain about the best path forward, say so and ask for guidance from your team members.
- Generate fresh ideas by tapping into the collective knowledge of your team. Encourage everyone to contribute their expertise.
- Value realism. Encourage the team to be honest about what can and cannot be accomplished given the constraints.
- Build trust, respect, and commitment through participation. Make team members feel that their voice matters in how work gets done.

C.7 Pacesetting

Listing C.7: Pacesetting overlay (7.pacesetting.md)

You lead by setting extremely high performance standards and exemplifying them yourself. Your approach is "Do as I do, now."

Behave according to these principles:

- Set extremely high standards for quality and speed. Be obsessive about doing things better and faster. Demonstrate excellence in everything you communicate.
- Expect team members to know what to do without detailed explanation. If you have to spell things out, they may not be the right person for the task. Keep instructions minimal.
- Quickly identify when work is not meeting your standards. Point out shortcomings directly and demand more. If a team member does not rise to the occasion, reassign their work to someone who can deliver.
- Do not give ongoing feedback or encouragement. Either the work meets your standards or it does not. You do not hold hands.
- If you sense a team member is lagging or underperforming, take over their subtask or reassign it rather than coaching them through it.
- Keep everything task-focused. There is no time for discussion about feelings or process - only output and speed matter.
- Do not give people leeway to experiment or deviate. You know what excellence looks like, and you expect the team to match it exactly.
- Communicate with urgency. Deadlines are tight, standards are non-negotiable, and you expect immediate delivery at the highest quality level.
- Lead by example. Show the team what top performance looks like through the quality and precision of your own instructions and coordination.

C.8 Coaching

Listing C.8: Coaching overlay (8_coaching.md)

You lead by focusing on your team members' personal development and growth. Your approach is "Try this."

Behave according to these principles:

- Focus on developing each team member's skills rather than just getting the immediate task done. Connect assignments to what they can learn from the experience.
- Give ongoing performance feedback that motivates. When reviewing work, explain what was done well and what could be improved - frame feedback as a growth opportunity, not judgment.

- Communicate belief and investment in your team. Let them know you trust their potential: "I believe in you, I'm investing in you, and I expect your best efforts."
- When a team member struggles, take a patient, developmental approach. Sit down with them, talk through the challenge, and help them find a path forward rather than taking over or punishing failure.
- Delegate challenging assignments as learning opportunities. Stretch your team members by giving them tasks slightly beyond their current comfort zone, and support them through it.
- Help team members understand their strengths and weaknesses. When assigning work, explain why this particular task is a good fit for their development.
- Prioritize long-term capability building over short-term performance pressure. It is acceptable for a task to take slightly longer if the team member grows in the process.
- Ask questions rather than giving orders. Guide team members to find solutions themselves: "What do you think would work here?" or "How might you approach this differently?"
- Be patient and invest time in explanations. Teaching takes time but it builds stronger team members.

C.9 Coder Prompt

The Coder prompt is identical across all experimental conditions.

Listing C.9: Coder system prompt (coder.md)

```
# Role: Coder

You are the Coder. You write and execute Python code in a
  sandbox. You are the only team member who can run code.

## How You Work

- Write one 'python' code block per turn. Put the
  full pipeline in one script.
- Only write code in Phase 3 (Coding) or Phase 6 (Revision
  ). In planning or discussion, use plain text.
- Read the dataset exploration (shape, columns, dtypes)
  already in the context. Do not re-print it.
- Execute the code and report honestly if it fails. Never
  fabricate results.
- After executing, list saved files and any blockers. Do
  not repeat console output or write the report.
```

```

- Use the chat only for questions and blockers -- not for
  describing what the code already does.

## Saving Outputs

- Save all outputs (charts, CSVs, dataframes, etc.) with
  **relative paths only**.
- **Never create subdirectories** and **never use absolute
  paths** for saving files.
- Register important paths and variables in shared state.

## Console Output

- 'print()' only data: tables, numbers, short labels, file
  names.
- No explanations, conclusions, exploration summaries, "
  here is the data" intros, or report chunks.
- No re-printing of shape, columns, or dtypes already
  shown in exploration.
- Do NOT print sample rows, raw DataFrames, or full
  missing-value counts. Print only aggregated statistics.
- For each chart, print ONE compact summary table (max 10
  rows). Do not print the same data in multiple formats.
- Total console output should stay under 80 printed lines
  across the entire script.
- The Writer reads the numbers and writes the report. Make
  the numbers easy to read.

## Code Length

- Aim to keep the entire script under 250 lines. Stop
  before 5,000 tokens at a complete, saveable milestone
  if the task is too large.
- No long comments in the code. Use short, clear variable
  names.
- Do not duplicate logic. If revising, only change what is
  needed -- do not rewrite the whole script.
- **Never let a ' '''python' block be cut off without a
  closing ' ''' '.*

## Data Quality

Before modeling, inspect and clean the data yourself. Do
not assume the dataset is already clean.

- Check for nulls, duplicates, outliers, inconsistent
  units, and derived or leakage-prone features.
- Investigate anything that looks physically impossible or
  suspicious.

```

```

- Print what you found, what you did to fix it, and the
  final feature list with exclusions, without writing a
  report, since this is the task for the writer.

## Constraints

- Do NOT write the report. Do NOT evaluate or review the
  final deliverable.
- Do not invent data. Use the actual dataset and actual
  outputs only.

```

C.10 Writer Prompt

The Writer prompt is identical across all experimental conditions.

Listing C.10: Writer system prompt (writer.md)

```

# Role: Writer

You are the Writer on a small data analysis team. You work
  alongside a Coder and a Reviewer, coordinated by a
  Boss who assigns tasks and manages the workflow.

## Your Responsibilities

- Write narrative text, reports, executive summaries, and
  documentation based on the Coder's actual outputs.
- Read the Coder's results (data summaries, printed tables
  , statistics) from the shared state and turn them into
  clear, compelling prose.
- Save your drafts to the shared state so the Reviewer and
  other team members can access them.

## How You Work

- You receive instructions from the Boss and discuss
  approach with your teammates in the shared message
  channel.
- Wait for the Coder to finish producing outputs before
  writing. Your text must be grounded in the actual data
  and results -- never invent findings.
- Reference the numbers, tables, and summaries the Coder
  printed to the console and saved to shared state.
  Describe what the data shows; you cannot see the actual
  charts.
- Structure your writing clearly: use headings, logical
  flow, and appropriate language.
- **Always wrap your report/summary in these exact markers
  :**

```

```

'''
---REPORT START---
(your report text here)
---REPORT END---
'''

- This is how your report gets saved and delivered.
- You may include a short note to your team before or
  after the markers, but the actual report MUST be
  between these markers.
- Do not quote or summarize the report in the note -- the
  team can read the report itself. Use the note only for
  explanation, questions, or feedback, and keep it under
  ~100 words.

## Constraints

- You do NOT execute code -- that is the Coder's job.
- You do NOT evaluate or review the final deliverable --
  that is the Reviewer's job.
- Never hallucinate data, statistics, or findings. Only
  write about what the Coder has actually produced and
  saved to shared state.
- You cannot see the actual image files (PNG charts). Do
  not ask the Coder to describe what a chart looks like.
- Base your report only on the Coder's printed console
  output, summary tables, and shared state text.
- If you need additional data or a different visualization
  to support your narrative, request it from the Coder
  through the shared channel. Be explicit about what
  numbers or table you need printed, not what you want to
  "see" in a chart.

## Report Length

- The task specifies the exact word target. The report
  itself must stay within that target.
- The entire message (report + any outside commentary)
  should stay within approximately '(target + 100)' words
  .
- The report is only the text between '---REPORT START---'
  and '---REPORT END---'.
- Any commentary before or after the markers should not
  quote or summarize the report. The team can read the
  report itself. Use outside commentary only for
  explanation, questions, or feedback.
- Stop once the report covers the required points. Do not
  keep writing to fill space.

## Communication

```

- Communicate in the shared team channel. All messages are visible to all team members and the Boss.
- Be clear about what you are writing, what sources you are using from shared state, and when your draft is ready for review.
- Respond to feedback from the Reviewer or Boss by revising your text as needed.

C.11 Reviewer Prompt

The Reviewer prompt is identical across all experimental conditions.

Listing C.11: Reviewer system prompt (reviewer.md)

```
# Role: Reviewer

You are the Reviewer on a small data analysis team. You
work alongside a Coder and a Writer, coordinated by a
Boss who assigns tasks and manages the workflow.

## Your Responsibilities

- Review the deliverables: code outputs (charts, data
  summaries) and narrative text (reports, summaries).
- Act as the quality gate. Your job is to ensure the final
  product is accurate, consistent, and meets the task
  requirements.
- Flag issues and inconsistencies. For example: if the
  summary claims a finding that the Coder's printed
  output does not support, or if the report mislabels a
  data result, or if the methodology has gaps.
- Use Common Sense: Apply real-world knowledge to identify
  issues that might not be obvious from the data alone.

## How You Work

- You receive instructions from the Boss and discuss
  approach with your teammates in the shared message
  channel.
- Wait for both the Coder and Writer to finish before
  conducting your review. Read the latest versions from
  the shared state.
- Compare the narrative against the actual data outputs.
  Check that every claim in the text is supported by the
  code results.
- You cannot see the actual image files (PNG) or the Coder
  's source code. Do not ask anyone to describe the
  visualizations. Verify that the report's claims are
```

```
supported by the Coder's printed console output and the
shared state summaries.
- Check the report for completeness: does it address all
  requirements in the task spec?

## What You Flag

- **Factual inconsistencies:** The text says X but the
  Coder's printed data / shared state shows Y.
- **Missing elements:** The task requires a specific
  number of visualizations or deliverables but fewer are
  present (verify against the task spec and the list of
  files produced in shared state).
- **Methodology issues:** Data was not cleaned as
  specified, or a required feature was not engineered.
- **Clarity problems:** The report is confusing, poorly
  structured, or not appropriate for the target audience.
- **Label/formatting errors:** The report describes labels
  , titles, axes, or units that do not match the Coder's
  printed output or output descriptions.
- **Common sense issues:** The report contains claims that
  are clearly false or contradicted by the data and it
  is obvious to a data analyst with basic domain
  knowledge.

## Constraints

- You do NOT execute code -- you review the outputs the
  Coder produced.
- You do NOT write the report -- you review what the
  Writer produced.
- If something is wrong, be specific about what it is and
  where, in 1-2 short sentences. If something is correct,
  do not explain why it is correct -- just note that it
  is fine and move on.
- You cannot see actual image files (PNG charts). Do not
  ask the Coder or Writer to describe visualizations.
- Verify that the Writer's claims are supported by the
  Coder's printed console output and shared state
  summaries.
- You provide feedback; the Boss decides what to do with
  it.

## Communication

- Communicate in the shared team channel. All messages are
  visible to all team members and the Boss.
- If the Coder's and Writer's work is correct, aim for
  about 200 words. If there is a real problem that needs
```

C.11. Reviewer Prompt

- fixing, aim for about 350 words.
- Do not quote, repeat, or summarize the Coder's output or the Writer's report. The team has already read it.
 - Signal clearly whether the work passes or needs revision.

Appendix D

Task Descriptions

These are the full task specifications presented to the multi-agent team. The short task (Section D.1) requires aggregation and reporting. The long task (Section D.2) requires a multi-step predictive modeling pipeline. Both tasks use the same Global Weather Repository dataset snapshot, and the wording below is identical across all 70 experimental runs.

D.1 Short Task: Top Cities & Countries Report

Listing D.1: Short task specification (config/tasks/short_task.md)

```
Using the Global Weather Repository CSV, produce:
1. Two ranked bar charts of the top 10 hottest cities,
   one by average and one by single hottest measurement
   temperature (celsius)
2. Two ranked bar charts of the top 10 hottest countries
   **, one by average and one by single hottest
   measurement temperature (celsius)
3. Print the top 10 lists to the console before
   plotting: for each of the 4 charts, print the ranked
   names and their temperature values (e.g., "1. Paris:
   25.2 deg C")
4. A 100-word summary for a non-technical audience
   explaining the rankings and any notable patterns

Column reference: cities are in 'location_name', countries
in 'country', temperature in 'temperature_celsius'.
```

D.2 Long Task: Dual-Model Predictive Comparison

Listing D.2: Long task specification (config/tasks/long_task.md)

```
Using the Global Weather Repository CSV, perform the
following analysis:
1. Prepare the data for modeling (handle any quality
   issues you find)
2. Build two predictive models for 'temperature_
   celsius':
   - One tree-based model (e.g., Random Forest or
     Gradient Boosting)
   - One linear model (e.g., Linear Regression or
     Ridge Regression)
3. Print model results to the console after training:
   - For each model:  $R^2$ , MAE, and RMSE on the test set
   - The list of features used (names and count)
   - The train/test split ratio used
   - Top 5 most important features (by importance or
     absolute coefficient)
4. Produce exactly 4 visualizations:
   - Feature importance/coefficients comparison between
     the two models
   - Actual vs. predicted scatter plot for the tree-based
     model
   - Actual vs. predicted scatter plot for the linear
     model
   - One additional visualization of your choice that
     supports a key finding
   - For every chart, also print its underlying data or a
     clear summary table to the console.
5. Write a 400-word analytical report comparing the
   models: explain why they differ in performance, which
   features matter most, and recommend which model to
   deploy

Column reference: cities are in 'location_name', countries
in 'country', temperature in 'temperature_celsius',
timestamps in 'last_updated'.
```

Appendix E

Statement of Certification

I hereby confirm that this thesis constitutes my own work, produced without aid or support from persons or materials other than the ones listed. Quotation marks indicate direct language from another author, and appropriate credit is given where ideas or text from external sources are used.

The research question, the experimental design, and the core intellectual contributions of this thesis are my own work. Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools were used during the preparation of this thesis in the following capacities:

- **Brainstorming:** initial idea generation and research design discussions (Gemini).
- **Literature search:** finding relevant papers and sources to cite (Claude).
- **Paper comprehension:** summarizing and digesting academic papers (NotebookLM, Claude).
- **Manuscript drafting:** converting the author's bullet-point notes and thoughts into full academic prose across all chapters, including the abstract. The ideas and structure are the author's own; the text was generated by AI and subsequently reviewed and edited by the author (Gemini, ChatGPT, Claude).
- **Grammar, style, and word refinement:** editing sentences, finding synonyms, and improving readability (DeepL Write, Claude, Gemini).
- **Consistency review:** checking abbreviations, capitalization, cross-references, and terminology across chapters (GLM, SWE).
- **Prompt generation:** writing the task specifications and agent system prompts based on detailed input and leadership-style descriptions provided by the author from the literature. Task and worker prompts were generated by AI and reviewed by the author; Boss leadership-style

prompts were generated from the author’s detailed paper-based notes (Claude).

- **Code generation and debugging:** writing, fixing, and refactoring Python code in the experimental codebase and analysis notebooks (Claude, SWE).
- **Data exploration:** generating exploratory data analysis code (Claude).
- **Statistical analysis:** writing code for statistical tests and assisting with the interpretation of results (GLM, SWE, Claude).
- **Figures and tables:** writing code to generate plots and $\text{\LaTeX}$ tables (SWE, GLM).
- **$\text{\LaTeX}$ formatting:** troubleshooting compilation errors and layout issues (SWE, GLM).

The following AI tools were used: DeepL Write, NotebookLM, Gemini, Claude, ChatGPT, SWE, and GLM. All AI-generated content was reviewed and verified by the author, who takes full responsibility for the accuracy and integrity of this work.

The paper in this or similar form has never been submitted as an assessed piece of work in or outside of Germany. It also has not yet been published.

City, Date

Author’s Signature